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PART 1:

BEFORE THE VANISHING

In the age before Earthfall, fortunes were forged by vast empires like Azlant and Thassilon. Yet other empires existed in these times as well—empires ruled not by humans but by creatures of legend. The cyclopes ruled two such empires, notably one in Garund and another in northwestern Casmaron. As with their contemporaries, time brought an end to their rule.

Yet while the cyclops empires crumbled, they have not vanished from Golarion altogether. Pockets of them exist today, although they possess but a shadow of their former glory. Only in remote locations does evidence of ancient cyclops empires still exist. One such remnant lies deep in the Tors of Levenies in the form of the cyclops lich Vordakai, once a notorious tyrant and powerful necromancer in Casmaron long ago. Vordakai himself did not survive the uprising and turmoil that followed Earthfall during the Age of Darkness, yet ironically his name did. The least of his apprentices appropriated his master's name in the hope of using its power to rebuild an empire. Yet in the end, this task would require more than notoriety. This new Vordakai became the last when those he was attempting to command rose up against him and, in an ironic turn of events, trapped him in a tomb of his own design, hidden away at the westernmost edge of Casmaron in a minor mountain range often overlooked by explorers and adventurers.

As the ages wore on and Vordakai's torpor changed into an ageless slumber, his name lived on in the legends of the region's Nomen centaurs, who took up

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a tradition of standing vigil over the approach to his tomb, ready to act upon any sign of his return. But when Taldor's militaristic expansion into the Stolen Lands drove the Nomen centaurs east into Iobaria, the approach to Vordakai's tomb was left unguarded. When Nomen refugees returned generations later after Taldor abandoned the Stolen Lands, the tales of Vordakai had largely been forgotten.

This status quo has remained over the intervening years—until now, that is. When the swordlords of Restov sent agents south into the Stolen Lands, a new colony—Varnhold—was established at the edge of the old centaur rangelands, and along with these settlers came an ambitious treasure hunter named Willas Gundarson. Using Varnhold as a base of operations and following an ancient map copied from an even more ancient tablet recovered from deep Casmaron, Willas hoped to find a previously undiscovered hoard of treasure. Unfortunately for Willas, he mistranslated the ancient tablet, and what he had assumed was an indication of vast magical wealth was actually a warning of vast magical danger.



MAEGAR VARN

Armed with his mistranslated lore, Willas ranged far and wide while Varnhold was being established, operating under the guise of a scout determining the lay of the land and identifying any potential threats facing the fledgling settlement. It was on one of these journeys that he discovered Vordakai's Tomb and crossed the deep waters of the Little Sellen on a *swan boat feather token*. On the island, he located wards designed to prevent intrusion and grasped something of their dire nature. He was about to turn back when he glimpsed a cache of treasure just a short way down the corridor leading into the tomb. Greed overcame his common sense, and he crept inside to investigate—but as he did, he felt the ancient warding alarms go off. Pausing only to snatch a single jade bracelet, Willas fled the tomb and retreated back across the river.

Willas knew he'd triggered the guardian wards but managed to creep back out of the ruined complex without triggering any others. He then returned to Varnhold with the bracelet. Along the way, he worked up a story about how he found the jade bracelet on the shore of a riverbank, hoping to cover up his momentary lack of judgment. Unfortunately, Willas's fears were well founded, for the triggering of the wards woke Vordakai from his ageless slumber, and in so doing, the treasure hunter had doomed Varnhold.

VISITING VARNHOLD

The town of Varnhold is established early during this campaign, with its founder, Maegar Varn, claiming the site for the settlement some time before the PCs defeat the Stag Lord and begin their own kingdom.

While the exact timing of this is left to you as the GM to determine, Varnhold should be founded at about the point the PCs reach 3rd level. The village vanishes at some point while the PCs are 7th level, likely while they're handling the events of the previous chapter.

As a result, there's a window of time wherein the PCs could visit Varnhold. If the PCs made a particularly favorable impression on Varnhold's founder during Chapter 1 of *Kingmaker*, Maegar Varn invites them to pay a visit to Varnhold once the PCs get their own kingdom up and running. Diplomatic relations with Varnhold can help out a fledgling kingdom, and a visit to the settlement can give the PCs an additional emotional tie to the location when they learn of the settlement's eventual doom.

If the PCs do receive a letter of invitation to visit Varnhold, that letter comes with a shipment of resources—a gift from an already prosperous neighbor that grants the PCs 2 bonus Resource Dice at the start of their next Kingdom turn.

VARNHOLD — SETTLEMENT 5

NG TOWN

Bustling but doomed settlement

Government Lord Mayor (appointed)

Population 149 (95 humans, 11 halflings, 10 gnomes, 8 half-orcs, 8 dwarves, 6 half-elves, 4 elves, 7 other)

Languages Common, Hallit

Religion Erastil

Threats spriggans, Vordakai's plot

Frontier Town Varnhold is located on a remote frontier. As a result, trade is lacking–treat Varnhold as a 3rd-level settlement for the purposes of buying equipment.

Caspar Morgarion (LG male human cleric of Erastil 6) Town priest and counselor of Varnhold

Cephal Lorentus (NG male human wizard 7) Emissary of Varnhold

Edina and Jolia Aldori (LN female human fighters 7) General and warden of Varnhold

Maegar Varn (NG male human swordlord 8) Lord Mayor of Varnhold

Willas Gundarson (CG male human ranger 7) Ambitious explorer and treasure hunter

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PART 2:

THE VANISHED VILLAGE

After Willas Gunderson woke Vordakai from his slumber, the undead wizard swiftly realized that thousands of years had passed. Faced with a new world of wonder, the cyclops lich dispatched minions to explore and bring back word of how things had changed. Vordakai became particularly obsessed with the audacious human who had freed him, and upon noticing the theft of the jade bracelet, set about tracking the thief back to the settlement of Varnhold. Unleashing ancient cyclops magic, Vordakai emptied the settlement of its inhabitants in a single night of horror. Now, Vordakai studies the lore he has learned from Varnhold's vanishing and draws his plans to establish a new empire. With his kin gone from the region, the undead cyclops is confident that this time, his will be a lasting rule.

JAMANDI'S MESSAGE

When Vordakai steals away the people of Varnhold, it's not long before Rostland takes note. Lady Jamandi Aldori first learns of the vanishing of Varnhold when two of her distant cousins, Edina and Jolia Aldori, arrive at her manor with disturbing news: they found their village abandoned after they returned from a long hunting trip. If the Aldori sisters perished already in Chapter 5, Lady Jamandi hears the news from elsewhere.

The news comes at an awkward time for Lady Jamandi, as the political climate in Restov has become dangerously tense. With Rostland's perceived interest in the Stolen Lands being interpreted by northern Brevoy as evidence they're seeking to increase their

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holdings in preparation for a potential civil war, Restov's government is increasingly forced to disavow any contact or alliance with its agents to the south. Should it come to civil war, Rostland cannot afford to be distracted by events in the Stolen Lands.

All of this puts Jamandi in a tough situation—she wants desperately to learn what has become of Varnhold but cannot act directly without triggering a conflict, nor can she send her cousins back south since she wants Edina and Jolia to remain close at hand in case they're needed to aid in Rostland's defense. Since the PCs hold the closest colony to Varnhold, Lady Jamandi reaches out to ask them to investigate. Her request arrives via courier when you are ready to have the PCs begin this part of the adventure; the message is presented on the next page as **Handout 6–1**.

FATE OF VARNHOLD

80 XP

The PCs must travel to Varnhold, discover what happened to its vanished citizens, and take steps to ensure such a mass disappearance will not happen again.

Source: Jamandi Aldori (at your discretion, the PCs could learn of the vanishing via another source—perhaps even from their own citizens if they've established diplomatic relations with Varnhold).

Completion: Slay Vordakai and release as many imprisoned villagers as possible from captivity in the lich's dungeon of souls (area **F5**).

Reward: With Vordakai's defeat and the captured villagers released from the dungeon of souls, the citizens of Varnhold eagerly ask to join the PCs' kingdom; see page 285 for details.

THE VARNHOLD DOOM

When Willas Gunderson came to Varnhold, he had visions of treasure in his mind, for he had an ancient map claiming to lead to a long-forgotten crypt southwest of town. Yet when Willas found the site promised on his map, he gained naught but a single jade bracelet before waking an ancient evil.

Maegar Varn took interest in the jade treasure, but like Willas, he mistook the giant-sized ring for a bracelet and tentatively identified its markings as associated with Nomen centaurs. Believing the "bracelet" to be an artifact of that culture, he sent word to an old colleague from Oppara—Ervil Pendrod, a scholar specializing in Iobarian antiquities. Maestro Pendrod is also a composer, and as he was in the beginning stages of composing an epic opera dedicated to the history of the Iobarian steppes, he gleefully accepted word of the artifact as evidence of a link between Nomen centaurs and those of ancient Iobaria. He set out for Varnhold to study this magnificent find.

KINGDOM IN THE BACKGROUND

After the events of "Cult of the Bloom," the citizens of the kingdom are shaken but thankful for the PCs' actions in defeating the curse. The size of the kingdom doesn't expand much during this chapter, as its people are focused on recovering from recent events. When news of the Varnhold vanishing occurs, the PCs' kingdom grows even more timid about expanding its borders, and it isn't until Vordakai is defeated and the next chapter begins that expansion returns to normal.

Yet Maestro Pendrod was not the only individual interested in the "bracelet," for with its theft, Vordakai awoke. Using his powers to recover the ring and discover the location of the thief, the lich located both in Varnhold. Vordakai emerged from his crypt for the first time in thousands of years and made his way toward the village. One still evening soon thereafter, he used a potent artifact known as the *Oculus of Abaddon* to create a haunting beckon from a hillock at the edge of town. The magic called forth all of the townsfolk in a daze. By drawing upon ancient reserves of magic, Vordakai captured each villager's soul and stored them within his crypt as a source of information to educate himself about the new world he finds himself in.

THE WATCHER — TRIVIAL 8

Vordakai left his familiar, the raven Horagnamon, to spy on Varnhold and the surrounding lands. For several hours a day, Vordakai explores the world by watching through Horagnamon's eyes. At some point during the adventure, Horagnamon notices the PCs and swoops low to watch, following with interest as



HORAGNAMON

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Greetings from Restov and congratulations on your triumphs. I hope that we are entering a time in which these lands will be called "stolen" only in history texts. Yet it seems that for all your victories, your fellow settlers to the east have met with trouble. The people of Varnhold have, according to eyewitness accounts, vanished!

As the political climate here in Restov grows more turbulent, we find ourselves increasingly limited in the amount of aid we can send. Certainly, we cannot send troops south to investigate without our overly watchful "allies" to the north misinterpreting the act. And so it falls to you, I fear, to investigate the mystery behind Varnhold's vanishing, whether it is the Nomen centaurs or another threat. If something dire has befallen the town, you must realize that your own could be next!

Trusting in your discretion and expedience,
Jamandi Aldori, Swordlord of Restov

HANDOUT 6-1

Vordakai observes the PCs through the raven's eyes. Horagnamon is careful to remain more than 100 feet away from the PCs to avoid arousing suspicion, but as the adventure goes on, you should let the PCs know that they have a strange feeling, as if they're being watched. Once per day, allow the PCs to attempt a DC 30 Perception check or a DC 25 Nature check to note that one raven in particular seems to be following and watching them intently.

If confronted, Horagnamon flees to the southwest, seeking to avoid all combat if possible. If the PCs manage to capture and interrogate the raven, he begs to be released. If the PCs don't comply within a round, Vordakai uses his link to the familiar to destroy it by activating Horagnamon's Death Throes.

HORAGNAMON CREATURE 8

UNIQUE NE TINY ANIMAL MINION

Male raven familiar

Perception +18; low-light vision

Languages Cyclops, Daemonic, Jotun, Necril

Skills Acrobatics +18, Stealth +18, Thievery +18

Str –3, **Dex** +6, **Con** +3, **Int** +0, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +0

Cunning Horagnamon can use simple items as tools, such as poking a stick at an opening to tease out a piece of food. He's also quite adept at stealing objects. He can't use Thievery to Palm an Object, Disable a Device, or Pick a Lock, but he can use Thievery to Steal light objects that he can carry in his beak or talons or to accomplish other relatively simple tasks.

AC 28; **Fort** +13, **Ref** +20, **Will** +16

HP 100

Death Throes ↷ (death, necromancy, occult) **Trigger** Horagnamon takes any damage or suffers a condition while Vordakai is using Familiar Farsight; **Effect** Horagnamon dies, then bursts into a 30-foot-diameter burst of feathers and seething black tendrils of smoke and energy. All creatures in this area must attempt a DC 23 Fortitude save.

Critical Success The creature takes no damage.

Success The creature takes 3d10 negative damage.

Failure The creature takes 6d10 negative damage and becomes drained 1.

Critical Failure The creature takes 12d10 negative damage and becomes drained 2.

Speed 10 feet, fly 40 feet

Melee ❖ beak +20 (finesse), **Damage** 1d6 piercing

VARNHOLD FEATURES

Most of Varnhold's buildings have stone foundations and wooden walls. Their windows bear shutters and are unglazed unless otherwise noted, and their roofs are uniformly wooden shakes. The town is constructed around a ford of the Kiravoy River, next to a low, flat-topped hill. Atop this hill stands the hewn-log stockade and blockhouse built for the colony's defense—the seat of Varnhold's lord mayor, Maegar Varn.

As the PCs explore the town, impress upon them the eerie nature of the abandoned settlement—and that what happened here could happen at home!

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A1. HOG KEEPER'S FARM LOW 8

This structure, though fairly new, is poorly built. The clapboard walls have large gaps, and its roof sags alarmingly. The smell of decay and filth emanating from this dwelling is horrendous. Behind the cottage is a mud-filled enclosure and a covered shed.

This building was the home of a hog keeper who hunted the surrounding hills for wild boars, some of which he attempted to domesticate. The hog keeper was a vile man of questionable hygiene and habit, ill-liked by his neighbors. His home is a shambles simply because of his personal habits.

Creatures: The rotten, half-eaten corpses of a number of hogs lie scattered around the muddy pigpen, covered in clouds of fat black flies. One wall of the pen has collapsed, allowing (in an ironic turn of events) a group of four daeodons to enter and feed on the bodies. If these oversized boars notice the PCs, they immediately charge to attack, although the first daeodon has to take an action to smash through the poorly built split-rail fence as it does so.

ELITE DAEODONS (4) CREATURE 5

Pathfinder Bestiary 6, 43
Initiative Perception +14

A2. FARMHOUSES

All of these homes show signs of having been derelict for several weeks, though each appears to have been abandoned in the midst of normal activities.

A3. HIDES FROM RIDES

The stench of a tannery wafts from this modest building. An outhouse stands across the yard.

The village tanner, an unpleasant man who lived alone, dwelt and worked here. Out back is a fenced enclosure with what appear to be three horse hides stretched upon it. A PC who succeeds at a DC 15 Nature check to Recall Knowledge recognizes them as being strangely incomplete above the withers, while a critical success confirms the disturbing truth: these are actually centaur hides missing the humanoid portion.

A4. DELVER'S BREWERY

This building partially overhangs the riverbank. A wagon sits at the loading dock with a pair of barrels on its bed. A sign above the front entrance shows a barrel and a smiling dwarf.

This small brewery established Varnhold's own beer brand: Cheerful Delver Stout. The wagon and loading dock hold sealed barrels of the stout—still good—and another dozen barrels of the completed product are inside the building. The spriggans who have invaded the town have not yet searched this structure due to the presence of the hungry chuuls at the ford.

Treasure: The stout is of decent quality, though lacking refinement, and the 15 barrels could be sold for 7 gp each. A PC who succeeds at a DC 25 Perception check notices a loose floorboard beneath one of the brewing vats; underneath is a lockbox (requiring a successful DC 25 Thievery check to Pick the Lock) that holds 115 sp and the recipe for Cheerful Delver Stout (worth 50 gp to the right buyer).

A5. KIRAVOY FORD LOW 7

The ground slopes steeply downward to the riverbank where the river runs wide and shallow, though it's muddy with the runoff of recent rains to the south.

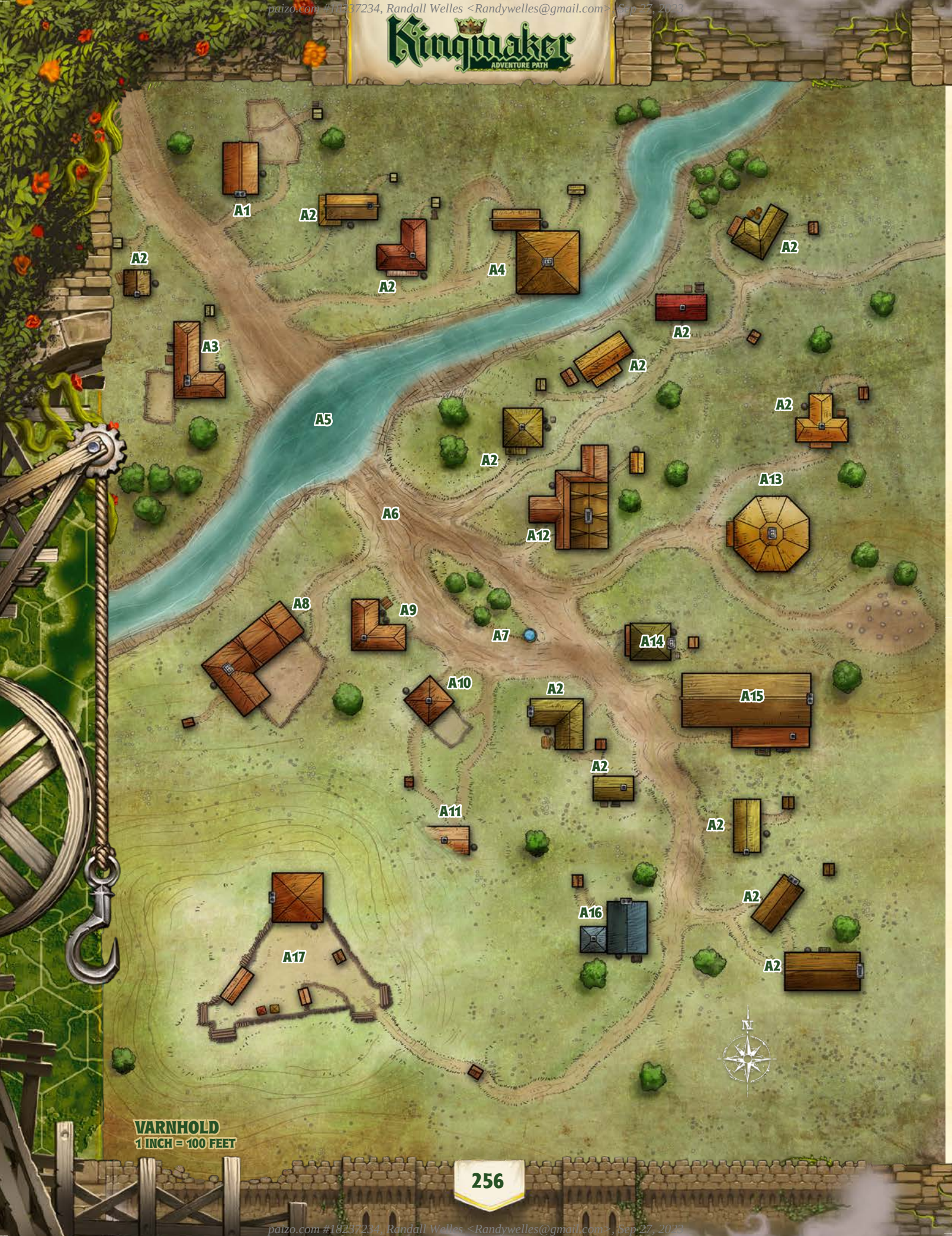
The Kiravoy River is shallow here, only 4 feet deep at the center. To the east, the riverbed drops into a



DAEODON

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VARNHOLD
1 INCH = 100 FEET

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20-foot-deep pool— anyone using the ford who strays too far in this direction could unexpectedly end up underwater. A PC who succeeds at a DC 20 Perception check while searching the pool's depths can find a 5-foot-wide tunnel that leads south—this flooded tunnel connects to the well in area **B10**.

Creatures: Two chuuls that were displaced from the pool when Maegar Varn and his mercenaries drove them out have returned to their old home from upriver. They have caught and eaten several of the spriggans, and the surviving spriggans now avoid the ford. The chuuls are currently content to ignore the remaining spriggans if they leave them alone, but hunger may eventually force them to become more aggressive.

CHUULS (2) CREATURE 7

Pathfinder Bestiary 64
Initiative Perception +15

A6. TRAPPED ROADWAY TRIVIAL 8

The spriggans placed three funnel-shaped, spike-lined pits here and obscured them with cloth sheets and dirt. A character who enters this area stumbles into one of the three traps. Once a character falls into a pit, they can Climb out by succeeding at a DC 15 Athletics check.

CAMOUFLAGED SPIKED PITS (3) HAZARD 8

MECHANICAL | TRAP

Stealth DC 31 (expert)
Description A 20-foot deep, funnel-shaped pit with dozens of wooden spikes lining its walls.
Disable Yanking the cloth away is a simple way to expose the danger to allow someone to merely avoid it by walking around its edges, but it cannot be quickly disabled.
Spiked Pitfall ↷ **Trigger** A creature walks onto one of the pits; **Effect** The triggering creature falls and rolls through several spikes as it slides to the bottom. This inflicts 5 bludgeoning damage from the fall itself down the steep slope (the falling PC can't attempt to Grab an Edge due to the lack of defined edges to the pit's walls), but the falling PC must also attempt a DC 26 Reflex save.
Critical Success The character avoids all of the spikes and takes no additional damage.
Success The character takes 2d10+11 piercing damage from the spikes.
Failure The character takes 4d10+22 piercing damage from the spikes.
Critical Failure The character takes 4d10+22 piercing damage from the spikes plus 2d6 bleed damage. While the character is taking this bleed damage, they are also sickened 2 from the pain.
Reset Creatures can still fall into the trap once it has been exposed, but the camouflaged cover must be reset manually for the trap to become hidden again.

A7. TOWN COMMONS

A greensward occupies the center of town. A few trees grow around an unoccupied pillory, and a well has been dug at the southern end. Although the 20-foot-deep well once held good drinking water, it currently contains the decaying body of a naked spriggan, the victim of a prank gone too far. The spriggans avoid the well now.

A8. THE HORSE AND HAMMER LOW 8

This long, low building partially surrounds a yard encompassed by a sturdy fence. A sign above a wide, barn-like entrance shows a harness for a horse and a blacksmith's anvil. Despite the abandonment of the village, it appears that many mounts and a great deal of livestock were left behind, trapped in the livery and yard. A half-dozen horse carcasses, decomposing and partially eaten by the crows that continue to pick at them, lie sprawled in the yard.

When Vordakai led the villagers away, the animals kept here were left trapped within and ultimately died of thirst. Their bodies have been serving as food for the crows for some time now. A character who looks into the yard of dead livestock can try to succeed at a DC 15 Perception check to notice that one dead horse in the center of the yard wears particularly expensive-looking tack.

Creatures: Because of the large number of animal carcasses lying here and the easy access to the yard and the stable itself by means of the hayloft doors, a huge number of scavenging crows have been attracted to this place to feed upon the remains. This murder of crows is particularly dangerous due to the huge number of ill-tempered birds in the swarm, but as long as the PCs don't attempt to enter the building or its yard, the crows leave them alone.

MURDER OF CROWS CREATURE 9

RARE | N | LARGE | ANIMAL | SWARM

Variant raven swarm (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 221)
Perception +19; low-light vision
Skills Acrobatics +19, Thievery +19
Str +0, **Dex** +6, **Con** +4, **Int** –4, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +0
AC 27; **Fort** +7, **Ref** +12, **Will** +9
HP 150; **Immunities** precision, swarm mind; **Weaknesses** area damage 10, splash damage 10; **Resistances** bludgeoning 5, piercing 10, slashing 10
Speed 10 feet, fly 40 feet
Enraged Cunning A murder of crows can get past most barriers to hound their prey. Simple latches, unsecured chimney flues, loosely shuttered windows, and similar obstacles rarely keep a murder away. A murder of crows automatically bypasses many of these simple

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obstructions and can attempt a DC 25 Thievery check to get through more complex obstructions (such as closed windows or simple barricades).

Swarming Beaks ❖ The crows' angry pecking deals 2d8 piercing damage to each enemy in the swarm's space (DC 28 basic Reflex save). A creature that critically fails its save is blinded for 1d6 rounds as the crows focus their attacks on the target's vulnerable face.

Treasure: The dead horse wearing the expensive tack belonged to Maestro Pendrod. The tack is worth 50 gp, and when outfitted on a horse, grants a +1 item bonus to the rider's checks to Command the Animal. While Pendrod's name doesn't appear on the tack, a PC who succeeds at a DC 20 Society check to Recall Knowledge confirms that the style of the tack suggests Taldor's aristocracy. A critical success narrows that to the city of Oppara in particular.

A9. CLOAKS FOR FOLKS

This modest cottage is neatly kept and has curtains hanging askew in its windows.

This house served as the workshop for the village tailor, as evidenced by the torn cloth and mangled tools within. It has been thoroughly looted by the spriggans.

A10. POTTER'S HOME

Unlike the other houses in town, the front door of this one has been broken down. A small yard adjoining the house and surrounded by a low picket fence holds the smashed remains of many clay vessels and statuettes.

This building served as the home of the village potter, who died several weeks ago of a fever. The spriggans had to break through the door to loot this building, and the entire floor is covered by a welter of smashed pottery fragments as a result.

Treasure: Though the spriggans took great delight in destroying the potter's wares, a PC who succeeds at a DC 20 Perception check locates a hidden panel. Nestled in a cushioning bed of straw is an elegant set of flagons and platters, hand-crafted and chased in platinum, that was intended as a wedding gift for King Noleski's eldest daughter next spring as indicated by a small placard. The set is worth 30 gp because of its fine craftsmanship.

A11. GUNDARSON'S HOUSE

This sod house has been dug into the base of the hill. Its heavy oaken door hangs askew.

This was the home of the Ulfen ranger Willas Gundarson—the man who awoke Vordakai and brought the cyclops lich's wrath down on the village. Like the other homes south of the Kiravoy, the spriggans have looted it.

Treasure: Lying among the debris strewn about by the spriggans' search of the house is a small wooden box about the size of a wizard's spellbook. Nearby is a book that has been torn in half at the spine. It's about three-quarters filled with handwriting in Skald. This is Willas's journal. It records his career as a ranger in the company of Maegar Varn and includes a description of several skirmishes that occurred between the Varnling Host and a tribe of "dangerous centaurs" who inhabit the hills east of Varnhold. The journal names the centaur tribe as Nomen. The last journal entry is dated approximately 2 weeks before the beginning of the chapter and relates a mundane scouting report of Varnhold Pass and concludes with a single sentence: "Found jade bracelet by the river." The remainder of that page has been torn away. The next page contains a single large rune inscribed in charcoal, which a PC who succeeds at a DC 25 Occultism or Society check to Recall Knowledge identifies as an archaic Ulfen symbol that is supposed to ward off bad luck.

While the diary is certainly of interest to the PCs, the nearby box is the true treasure. It contains a collection of *feather tokens* that the spriggans overlooked: an *anchor feather token*, three *bird feather tokens*, a *fan feather token*, four *holly bush feather tokens*, a *ladder feather token*, a *swan boat feather token*, and a *whip feather token*.

VARNHOLD'S TREASURE

80 XP

The PCs return the belongings of Varnhold's citizens.

Source: The PCs are not assigned this quest, technically, although if they rescue the surviving Varnhold citizens, the citizens ask for the return of their belongings.

Completion: The PCs shouldn't loot any of the treasure remaining in Varnhold (with the exception of the scrolls in the church of Erastil), but if they do, they must return the items (unless, in the case of consumable items, they've been used). In addition, the Varnhold treasure held by Agai, the spriggan leader, must be returned as well. At your discretion, the PCs can petition to keep certain items by securing deals with the original owners.

Reward: If the PCs make sure that the wealth of the villagers remains safe and is returned to them once the villagers are rescued, they start their next Kingdom turn with 3 Fame if their kingdom is famous; otherwise, they instead immediately gain 1d4+2 Unrest. In addition, the grateful townsfolk of Varnhold send additional support as thanks to the PCs' kingdom, and they start their next

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Kingdom turn with 4 bonus Resource Dice. In any event, in thanks for their rescue, the townsfolk ask the PCs to keep the scrolls from area **A13** as thanks.

A12. THE WATERHORSE

A two-story inn stands just off the village commons. A sign above the door depicts a rider clinging to the back of a madly galloping horse with a green mane and a fish's tail extending from its hindquarters. The inn's walls are painted a cheerful shade of yellow to complement the red shutters.

The Waterhorse was the center of social interaction in Varnhold on days other than Sundays (when the focus shifted to the church). The hostler, Miriam Kolescu, was of old Issian stock from a fishing village on the shore of the Lake of Mists and Veils. She brought many of her family's traditions and beliefs with her to Varnhold, though she was also a staunch loyalist to the Surtova crown. Her inn is simple but well kept. Its first floor consists of a common room (whose tables are set with rotting plates of food), a kitchen, a bathing chamber, and stores, along with a wing for the Kolescu family. The second floor consists of six guest rooms, all of which save one were unoccupied at the time the population vanished.

The inn's most recent patron was also its most famous. Ervil Pendrod had been staying at the inn for about a week before the vanishing. Maestro Pendrod hailed from Oppara's Kitharodian Academy. His studies into the indigenous peoples of ancient Iobaria brought him to Varnhold when Maegar Varn, a former student of his, sent word of Willas Gundarson's unusual find.

The first thing PCs notice upon approaching the front door of the inn is a single word hastily scratched into the wood of the front door in Common: "NOMEN." When the beckon of Vordakai summoned Maestro Pendrod along with the rest of the village, he finally realized the true source of the jade "bracelet" and used his last ounce of willpower to scratch this word with his dagger. He did so not as a warning, but in the hopes that those who came to investigate the vanishing would seek out the centaurs for more information about the cause of the event.

Ervil Pendrod established himself in a comfortable corner of the inn's common room, where he conducted his research on the "bracelet" and the surrounding region, entertained questions from the colonists, and gave impromptu lectures on his findings. He was in the midst of his research when Vordakai came, and the notes he left behind (see Treasure below) intrigued a spriggan who wandered into the tavern the day the Culcheks came to town. Unfortunately for the spriggan, they triggered a defensive ward Pendrod had placed on his collection; the spriggan's body lies dead on the ground, their arms, chest and face battered and shattered. A PC who succeeds at a DC 23 check to Identify Magic while investigating the notes and the body confirms that the spriggan was likely slain by a heightened *sound burst* stored in the notes via a *glyph of warding*.

Treasure: Maestro Pendrod's research materials remain on the table in the corner, somewhat scattered by the spriggan's ill-advised attempt to search them, but still readable. They include several books with titles such as *Iobarian Prehistory*, *Centaurs of Central Casmaron*, *The Untold Cost of the Taldan Armies of Exploration*, and the book that once bore Pendrod's *glyph of warding*: *Secrets of the Rashalka Mounds*. Among these works is an incomplete ethnography of the indigenous peoples of the Iobarian steppes—Pendrod was working on a section on the Rashalka centaurs and speculated that a local group known as Nomen is an offshoot of the greater Rashalka population who broke away and relocated to this area in the distant past. Mixed in with the books are a number of charcoal sketches of a heavy jade bracelet bearing peculiar markings that Maestro Pendrod has attributed to the premigration Nomen centaurs.

At the bottom of the stack sits a letter from Maegar Varn dated 2 months ago and addressed to Maestro Pendrod. This letter describes Willas's discovery of the jade bracelet on the banks of a "river of local provenance" and requests Pendrod's presence for further study of the artifact. The "bracelet" itself, however, is nowhere to be found.

A search of the inn's guest rooms reveals that only one of them was inhabited at the time of the vanishing. An investigation of the personal effects that remain indicate its occupant was Ervil Pendrod. Among the more mundane possessions in his travel trunk is a small library of further reference works. These tomes seem to be of less immediate relevance to his current project, but a PC who succeeds at a DC 25 Perception check locates a centuries-old geography book by one Carmyn e'Brothasa, chronicler of Taldor's Third Army of Exploration into the north. One passage is marked by Maestro Pendrod and reproduced as **Handout 6–2**. Pendrod's own handwriting in the margin of the text contains a simple but strange note: "Vordakai—sounds familiar—wish I had my full library to research..." The book frustratingly doesn't provide a location for the mythical island mentioned in the text, nor does it provide any further clues to Pendrod's cryptic margin note. The name "Vordakai" is a difficult one to recognize, but a successful DC 25 Arcana, Occultism, or Society check or a DC 20 Iobaria Lore check to Recall Knowledge allows a PC to recall it as the name of an ancient Iobarian

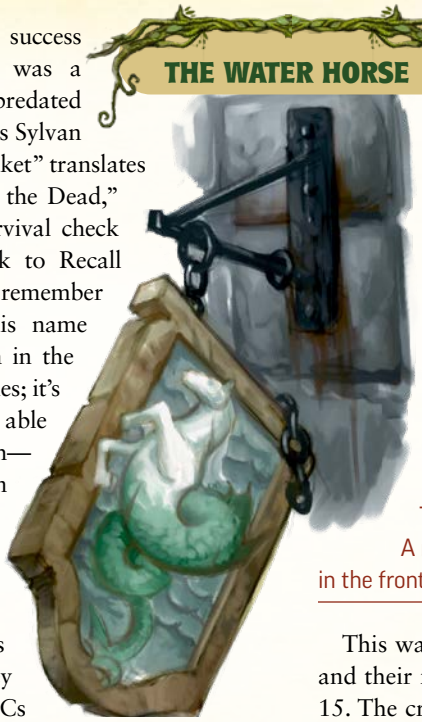
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necromancer. A critical success recalls also that Vordakai was a cyclops from an empire that predated Earthfall. Anyone who speaks Sylvan recognizes that "Olah-Kakanket" translates into Common as "Valley of the Dead," and a successful DC 33 Survival check or DC 31 Hills Lore check to Recall Knowledge is enough to remember that a location bearing this name lies somewhere to the south in the foothills of the Tors of Levenies; it's unlikely that the PCs will be able to achieve this success, though—they are more likely to learn this from the Nomen centaurs in Part 3.

Maestro Pendrod's collection of books could be sold to a bookdealer for as much as 50 gp, though they might question how the PCs came by books that bear the professor's own sigil as well as that of the Kitharodian Academy on the inside cover. The academy itself would pay a 75 gp reward for the return of all of Maestro Pendrod's books and papers. His finely crafted viola, a *lesser maestro's instrument* (recognizable as the work of the master craftsman Azores of Wispil), can be found in a case beneath his bed by a PC who succeeds at a DC 20 Perception check.

The inn's till holds 1 gp, 37 sp, and 52 cp.



A13. CHURCH OF ERASTIL

A small church stands here, its whitewashed walls and stained-glass windows gleaming in the sun. The bow symbol of Erastil shines like a beacon above the doors. Behind it on one side sits a neatly kept parsonage, and on the other side a low hill holds the beginnings of a small graveyard.

This small church of Erastil was established by Maegar Varn's companion, the cleric Caspar Morgarion. It served as the official church of Varnhold. The interior is simply furnished with wooden pews and a humble altar, and it has been thoroughly looted by the spriggans. The graveyard was established when the colony experienced its first casualties, who succumbed to the elements and dangerous wildlife. It holds a total of 14 wooden grave markers, the latest standing over a fairly fresh grave. That marker reads, "Andrisha the Potter" and is dated several weeks ago.

Treasure: The spriggans weren't completely efficient in looting the church; succeeding at a DC 25 Perception check reveals to a PC a hidden drawer in the altar that contains several scrolls the priest had stashed in case of emergencies: three *scrolls of heal* (3rd), three *scrolls of remove paralysis*, a *scroll of restoration* (6th), a *scroll of remove curse*, a *scroll of breath of life*, and a *scroll of raise dead*. Since the current situation in Varnhold certainly qualifies as an emergency, if the PCs claim and use these scrolls, they won't suffer any backlash from the villagers as a result.

A14. WEAVER'S HOME

This cottage has cheerful curtains in its windows. A number of wooden children's toys lie abandoned in the front yard.

This was the home of the colony's weaver, his wife, and their four children, who ranged in ages from 2 to 15. The cramped house is occupied by a loom as well as large reels of thread.

With a successful DC 15 Perception check, a PC discovers a half-starved calico cat hiding beneath the loom and watching the party warily. Success at either a DC 23 Nature check or a DC 18 Diplomacy check to use Wild Empathy is enough to coax the hungry cat out (using food to lure the cat grants a +4 item bonus to this check), at which point the PCs can attempt to communicate with it by magical means like *speak with animals*. The cat, whose name is Dragon, relates, "My feeders left me at the red-sun time when they heard the new birdsong. I was busy eating a bit of fish and did not follow them out. My feeders did not come back, and I am now quite hungry for some more fish!" A PC who succeeds at a DC 10 Nature check identifies the "red-sun time" as the evening and the "new birdsong" as some sort of music, perhaps, but can make no further headway with the animal's description.

A15. VARNHOLD GRANGE MODERATE 8

This barn has a wide door on the front and a smaller door on the side. The strong odor of barley and other grains wafts through the seams in the clapboard walls.

Creatures: The grange was never vermin-proof in the best of times, and since the vanishing, the foodstuffs here have become infested by thousands of horrific vermin, including three swarms of sportlebores. To the casual observer, these deadly creatures are indistinguishable from the dried fruits that they've infested. The three swarms swiftly move to attack anyone who enters the grange.

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SPORTLEBORE SWARMS (3) **CREATURE 7**

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 251

Initiative Stealth +17

A16. GLITTERWORKS

The wooden walls of this house have been staved in at several locations, and the door has been battered down.

This house served as the home and shop of the local gemcutter, his wife, and his hired guard. The spriggans who searched this house quickly discovered that it contained considerable wealth and literally demolished the interior to find any secret panels or hidden caches. Nothing of value remains here.

A17. STOCKADE AND BLOCKHOUSE

Perched atop a low hill, this triangular fortification looms over the town. A palisade of sharpened stakes leaves enough gaps for archers within to fire out upon the surrounding hillsides. The southern corners of the fort each have twin watch platforms, and the northern corner is anchored by a solid-looking blockhouse of sturdy timbers. A thin column of smoke drifts upward from a fire in the compound.

The 8-foot-tall stockade wall surrounding the blockhouse requires a PC to succeed at a DC 20 Athletics check to surmount it. Before clearing the top, a climber must succeed at a DC 20 Acrobatics check to avoid being impaled on the fire-hardened spikes for 1d6 piercing damage—remember, taking damage while climbing can result in a fall!

VARNHOLD BLOCKHOUSE

The stockade and blockhouse have been claimed by the Culchecks, a mob of 14 brutish spriggans who moved here from their previous cavern lair about a week ago after noticing the human village had been abandoned. While 13 of the Culcheck spriggans have the stats of a spriggan warlord (*Bestiary 2* 253), a powerful sadist named Agai is their leader.

If an alarm is sounded, the spriggans' first priority is to seal the blockhouse (areas **B8–B20**). The spriggan in area **B8** closes and bars the door and retreats to area **B9**, where she is joined by the spriggans from **B11**; together, they defend the door. One spriggan in area **B18** climbs to area **B20** and assumes Large form in order to throw rocks at intruders, while the other spriggan in **B18** becomes Large and holds the room. Agai and his two guards move from area **B15** to join the two spriggans already in area **B19** to station the murder holes and firing loops. Those spriggans trapped outside the blockhouse assume Large form and try to drive back the invaders.

And so it was, high upon the Torres and well above the Vale's Stairs, where rises from the high water a stony isle of dire report. Known as Vordakai's Island to those that do live thereabout, some legend of its name doth come down through the locals. For they speak of a guardian that doth destroy all who would set foot upon its accursed shores. They did name no fewer than a twelvecount of their hero-knights who had left their bones upon its rocky shores over the years after having tested their mettle against its dread warden, 'til none would any longer go there for fear of its hidden terror. And the name of this terror was given unto this Island.

HANDOUT 6–2

B1. GATEHOUSE

The gatehouse towers are composed of fifteen-foot-tall sharpened stakes. A ladder-accessible platform, ten feet above the ground, stands against the two walls. A number of helmets are barely visible over the edge of the wall.

Three sticks have been propped up on each of the platforms; helmets taken from the armory are balanced on them to give the appearance of guards standing watch. A PC who succeeds at a DC 20 Perception check sees through the ruse. The gate can be opened easily, as the spriggans destroyed its lock when they broke in.

B2. WEST GATETOWERS TRIVIAL 8

Creature: This area is similar to area **B1**, save for the lack of a gate. Instead of the fake guards set up at **B1**, an actual spriggan keeps guard here, peeping between the tips of the sharpened stakes with only his helmet visible over the top. If he sees anyone approach within 30 feet, he raises the alarm and then attacks.

SPRIGGAN WARLORD **CREATURE 7**

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 253

Initiative Perception +14

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B3. TOOL SHED — LOW 8

This area is surrounded by a split-rail fence, anchored at one end by a rough shed built from logs. The corral is empty save for a number of gnawed and picked bones.

The spriggans have eaten the livestock that was once kept here. Two male spriggans who are supposed to be on guard duty at area **B1** snuck into this tool shed to drink dry several barrels of ale they found stored here. As a result, they are currently sickened 3. If the alarm is raised, they wake and join the battle in 1d3 rounds.

SPRIGGAN WARLORDS (2) — CREATURE 7

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 252
Initiative Perception +11

B4. OUTHOUSES

These two rickety outhouses are mundane in every way, although the spriggans have been somewhat poor caretakers and cleaners.

B5. STOREHOUSE

This long, low building is composed of logs reinforced with a mixture of mud and mortar.

This building holds stores for the stockade. It contains a sizable store of dried fruits and vegetables, bags of grains, and assorted roots and tubers (all food not to the spriggans' tastes), along with a large number of tools and other supplies.

Resources: If the PCs claim the supplies here, they gain 1 bonus Resource Die at the start of the following Kingdom turn. Of course, if they use these resources before completing the Varnhold Treasure quest (page 258), they'll fail that quest, as these resources belong to the town.

B6. SMITHY

This small building has an open front, where a forge and anvil sit unused.

Varnhold's smith and weapons master Howitt Gurney once plied his trade here. The anvil could make an excellent thrown weapon for a Large spriggan (base damage 2d8 bludgeoning, range increment 10 feet).

B7. YARD — MODERATE 8

This yard is composed of churned mud and scraggly weeds. A well stands near the center, while not far away is a large bonfire with a spit holding a side of beef over it.

A spriggan watches this yard, along with a group of five giant wolverines.

SPRIGGAN WARLORD — CREATURE 7

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 252
Initiative Perception +14

GIANT WOLVERINES (5) — CREATURE 5

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 295
Initiative Perception +9

Hazard: The spriggans have set up a spiked pit in the yard near the main entrance to the blockhouse. The spriggans are careful to walk around the trapped area when they come and go from the structure.

CAMOUFLAGED SPIKED PIT — HAZARD 8

Page 257
Stealth 31 (expert)

B8. ENTRY — TRIVIAL 8

The entrance into the blockhouse is kept secured by a bar; success on a DC 25 Athletics check to Force Open the door can break it down. The spriggans come and go by speaking the passphrase "Glory to Agai" in Aklo to get the guard posted within to let them in; if the PCs scout the site out, it'll be just a matter of time before they observe this. They must successfully Lie to the guard within while using this phrase in Aklo to trick them into letting them in.

Creature: A spriggan warlord guards this room.

SPRIGGAN WARLORD — CREATURE 7

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 252
Initiative Perception +14

B9. STRONGROOM

This chamber has a strong wooden door that can be barred from the inside (requiring success on a DC 25 Athletics check to Force Open) and firing loops that look out into area **B8**. The firing loops provide greater cover.

B10. WELL ROOM

This chamber contains a small well and several water barrels. Twenty buckets are stacked against the south wall.

The buckets are used in case of fire; if the PCs use fire to try to smoke out the spriggans, the spriggans use these buckets to put out the fire. The well is 40 feet deep, the bottom 20 feet of which are filled with water. A PC must succeed at a DC 20 Athletics check to scale the well's shaft. Underwater, a 5-foot-wide, water-filled tunnel winds north several hundred feet to eventually connect to the deep pool at area **A5**.

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Treasure: A PC who clambers down into the well and succeeds at a DC 25 Perception check notes a hidden niche in the wall. Inside are four *potions of water breathing*.

B11. BUNKHOUSE LOW 8

This bunkhouse holds beds for a dozen individuals and has hooks on the wall for their clothing and equipment.

Creatures: Currently, two spriggans are asleep in here. If an alarm is sounded, they require 6 rounds to gather their weapons and armor.

SPRIGGAN WARLORDS (2) CREATURE 7

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 252
Initiative Perception +14

B12. SERGEANT-AT-ARMS'S QUARTERS

This bedroom contains a well-used sparring dummy.

This room served as the abode of Howitt Gurney, adventuring companion to Maegar Varn and weapons master, armorer, and sergeant-at-arms of Varnhold.

B13. ARMORY

Weapons and suits of armor are stored here. The gear seems to have been rifled through but not thoroughly searched.

Treasure: This chamber has been largely ignored as the equipment here is of little interest to the spriggans, who are happy with their current weapons and armor. Hanging from racks and packed in chests are 12 suits of padded armor, a breastplate, seven wooden shields, 20 spears, three shortswords, two hatchets, a shortbow, two longbows, four light crossbows, two heavy crossbows, a *+1 grievous scimitar*, 200 arrows, and 220 crossbow bolts.

B14. DOVECOTE

Wire cages hang from the rafters of this chamber, and the floor beneath is spattered with droppings. Sacks of seed are stacked near the door. The cage doors stand open and are empty but for a sprinkling of feathers, while in the ceiling above, shutters close up a skylight.

Messenger pigeons were once kept here by Cephal Lorentus. They have all been eaten by the spriggans.

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B15. KITCHEN AND STORES SEVERE 8

This chamber is a cluttered kitchen. Crates and boxes are stacked in the western portion, while the main area has been converted into a bedroom.

Creatures: This is the den of the Culcheck leader, Agai. He spends most of his time here with his two lieutenants sorting through the treasures recovered from the village and worrying about the villagers' return. If the alarm is raised, he and his guards join the spriggans in area **B19** to fire their crossbows out of the arrow slits at any foes outside. If attacked here, he raises a cry to bring the other spriggans in the building here as quickly as they can come. If he's slain, once the other spriggans realize their leader has been defeated, they abandon the building and flee for their lives.

AGAI CREATURE 9

UNIQUE | CE | SMALL | GNOME | HUMANOID | SPRIGGAN

Variant male spriggan warlord (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 253)

Perception +19, low-light vision

Languages Aklo, Common, Gnome

Skills Acrobatics +19, Athletics +17, Intimidation +19, Society +15, Stealth +17, Survival +17, Thievery +19

Str +4, **Dex** +6, **Con** +4, **Int** +2, **Wis** +4, **Cha** +6

Items *bag of holding* (type II), breastplate, *lesser healing potions* (3), *+1 morningstar*, *+1 striking crossbow* (20 bolts), 30 gp

AC 28; **Fort** +17, **Ref** +21, **Will** +19

HP 155

Enlarged Growth ↷ (polymorph, primal, transmutation) As spriggan warlord.

Speed 20 feet

Melee ❖ *morningstar* +16 (versatile P), **Damage** 1d6+8 bludgeoning

Ranged ❖ *crossbow* +21 (range increment 120 feet, reload 0, two hands), **Damage** 2d10+8 piercing

Primal Innate Spells DC 27; **4th** *fear*, *fly*, *shatter*; **3rd** *dispel magic*; **2nd** *blur*; **Cantrips (4th)** *dancing lights*

Sneak Attack Agai's Strikes deal an additional 2d6 precision damage to flat-footed creatures.

Warlord's Training As spriggan warlord.

SPRIGGAN WARLORDS (2) CREATURE 7

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 252

Initiative Perception +14

Treasure: Agai's *bag of holding* contains the following treasure (items marked with an asterisk are from the spriggans' original lair and were not looted from Varnhold, and taking these items doesn't cause the PCs to fail the Varnhold Treasure quest): 600 gp in assorted coins and jewelry, a small payroll coffer holding 500 sp, an assortment of gems* worth 350 gp, a *+2 longsword** with the crest of House Varn on its pommel guard (this belonged to Maegar Varn; he left it behind when he was lured to his doom, and the villagers eagerly award it to the PCs in thanks, so it doesn't count as one of Varnhold's treasures), a *wand of spectral hand**, a *messenger's ring*, and *Skybolt**—an exquisite *+1 thundering composite longbow*. A PC who succeeds at a DC 20 Nature or Society check identifies *Skybolt*'s construction as being similar to weapons created by the centaurs of Iobara, with a critical success confirming the bow is a sacred ancestral relic of Nomen centaurs.

B16. MASTER OF DISPATCH'S QUARTERS

These quarters are an absolute mess of broken furniture and scattered parchments.

This room served as the chamber for Cephal Lorentus, Varn's wizard, birdkeeper, and master of dispatch. The spriggans destroyed much of the contents of this room, but a search through the scattered parchments still reveals mundane correspondence between the town and Restov. There are a number of mentions of conflicts with Nomen centaurs, but nothing to hint at what may have befallen the village.

Treasure: A PC who succeeds at a DC 25 Perception check locates an intact page torn from one of Cephal's spellbooks. The PCs can attempt such a check up to a total of seven times, with each success discovering one of the following spells: *comprehend language*, *flaming sphere*, *phantom steed*, *private sanctum*, *shrink item*, *spider climb*, and *stoneskin*.

B17. LORD MAYOR'S QUARTERS

The only hint that this room once housed the leader of the village of Varnhold is the large map of Nomen Heights tacked to one wall. The map has been torn to shreds, and the other bedroom furnishings are either similarly ruined or missing.

Treasure: Agai claimed many of the furnishings from Maegar Varn's bedroom for his new home and destroyed the rest. The map on the wall is fragmented, but a PC who succeeds at a DC 20 Perception check can partially reconstruct it. Doing so allows the PCs to fill in all of the terrain details and nonhidden encounter areas within 2 hexes of Varnhold, as well as the hex containing the Nomen centaurs (area **NH1**). Consider these hexes explored by the PCs (although to resolve any unvisited encounter areas, they have to actually travel to those areas).

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B18. GUARDROOM LOW 8

Creatures: Two off-duty spriggans pass their time in this room. The ceiling of this chamber contains a 5-foot-wide shaft that extends upward 20 feet to the floor of area **B20**. A ladder bolted to the north wall gives easy access to the trapdoor that provides entrance to the watch post. If the alarm sounds, the two spriggans here assume Large form; one climbs to area **B20** and watches for opportunities to throw rocks at intruders while the other attempts to hold the room.

SPRIGGAN WARLORDS (2) CREATURE 7

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 252

Initiative Perception +14

B19. OVERLOOK LOW 8

This narrow corridor ringing the blockhouse is set with firing loops and murder holes to provide a view of the surrounding grounds and the area immediately below.

The firing loops provide greater cover. Stacked in the corners are piles of broken rock for throwing down through the murder holes on attackers.

Creatures: Two spriggans patrol this corridor, looking out the loopholes every few minutes. They raise the alarm and fire their crossbows if they spot intruders.

SPRIGGAN WARLORDS (2) CREATURE 7

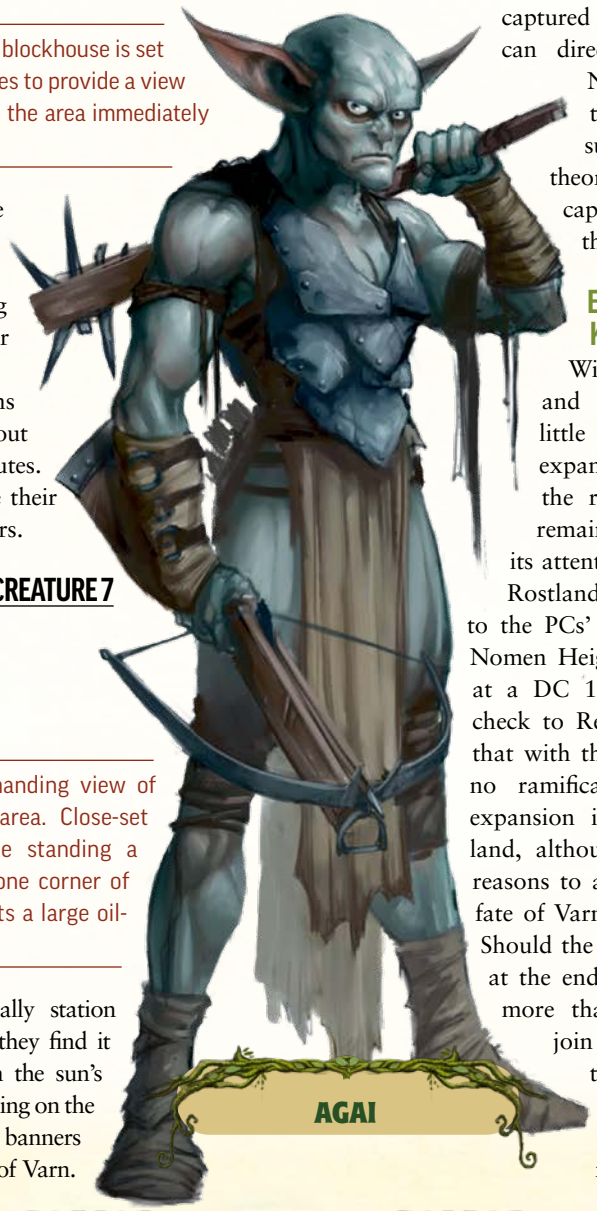
Pathfinder Bestiary 2 252

Initiative Perception +14

B20. WATCH POST

This rooftop provides a commanding view of the village and surrounding area. Close-set logs provide cover to anyone standing a watch. A single barrel sits in one corner of the platform, while opposite sits a large oil-burning brazier.

The Culchecks don't typically station anyone in the watch post, as they find it too hot and uncomfortable in the sun's unshaded rays. A broken pole lying on the platform floor bears the soiled banners of both Brevoy and the house of Varn. When Varnhold was active, the brazier served as a beacon and was lit every evening to bring good luck on the next day. This is little more than a local superstition—although the night Vordakai came to town, a guard did forget to light the beacon.



AGAI

FOLLOWING THE CLUES

When the PCs explore Varnhold, they may initially suspect that the spriggans were the cause of the vanishing, despite the fact that no bodies or, indeed, any evidence of fighting exists in the town. Any spriggan the PCs speak to can make plain that they found the village empty, and the Culchecks have no idea where the people who lived here went.

The logical next step in investigating the Varnhold vanishing should be to contact the Nomen centaurs. If the other clues in Varnhold aren't enough, a captured or cooperating spriggan can direct the PCs toward the Nomen centaurs, even though there's no evidence supporting the spriggans' theory that the people were captured and taken away by the centaurs.

EXPANDING THE KINGDOM

With Varnhold abandoned and its leaders gone, there's little to prevent the PCs from expanding their kingdom into the region or annexing what remains of the settlement. With its attention diverted to the north, Rostland won't notice or react to the PCs' kingdom expanding into Nomen Heights. A PC who succeeds at a DC 15 Legal Lore or Society check to Recall Knowledge confirms that with the citizens gone, there are no ramifications against the PCs' expansion into this now unclaimed land, although there may be moral reasons to avoid it, at least until the fate of Varnhold's citizens is learned. Should the PCs rescue the townsfolk at the end of this chapter, they are more than eager and willing to join the PCs' kingdom—see the section on Annexing Varnhold at the end of this chapter (page 285) for additional details.

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PART 3:

AMONG NOMEN

Nomen centaurs are an offshoot of the mighty Rashalka centaurs that once ruled the northern Casmar steppes. In the distant past, the branch that would become Nomen migrated northwest into the fringes of Avistan, eventually coming into conflict with the people who would one day form the nation of Brevoy.

Nomen follow two key traditions that they no longer fully understand. First, they serve as guardians against an ancient evil they know only by the name Vordakai. Second, the Valley of the Dead and the Tors of Levenies above it are taboo to them. Over the generations, the reasons behind these traditions have fallen into obscurity, but to Nomen centaurs, the traditions themselves are all they need to continue in their ways.

Nomen centaurs form a matriarchal society led by a war-priestess dedicated to the worship of Desna in an aspect they call "Mother Moon." Their history with the armies of Taldor have left them wary of the motives and interests of all bipedal folk.

A PC who succeeds at a at a DC 25 Nature or Society check or a DC 20 Iobaria Lore check to Recall Knowledge knows the above, while a critical success confirms that the original Nomen served a key role in protecting the region from a malign necromancer named Vordakai many centuries ago.

FINDING NOMEN CENTAURS

Some of the clues the PCs find in Varnhold implicate Nomen centaurs, while others suggest that members

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of the Nomen tribe might have further answers. Despite the fact that Nomen have had their share of clashes with Varnhold, they aren't responsible for the vanishing. Instead, their traditions and knowledge of the area can set the PCs on the right path to rescuing the villagers.

The PCs can discover the location of the Nomen encampment (encounter site **NH1)** from the map in the Varnhold blockhouse (area **B17**), or they can simply stumble upon the site on their own. Contacting the Nomen tribe is simple enough; the PCs automatically encounter Nomen centaurs within hours of entering any hex within Nomen Heights.

Creatures: Generations of conflict with humanity have left Nomen centaurs with an ill opinion of bipedal people: they consider "two-leggers" warlike and untrustworthy. If the PCs decide to seek out members of the Nomen, they'll need to tread lightly and diplomatically, or they'll have a conflict on their hands—the centaurs' initial attitude toward the PCs is unfriendly. Nomen centaurs speak Common, though they prefer to speak in Sylvan.

Unless the PCs are successfully stealthy, they're initially approached by a Nomen patrol consisting of eight centaur scouts—a severe-threat encounter for 8th-level characters. The centaurs move to surround the PCs and gauge their responses to their presence. If the PCs attack, the centaurs fight back until at least three of their number are defeated, at which point they flee back to their campsite—inadvertently leading the PCs to their homes, for the trail they leave in this case is simple to track.

If the PCs instead attempt peaceful contact, they can do so by Lying, Making an Impression, or Coercing. Multiple attempts are possible, but any repeated attempt by the same character takes a –2 circumstance penalty. Making an Impression on the initially unfriendly centaurs requires a DC 25 Diplomacy check. Attempts to gain their favor via Lying are a bit tougher and require a DC 28 Deception check. On a successful Lie, the centaurs' attitude improves to indifferent, but on a critical failure, they become hostile. Coercing the centaurs is the riskiest. Success on a DC 25 Intimidation check to Coerce the centaurs makes them indifferent, but on a failure the centaurs become hostile; furthermore, once a PC attempts to Coerce the centaurs, the DC to Make an Impression on them for all future attempts increases by 5.

If the PCs recovered the magic longbow *Skybolt* from the spriggan chieftain in the Varnhold blockhouse (area **B15**), they can hand the ancestral weapon over to automatically change the centaurs' attitude to friendly. If any PC openly carries the bow, the centaurs confront the PCs and demand its return. If the PCs don't return the bow, the centaurs become hostile.

Helpful: In order to make the centaurs helpful, the PCs must return *Skybolt* to them and then successfully Make an Impression to change their attitude from friendly. The warband then escorts the PCs to their camp and makes no requests about the PCs' weapons.

Friendly: The centaurs escort the PCs to their campsite to meet the leader of the tribe, but they warn the PCs to keep their weapons sheathed and stowed; failure to comply shifts their attitude to indifferent.

Indifferent: The centaurs escort the PCs to their campsite but only if the PCs temporarily hand over their weapons. These confiscated weapons will be returned once the meeting with their leader is over and the PCs are on their way.

Unfriendly: The centaurs continue to be wary about the PCs. They don't attack, but they won't agree to escort the PCs to their camp. Any attempt by the PCs to push on to the Nomen campsite causes the centaurs to become hostile.

Hostile: The centaurs attack. If the PCs surrender, the centaurs confiscate their weapons, bind their wrists, and lead them into their camp to meet their leader to decide their fate.

CENTAUR SCOUTS (8) CREATURE 5

RARE N LARGE BEAST

Variant centaurs (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 60)
Perception +13; darkvision
Languages Common, Elven, Sylvan
Skills Athletics +12, Diplomacy +8, Intimidation +12, Nature +11, Survival +13
Str +5, **Dex** +3, **Con** +2, **Int** +0, **Wis** +4, **Cha** +1
Items leather armor, spear

AC 22; **Fort** +11, **Ref** +12, **Will** +15
HP 75

Speed 40 feet
Melee ❖ spear +14, **Damage** 1d6+8 piercing
Melee ❖ hoof +14 (agile), **Damage** 1d10+8 bludgeoning
Ranged ❖ spear +12 (thrown 20 feet), **Damage** 1d6+8 piercing
Trample ❖❖❖ Medium or smaller, hoof, DC 22

SKYBOLT

30 XP

The PCs return the ancestral treasure *Skybolt* to the Nomen centaurs.

Source: The PCs can find the treasure in Agai's *bag of holding* (page 264); otherwise, the leader of the Nomen centaurs can ask them to find it.

Completion: Return *Skybolt* to the Nomen centaurs.

Reward: Completing this quest not only proves to the Nomen centaurs that their spriggan enemies have been defeated, but it also earns their trust and changes their attitude to helpful.

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Reward: If the PCs make the centaurs friendly or helpful, grant them 50 XP.

MEETING AECORA SILVERFIRE

The Nomen campsite is located at encounter site **NH1** of Nomen Heights. The camp sits in a low hillock surrounded by a sea of grass. A large bonfire dominates the center of the camp, while nearly a hundred open-sided hide huts are ranged around the central fire. It is within these huts that Nomen centaurs congregate, eat, and sleep.

The encampment is home to the majority of the tribe. In all, the Nomen consist of 200 centaurs, and even though at any one time 60 to 80 are out hunting or patrolling, the remaining numbers are sizable enough that open hostility should not be a viable option.

If the PCs arrive at the encampment without being intercepted by a war party, they'll be confronted as soon as they make themselves known. In this case, all DCs to Lie, Make an Impression, or Coerce the centaurs increase by 5, as the centaurs are startled by the PCs' sudden appearance in their camp. If the PCs fail to make the centaurs' attitude indifferent, they're forcefully escorted out of the encampment; otherwise, they are brought into the center of the camp near the bonfire for an audience with their war-priestess leader.



AECORA SILVERFIRE

Creature: If the PCs came peacefully, they are brought to the war-priestess, Aecora Silverfire, patron of "Mother Moon." A PC who succeeds at a DC 25 Religion check or a DC 20 Desna Lore check is enough to note that Mother Moon is an aspect of Desna. Aecora is long embittered by the violent territorial expansion of humans, but she believes that trespassers are not always the enemy. She does her best to adhere to Desna's teachings, but years of betrayal and conflict with humanity have left her cynical. Varnhold's recent expansion into the land has pushed her to the edge, and only her faith in Mother Moon has kept her from an overreaction that could well lead the tribe into war against Restov.

Aecora's initial attitude is unfriendly, but if any PC is obviously a worshipper of Desna, her attitude shifts to indifferent. She must be made friendly before she'll agree to provide aid to the PCs. This requires a DC 27 Diplomacy check to Make an Impression on her (DC 25 if the PCs are escorted by friendly Nomen scouts, or DC 22 if they're escorted by helpful Nomen scouts) or a DC 27 Deception check to Lie to her well enough to make her friendly. A PC who attempts to Coerce her must succeed at a DC 32 Intimidation check; on a failure, she orders the PCs to be escorted from the camp, and on a critical failure, she also becomes hostile.

Aecora Becomes Hostile: Aecora draws her weapons, as do the eight centaur scouts (page 267) nearby, and she orders the PCs to leave the camp immediately. If they don't, she and the scouts attack.

Aecora Becomes Friendly: The war-priestess confirms that she knew about the vanishing at Varnhold, having learned of it from her scouts, but she says that she hasn't sent her people to investigate. She denies any involvement beyond this with the vanishing, and in truth, the mystery disturbs her, as she fears that what happened to the human town could happen to her people next. She presents the PCs with an opportunity to prove their worth: she asks them to seek out the Culchek spriggans and return with an important magical bow

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the monsters stole from her people several years ago. Aecora can give the PCs directions to the Culcheck cavern (area **LV3**); she is unaware that the spriggans have moved into Varnhold unless the PCs tell her.

Aecora Becomes Helpful: Aecora reveals the information for becoming friendly, but as she does, her voice softens and she even grows somewhat apologetic. She explains that her people have a violent history with humans, going back to Taldor's Army of Exploration, and she offers to let the PCs stay the night in the camp to recover and rest as a show of her goodwill.

Aecora's Story: If she's made friendly or helpful, Aecora shares more information with the PCs. If the PCs haven't mentioned Vordakai, she does so now, revealing that the Nomen centaurs believe Vordakai to be a "slumbering warlord—an ancient, powerful figure from the distant past." Aecora apologizes for being unable to give the PCs more information, as her people have lost much of their history in the years since they were dispersed by Taldor's armies.

At this point, Aecora tells the PCs of a place to the west called Olah-Kakanket—the Valley of the Dead. This place is taboo to the Nomen centaurs, but their traditions also dictate that they must watch the valley for signs of disturbance or strange awakenings. Recently, a Nomen hunter saw a frightful shape lumbering amid the stones of Olah-Kakanket. Aecora wonders if, perhaps, the humans of Varnhold with their insatiable curiosity and drive to expand and conquer might have entered Olah-Kakanket and if this, perhaps, might be tied to the vanishing. One thing she can confirm, though, is that the name "Vordakai" is associated with a narrow trail that leads up into the mountains from the far end of Olah-Kakanket; she believes that the valley is a cemetery and that this trail leads to Vordakai's tomb.

If at any time the PCs mention the mysterious bracelet mentioned or sketched in Pendrod's notes (see area **A12**), she says that Nomen centaurs wear no such jewelry, only further convincing her that someone from Varnhold disturbed something that should have been left alone in Olah-Kakanket.

Before the party departs, Aecora makes one final plea. She admits that the centaur who claimed to see a strange shape lumbering deep in Olah-Kakanket was her headstrong daughter Xamanthe. When Xamanthe confronted Aecora, demanding to learn more about the site, Aecora was unable to satisfy her daughter's curiosity. Xamanthe has now been missing for several days, and Aecora fears the worst: that her daughter has broken tradition and entered Olah-Kakanket to investigate it on her own. The possibility that her daughter broke this taboo is painful for Aecora to contemplate, but the possibility of the loss of her daughter is more painful. She asks the PCs to remain observant if they enter Olah-Kakanket and to search for clues as to Xamanthe's whereabouts, if they can.

Once the meeting with Aecora is over, the centaur politely but firmly asks the PCs to leave their encampment, as their presence makes most of Nomen centaurs uncomfortable and nervous.

AECORA SILVERFIRE — CREATURE 7

UNIQUE CN LARGE BEAST

Female centaur war-priestess (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 60)
Perception +17; darkvision
Languages Common, Elven, Sylvan
Skills Athletics +14, Diplomacy +13, Intimidation +17, Nature +15, Religion +17, Survival +17
Str +5, **Dex** +2, **Con** +4, **Int** +2, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +4
Items breastplate, *+1 spear*, wooden shield (Hardness 3, HP 12, BT 6)

AC 25; **Fort** +15, **Ref** +13, **Will** +17
HP 120

Speed 40 feet
Melee ❖ *spear* +17, **Damage** 1d6+8 piercing
Melee ❖ hoof +16 (agile), **Damage** 1d10+8 piercing
Ranged ❖ *spear* +14 (thrown 20 feet), **Damage** 1d6+8 piercing
Divine Spells Prepared DC 25, attack +17; **4th** *heal*, *outcast's curse*; **3rd** *dream message*, *heal*, *sound burst*; **2nd** *heal*, *restoration*, *silence*; **1st** *command*, *ray of enfeeblement*, *sanctuary*; **Cantrips (4th)** *daze*, *disrupt undead*, *know direction*, *message*, *stabilize*
Trample ❖❖❖ Medium or smaller, hoof, DC 25

Reward: If the PCs make Aecora friendly or helpful, grant them 80 XP.

RESCUING XAMANTHE

30 XP

The PCs are tasked with rescuing the centaur Xamanthe from Vordakai's Tomb.

Source: Aecora Silverfire.

Completion: Bring Xamanthe back to the Nomen centaurs, or spin a convincing tale of her fate to Aecora (requiring a critical success at Lying or at Making an Impression).

Reward: If the mystery of Xamanthe's disappearance is explained, Aecora thanks the PCs and rewards them with four *moderate healing potions* and four *scrolls of restoration*; if the PCs returned *Skybolt*, she also gives them the bow to honor their service. If Xamanthe is brought back alive, the act restores some of Aecora's faith in humanity and she not only won't oppose expansion into Nomen Heights by the PCs' kingdom, but she may in time become chaotic good and work to establish peaceful relations between the Nomen tribe and their humanoid neighbors. In this event, award the PCs 80 Kingdom XP.

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PART 4:

VORDAKAI'S TOMB

Deep in the Tors of Levenies, where the Little Sellen River cascades over a cliffside into a deep mountain tarn, lies a strange island—the grave marker of Vordakai's tomb and a surviving complex from a cyclops empire that predated Earthfall. This island protrudes dramatically from the pool, almost like a stony finger pointing into the sky.

Though the island is all but forgotten today, ancient texts (such as the ancient geography book by Carmyn e'Brothasa that the PCs may have found in area **A12**) refer to it as Vordakai's Island, little suspecting the name refers not to some forgotten explorer but to the cyclops lich that dwells in a tomb carved into the island's stony heart. Since he was defeated eons ago by kin, Vordakai has slumbered in his tomb, unmoving while he awaited the call of his otherworldly masters. He rests unaware that a watch has been set by the centaurs of Iobaria—bitter enemies of his people—to prevent intrusion into his tomb and the subsequent awakening that would surely follow. Even in recent years, when the Nomen watch faltered and humans from surrounding lands managed to penetrate the outer precincts of the tomb, its remote location has continued to ensure that none broke the wards that kept him in his torpor. Not until Willas Gundarson came from Varnhold and stole a treasure from the tomb, setting off the tomb's wards, did Vordakai finally awaken.

Now, the ancient lich studies a strange new world through the eyes of a recently acquired raven familiar and via interrogations of villagers he snatched from

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Varnhold. As he reacquaints himself with the world and learns that his people's time has long passed, Vordakai grows increasingly convinced that he has been reborn into a world that is ripe for his rule.

SEEKING VORDAKAI'S TOMB

The lich Vordakai remains in his tomb, but he's far from uninformed about the outside world. In particular, his raven familiar, Horagnamon, has been scouring the Nomen Heights while Vordakai uses the *Oculus of Abaddon* (page 587) to see the world through the bird's eyes. In this way, Vordakai has learned of the PCs and has been following their movements and progress (see The Watcher on page 253).

WHAT COMES IN DARKNESS MODERATE 9

Vordakai eventually realizes that the PCs are going to find his tomb, and the lich decides to strike first with hideous conjured assassins: soul eaters. The timing of this event is left to you to determine, but the sinister nature of the creatures lends well to a midnight attack on a campsite, or even an ambush against the PCs while they are exploring another unsettling location in the wilderness. You should avoid having them face the soul eaters while they're in the middle of another combat or before they have a chance to recover from a battle, though, if only because the soul eaters are here for the PCs, not for any enemies they may be facing.

Creatures: Vordakai uses the *Oculus of Abaddon* to conjure four soul eaters from Abaddon. Once conjured, the soul eaters leave Vordakai's tomb and, using their Find Target ability, seek the PCs out. You can time this encounter to occur anytime after the PCs have been spotted by Horagnamon but before they reach Vordakai's tomb (but keep in mind that if the PCs are still 8th level, this becomes a Severe encounter). An attack on the PCs' camp at night could be one exciting possibility, as could a siege against them as they slumber in a reclaimed Varnhold building.

When this encounter occurs, Vordakai assigns a different PC to each soul eater as their target. The lich prefers to target arcane spellcasters first, then other spellcasters, then non-spellcasters.

SOUL EATERS (4) CREATURE 7

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 247
Initiative Perception +15

VORDAKAI'S ISLE

Vordakai's tomb lies within a massive, 100-foot-tall, naturally formed stack that rises from the center of a small lake in encounter site **LV6**. Its rooms and passageways are all hewn from limestone, often following the natural cracks and seams in the stone, and many bear the linear and pictographic artwork of the ancient cyclops empire embossed in bas relief.

C1. RIVER CROSSING

A jagged limestone cliff hems in the scene. A mighty waterfall rushes over its edge into a wide pool of black, frothing water. In the center of the pool stands a massive, hundred-foot-tall limestone pillar of weathered stone—the last, lonely sentinel marking where the cliff once stood in an age long past. At various points on the island's top, plumes of black smoke waft upward before swiftly fading away.

The trail from encounter site **LV7** leads up to this point on the Little Sellen River's southern bank. Anyone searching for tracks along the trail or the riverbank can attempt a DC 25 Survival check. Success reveals a few signs of passage by at least three different creatures over the past several weeks. The oldest of these signs appears to be a few human footprints; these were left by Willas Gundarson as he explored the area. The next oldest appears to be a larger set of skeletal humanoid footprints; these were left by the six undead cyclopes now lurking at encounter site **LV7**. The most recent, perhaps only a few days old, are of what appears to be an unshod horse; these are from the centaur Xamanthe.

The plumes of black smoke rising from the top of the island are foul-smelling gases emitted from a series of vents along the island's western face. These are poisonous gases escaping via several narrow fissures connected to area **E10**; once the gases escape into the air, their debilitating effects are lessened to being nothing more than foul-smelling vapor.

C2. LITTLE SELLEN RIVER

At this point, the Little Sellen River's average depth is 40 feet, but the pool surrounding the island is much deeper: at their deepest, the waters reach a depth of 120 feet. The waters themselves are relatively slow flowing, and it's only a DC 10 Athletics check to Swim across them.

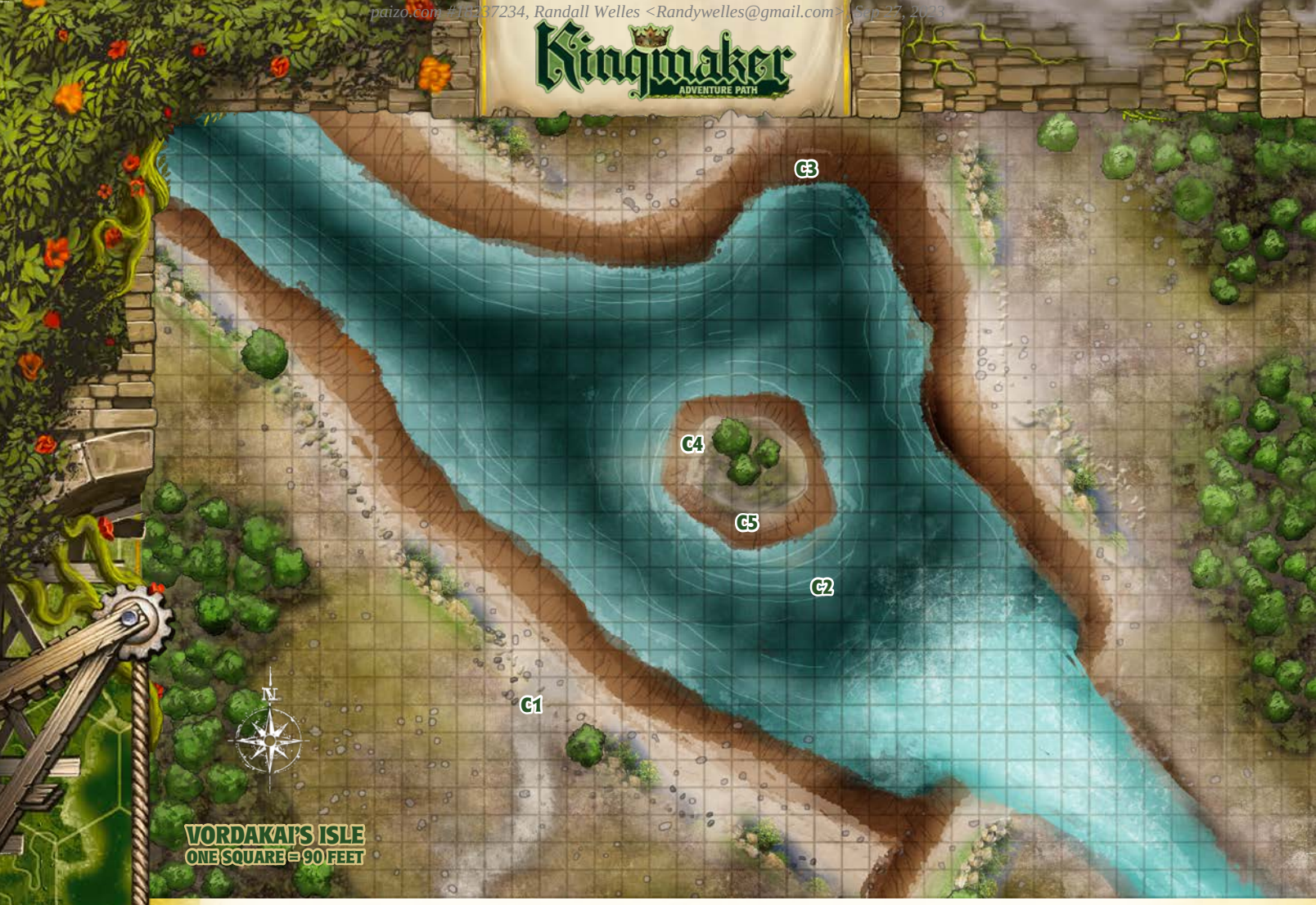
C3. WYVERN BLUFFS MODERATE 9

Limestone bluffs overlook the waterfall and the pool. Their surface is striated and pocked by weathering—crumbling in places and supporting creepers and other scrub foliage in others. Hundreds of bird nests fill the tiny seams and nooks that dot the cliff face, and the air before the cliffs is constantly abuzz with the insects that dwell in the foliage and the wrens and starlings that feed on them.

The bluffs are 100 feet high and level off evenly with the top of the cairn stack. The face is unstable

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and crumbling from long years of erosion, though it has many handholds (DC 20 Athletics check to climb).

Creatures: A naturally eroded declivity widens at the bottom into a sheltered cave chamber here. A PC who succeeds at a DC 28 Perception check can spot the chamber from the lake or the central island. This cave serves as the home for a family of three wyverns. Unless the PCs are stealthy when they approach the central island, the wyverns are swift to notice and swoop down to attack when the PCs are relatively spread out so the creatures can focus their violence on one or two foes at a time.

ELITE WYVERNS (4) CREATURE 7

Pathfinder Bestiary 6, 133
Initiative Perception +15

Treasure: The wyverns' stored treasures include a tattered backpack holding a complete set of Ustalavic silverware worth 75 sp, a pouch holding 37 sp among other odds and ends, a +2 *striking maul* stamped with the Issian coat-of-arms, and a messenger's bag containing five green spinels worth 10 gp each. A successful DC 26 Perception check notes a hidden pocket in the bag that contains a *scroll of sending*.

C4. HIDDEN OVERLOOK

A natural cleft in the side of the stone tower creates a sort of overlook here. The far wall is encased in a thick layer of vines.

It's a 60-foot drop from here to the surface of the river, and the cleft in the rock is 10 feet high. The vines along the back wall obscure a door that a PC can notice from the outside by succeeding at a DC 25 Perception check while at the same height as the door, 60 feet above the river.

The stone door is warded by a heightened *lock* spell (2nd level, requiring a successful DC 32 Athletics or Thievery check to open) but it isn't otherwise protected. Beyond the door, the passage slopes down to area **E11** in the tomb.

C5. BEACH ENTRANCE

At the foot of the cliff, where the beach meets the limestone scarp, a dark opening in the stone beckons, partially obscured by creepers and dangling foliage.

A faint path in the mud reveals the passage of three creatures over the past several weeks—Willas

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Gundarson, the undead cyclopes that wandered out of the crypt down to encounter site **LV7**, and the centaur Xamanthe. A PC who succeeds at a DC 24 Survival check can pick out one set of prints, while critical success notes all three and the order in which they were left.

VORDAKAI'S TOMB

The entire structure of Vordakai's tomb radiates faint transmutation magic. A PC who succeeds at a DC 25 Arcana check identifies this aura as preservative magic intended to maintain the structure over the ages. While this magic won't prevent damage from significantly destructive events (either intentional or by natural disaster) or stop magical effects like *disintegrate* or *passwall*, it does protect the ancient tomb from subtler effects like erosion.

Ceilings within the tomb arch from 10-foot-high walls, rising to 15 feet at the center of passages and reaching 20 feet high in rooms unless otherwise noted. None of the rooms have a light source unless noted. PCs can discover secret doors by succeeding at a DC 25 Perception check; they are made of 2-foot-thick stone and require a PC to succeed at a DC 25 Athletics check to Force them Open. Regular doors are made of bronze and cannot be locked unless indicated otherwise; unlike the secret doors, they swing open easily.

D1. TOMB ENTRANCE

This darkened passageway is decorated to the east and west with alcoves. Midway down the hall, just before the second set of alcoves, a decorative arch is carved into the stone. Upon its lintel are various runes and symbols. The eastern alcove just past the arch holds an ancient amphora that has broken open, spilling its contents into the corridor.

It was here that Willas Gundarson of Varnhold first laid eyes on the treasures of the cairn and chose to risk the tomb's defenses by taking something from them. A PC who succeeds at a DC 25 Arcana check identifies the symbols on the archway as some sort of magical warding or alarm that was recently discharged, its power now expended. They were a part of the protections placed on the cairn both to alert the nearest undead guardians and to awaken Vordakai if any of his treasures were taken. Willas activated them when he rushed in and stole the jade "bracelet," but he fled the island before the guardians from area **D2** could arrive—the sound of the skeletal hulks smashing through a wall and then squeezing their way toward his location was more than enough to scare Willas off.

A PC who succeeds at a DC 15 Survival check notes fairly recent tracks in the thick dust. The oldest of these are human (left by Willis); these lead from the beach up to the fallen amphora and then retreat back toward the beach. The next oldest are from several huge skeletal creatures (the six skeletal hulks) traveling from area **D2** to the beach; these tracks do not return. The most recent are hoofprints (left by Xamanthe); these go from the beach to area **D2**.

Around the corner toward area **D2**, a pile of rubble marks where a wall of stones once blocked the passage into area **D2**. A PC who succeeds at a DC 20 Perception or a DC 15 Architecture Lore check determines that the wall was broken down by a powerful force from the east; the skeletal hulks broke through the wall after the power of the tomb's wards was expended.

Treasure: The contents of the spilled amphora include 32 gp and 369 sp. Buried among the spilled coinage is another jade "bracelet" just like the one described in Maestro Pendrod's notes; this piece of jewelry—actually a ring for a cyclops—is worth 20 gp. A PC who succeeds at a DC 28 Crafting check or DC 24 Cyclops Lore check recognizes it as a ring and not a bracelet.

D2. SEPULCHER MODERATE 9

This chamber vaults to a height of nearly thirty feet at the center of the room. The room is shaped like a diamond with squared-off corners. The western corner leads to the tomb entrance, the northern corner is a wall of mortared stone, and the eastern and southern corners have empty cobweb-shrouded alcoves holding stone biers.

When Xamanthe reached this room, she was immediately attacked by the chamber's remaining guardians. She put up a good fight, but in the end, she was defeated.

For many centuries, six skeletal hulks stood guard in this room, all but filling the chamber with their bony girth, but when Willas broke in, the undead cyclopes lurched to unlife. Compelled further by Vordakai, they didn't return to this post but instead took up guardian positions down in the Valley of the Dead (encounter site **LV7**), leaving behind bony footprints in the drifts of dust on the floor.

The wall in the northern corner can be breached as any stone wall (hardness 14, 56 HP, 28 BT), though after the leukodaemon stationed in the alcove behind it uses *dimension door* to enter area **D1**, the alcove contains nothing else.

The back of the eastern alcove conceals a secret door to area **D3** that a PC can find by succeeding at a DC 25 Perception check.

Creatures: Once the skeletal hulks moved on, Vordakai sent two other minions to stand guard in their place: a pair of leukodaemons called in via the *Oculus*

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of Abaddon. One of the skull-headed fiends stands in the eastern alcove, while the other initially hides in the alcove behind the wall in the northern corner. Both leukodaemons bear fresh scars caused by what appear to be spear thrusts and kicks from a hoofed animal; these wounds were given by Xamanthe before she was overpowered and captured.

The eastern leukodaemon immediately attacks anyone who enters the room, moving forward to catch the PCs in its infectious aura before using its Breath Weapon to try to inflict daemonic pestilence on as many creatures at once. It then engages in melee, while the second daemon uses *dimension door* to exit the western alcove into the hallway (area **D1**) to try to trap the PCs within area **D2**, using Quicken Pestilence on diseased PCs before attacking at range with its longbow. The daemons fight until slain, pursuing PCs throughout the tomb but not outside. They do their best to capture living PCs and will even attempt to stabilize dying PCs with Medicine checks in order to do so, leaving them unconscious on the floor. Vordakai wants living creatures to interrogate (and eventually experiment upon); the dead are still useful to him, but not as much. Vordakai checks this room once a day with his *Oculus of Abaddon*, and if he sees new victims to collect, he gathers them up and returns with them to the tomb's third level—such was the fate of Xamanthe, who's now imprisoned in area **E5**.

LEUKODAEMONS (2) CREATURE 9

Pathfinder Bestiary 72
Initiative Perception +20

D3. POOL STAIRS MODERATE 9

This wide, natural cavern seems to have been artificially enlarged in places. A wide pool occupies the entire chamber save for a narrow rocky shelf hugging the cavern wall. Nearly thirty feet above, the vaulting ceiling is an upside-down forest of slowly dripping stalactites.

A submerged flight of steps descends from the eastern ledge into the water. A PC must succeed at a DC 15 Perception check to note the underwater portion of the flight of stairs from above the water. The stairs are immediately obvious to anyone underwater, although silt and murk in the water reduces underwater sight to a limit of 10 feet.

The stairs descend steeply for 20 feet before turning and entering a completely flooded 10-foot-high tunnel

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to the north that leads back out of the water via a flight of steps rising up to area **D4**

The pool itself is 30 feet deep and has a 15-foot-diameter underwater passage at its base that leads 140 feet west into the river basin. It is via this passageway that the pool's denizen comes and goes. A DC 25 Perception check is enough to see the underwater entrance from the surface. The waters here are still; it's a DC 10 Athletics check to Swim here.

Creature: A particularly large and dangerous river elasmosaurus has inhabited this pool for many years, living off the abundantly available eels. The animal is ferociously territorial, immediately attacking anyone who enters the water and pursuing foes onto land for short distances if needed.

RIVER ELASMOSAURUS CREATURE 11

RARE N HUGE ANIMAL

Variant elasmosaurus (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 105)
Perception +21; low-light vision, scent (imprecise) 30 feet
Skills Athletics +22
Str +7, **Dex** +5, **Con** +6, **Int** –4, **Wis** +6, **Cha** +0
Deep Breath The elasmosaurus can hold its breath for 2 hours.

AC 31; **Fort** +23, **Ref** +18, **Will** +21
HP 195
Long Neck As elasmosaurus.
Attack of Opportunity ↷ Jaws only.

Speed 5 feet, swim 35 feet
Melee ❖ jaws +24 (reach 15 feet), **Damage** 2d12+13 piercing plus Grab
Melee ❖ paddle +24, **Damage** 3d6+13 bludgeoning
Drag Below ❖ (attack) As elasmosaurus.
Thrashing Retreat ❖❖ As elasmosaurus.

Treasure: A diver who succeeds at a DC 25 Perception check can find the calcified, skeletal remains of a long-dead adventurer on the pool bed. Within a ruined belt pouch is a *jade serpent wondrous figurine*, and gripped in the skeleton's hand is a *wand of freedom of movement*.

D4. POTTERY STORE

This oddly shaped chamber has stairs descending into cloudy water to the south and another set of stairs descending to bronze double doors to the northwest.

The pottery in here is of ancient cyclops make, elaborate pieces painted primarily in black and white and depicting lotus flowers, cities, and one-eyed humanoids engaged in everything from worship to fighting to athletic contests. Some even show vicious confrontations between these humanoids and centaurs. A PC who succeeds at a DC 30 Society check or DC 25 Iobaria Lore check notices that the humanoids are all portrayed in a distinctive stylistic manner—with wide-legged, sway-backed stances—associated with the ancient Iobarian cyclops empire.

Treasure: The pottery is worth 50 gp in all, but the pieces' awkward sizes results in every 10 gp worth of pottery being 1 bulk.

D5. RIVER TRAP MODERATE 9

A ten-foot-high hallway extends at an angle from bronze double doors, passing two shallow alcoves before reaching a square room. Standing in the side alcoves are two human-sized statues of painted stone depicting one-eyed humanoids. More of these statues stand in ranks within the ten-foot-high room beyond.

The statues are of cyclops warriors clad in ancient Iobarian style. Anyone entering this hallway and succeeding at a DC 28 Perception check notices the telltale points of a raised portcullis in a shadowy recess of the hall's ceiling just east of the alcoves. The backs of the alcoves have sealed secret doors, unopened since the cairn was first excavated; a PC can detect them by succeeding at a DC 35 Perception check. Opening one of these secret doors requires pressing the eye of its nearby statue, causing the door and statue alike to grind down into the ground, revealing the 10-foot-deep alcove beyond.

The statues in the main room are identical to those in the alcoves. A PC can find a secret door on the room's western wall by succeeding at a DC 25 Perception check; opening this door triggers the room's trap. In the ceiling just beyond it is another hidden portcullis; detecting it requires a character standing within 10 feet of it to succeed at a DC 28 Perception check.

Creatures: A single cyclops zombie stands in each alcove beyond the secret doors east of the room. These creatures remain motionless and silent until either their door is opened or the room's trap is triggered, at which point they stomp out into the room to attack any living foes they find.

CYCLOPS ZOMBIES (2) CREATURE 7

NE LARGE MINDLESS UNDEAD ZOMBIE

Variant zombie hulk (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 341)
Perception +8; darkvision
Skills Athletics +18
Str +7, **Dex** –1, **Con** +4, **Int** –5, **Wis** +0, **Cha** –2
Slow A cyclops zombie is permanently slowed 1 and can't use reactions.

AC 21; **Fort** +16, **Ref** +9, **Will** +12
HP 160, negative healing; **Immunities** death effects, disease,

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mental, paralyzed, poison, unconscious; **Weaknesses** critical hits 14, positive 10; **Resistance** all 7 (except positive and critical hits)

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ fist +17 (reach 10 feet), **Damage** 2d10+9 bludgeoning

Hazard: This entire room is a deadly and complex trap that triggers as soon as the secret door to the west is opened. On the ceiling are arranged 12 cleverly hidden circular doors, each just under 5 feet in diameter and located in the center of each full 10-foot square area in the room. Noticing one of these trapdoors before it opens requires a PC to succeed at a DC 33 Perception check; on a critical success, a character notices all 12 doors. Treat these trapdoors as stone doors if the PCs attempt to force them open (hardness 10, HP 80, BT 40)—but once one of these doors is forced open or broken, the trap triggers.

FLOODING ROOM HAZARD 9

UNIQUE COMPLEX MECHANICAL TRAP

Stealth +23 (master)

Description When the western secret door is opened or any of the trapdoors in the ceiling are forced open, the trap is triggered. As soon as this occurs, the portcullises to the east and west come crashing down, each consisting of solid iron sheets that form watertight seals. At the same time, the dozen 5-foot-wide trapdoors open in the ceiling. These holes are the mouths of winding tunnels that connect to a second pair of apertures on the submerged side of the island outside, allowing the waters of the Little Sellen River to plunge down into this room, possibly damaging or knocking prone those in the square portion of the room itself (but not in the adjoining hallway) and eventually flooding the entire chamber.

Disable Thievery DC 26 (this increases to DC 30 once the trap is activated) to disable one of the 12 trapdoors and seal it shut; disabling all 12 of the trapdoors completely deactivates the trap, but a critical failure on any attempt causes the trap to trigger; Thievery DC 24 to disable one of the watertight portcullises and prevent it from falling; magic such as *shape stone* or *wall of stone* or even *lock* can also be used to disable portions of this deadly trap at the GM's discretion

AC 25; **Fort** +23, **Ref** +15

Portcullis Hardness 16; **Portcullis HP** 70 (**BT** 35); **Immunities** critical hits, object immunities, precision damage

Rushing Water ↷ **Trigger** The secret door to the west or any trapdoor is opened. **Effect** The 12 ceiling trapdoors open along with the two secret doors to the cyclops zombie alcoves, releasing river water and zombies into the room. Any creature standing in the central 40-by-40 foot section of the main room must attempt a DC 28 Reflex save; the trap then rolls initiative.

Critical Success The creature takes no damage.

Success The creature takes 1d10+6 bludgeoning damage from the cascade of water.

Failure The creature takes 2d10+13 bludgeoning damage from the cascade of water.

Critical Failure The creature takes 2d10+13 bludgeoning damage from the cascade of falling water and is knocked prone.

Routine (12 actions) The trap loses 1 action for each of its 12 ceiling trapdoors that are disabled. On each of the trap's actions, it pours water into the room, filling it to a depth of one inch. If all 12 trapdoors are open, it thus fills the room at a rate of 1 foot per round. If one of the portcullises is breached, the trap fills the room at half the rate, and if both are breached, it fills at one quarter the rate. Once the cascade of water begins, it's easy enough for a PC to avoid the downpour, but any creature that deliberately enters the cascade is subjected to the trap's Rushing Water reaction. If a creature is struck by Rushing Water while already underwater, the result of its Reflex save is automatically improved one degree of success.

The flooding ends and the trap deactivates once the area is filled to the ceiling–at this point, the water's surface is at the level of the river, and at the top of the stairs leading down from areas **D4** and **D6**. A Medium or smaller creature can try to Swim to freedom through one of the 5-foot-wide tunnels leading to the river from a trapdoor, but doing so requires navigating 200 feet of flooded tunnels.

Reset The trap must be reset with a major engineering effort.

D6. WINDING STAIR

This crooked stair is uneven. It winds upward, curving to the left as it rises.

These stairs lead up to area **E1** on the second level of Vordakai's tomb.

E1. DESCENDING STAIR

This crooked stair is uneven. It winds downward, curving to the right as it descends.

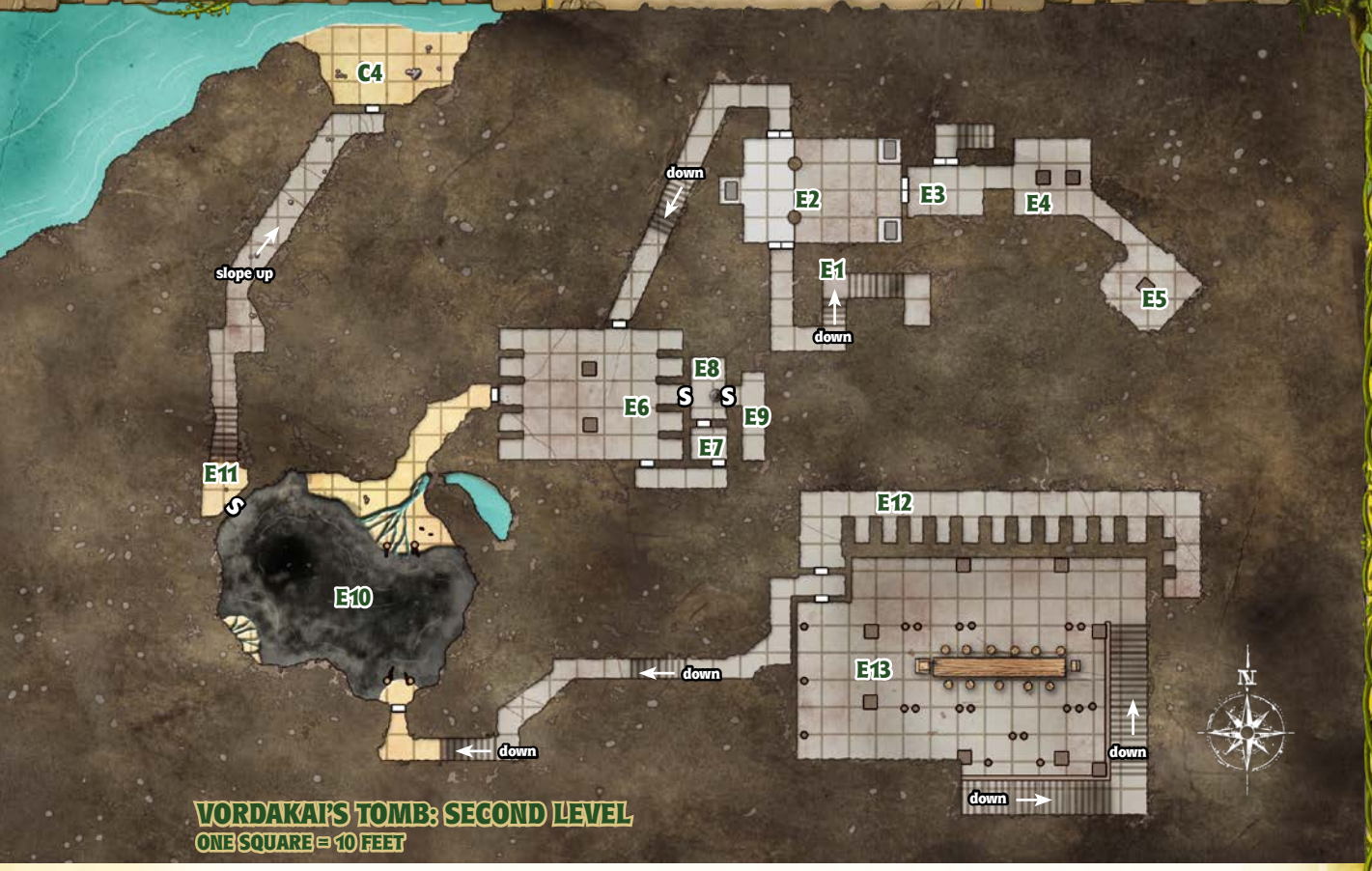
These stairs lead down to area **D6** on the first level of Vordakai's tomb.

E2. DAEMONIC SHRINE

This room is divided in two by a pair of pillars carved in the likeness of leering fiends. West of these pillars, the floor is tiled with light-colored slate. To the east, the walls are unadorned, and plain bronze double doors open to the north and south. An alcove on the south wall houses a

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VORDAKAI'S TOMB: SECOND LEVEL
ONE SQUARE = 10 FEET

simple stone altar bearing an unlit oil lamp. In the eastern part of the room, the slate floor tiles are darker, and friezes on the walls depict processions of animal-headed creatures marching along a black river's banks toward dual shrines in opposite corners of the chamber. These shrines, carved out of quartz, bear depictions of a shadowy individual standing in a sinister longboat, and an unlit oil lamp and a shallow cup rest atop each. Between the shrines stand bronze double doors, their faces decorated with a mosaic of a winding river crafted from obsidian tiles.

A PC who succeeds at a DC 20 Religion check to Recall Knowledge readily identifies the shrouded figure in the boat as Charon. Collectively, the Horsemen of the Apocalypse fueled Vordakai's vision, but the cyclops' interest lay primarily in the demigod Charon, the Horseman of Death.

The oil lamp on the western shrine is empty. The lamps on the eastern shrines are fueled, and the cups atop them are stained with a dark residue; succeeding at a DC 15 Medicine check to Recall Knowledge identifies this as dried blood no more than a week old. Success on a DC 25 Religion check to Recall Knowledge recognizes these dual altars as an archaic and obscure form of worshipping Charon in which the smoke of the two shrine lamps symbolizes the rising spirits of the dead as they approach the River Styx. On a critical success, the character knows that to properly light these lanterns, an offering of blood must be given to each lamp before they are lit. A character can collect enough blood to make an offering for one lamp by inflicting 1d4 points of slashing or piercing damage to themselves, but blood from any source (including bodies that aren't more than an hour deceased) works.

Hazard: If the PCs open the double door to area **E3** without first making the blood offerings and lighting both eastern shrine lamps, the quartz altars burst into freezing black fire that carries in it the eldritch properties of the River Styx.

STYGIAN FIRES — HAZARD 12

UNIQUE | COLD | CONJURATION | MAGICAL | TRAP

Stealth DC 35 (master)

Description Freezing black fire bursts from the two quartz altars, filling the room with numbing black flames that scour away memories and emotions as swiftly as they sear flesh and bone.

Disable Thievery DC 30 (master) to sever the links between the door and the lanterns, Religion DC 35 (master) to use prayer to deactivate the divine magic, or *dispel magic* (6th level; counteract DC 30) to counteract the trap

Stygian Fire ↷ (divine, cold, conjuration) **Trigger** The doors to area **E3** are opened without someone making blood offerings and lighting the lanterns. **Effect** Every creature

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in area **E2** must attempt a DC 32 Reflex save.

Critical Success The creature takes no damage.

Success The creature takes 3d10+13 cold damage and is stupefied 1 for 1 minute.

Failure The creature takes 6d10+27 cold damage and is stupefied 1.

Critical Failure The creature takes 6d10+27 cold damage, takes 1d10 persistent cold damage, and is stupefied 2.

Reset The trap resets one minute after the doors to area **E3** are closed.

E3. FALSE STAIR

This chamber is roughly hewn, as if it were never fully finished. Bronze double doors open to the north and west, and a passage exits to the east.

Once intended to lead to a large wing of the dungeon that was to contain priestly quarters, the tunnel to these chambers (as well as the chambers themselves) were indeed never finished. The northern doors open onto an unfinished stairway that climbs 30 feet and dead-ends at a stone wall. If you wish to expand Vordakai's tomb into additional areas, this presents an excellent place to add in more encounters of your own design.

E4. GUARD CHAMBER MODERATE 9

The construction of this chamber differs from those seen previously. The ceiling reaches to a height of twenty feet overhead and appears to bear many fractures in the rock. In the center of the chamber, two columns of mortared stone support a ceiling of strange, delicate arches of stone.

Creature: As soon as any living creature enters this room, a dreadful conjured guardian appears in a burst of foul-smelling damp mist. This monstrosity is an elite piscodaemon, and as soon as it manifests in the room, it speaks telepathically to the intruders, demanding to know in whose name they dare intrude upon the inner sanctum of the Horseman of Death. Any response that includes the name "Vordakai" is enough to persuade the piscodaemon to stand down. However, if anyone attempts to leave via this chamber with the prisoner from area **E5** in tow while the piscodaemon remains, the daemon attacks, even if Vordakai's name is invoked. (The piscodaemon can see invisible creatures, but other methods of hiding the prisoner from **E5** can fool it.)

ELITE PISCODAEMON CREATURE 11

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 6, 58

Initiative Perception +21

E5. PRISON

Masonry columns form shallow alcoves around a central pillar in this flat-roofed chamber. Manacles hang from the walls near ancient bloodstains.

Creature: Slumped in the southern corner of this room is Vordakai's latest prisoner, the curious Nomen centaur Xamanthe Silverfire, daughter of war-priestess Aecora Silverfire. After Xamanthe was defeated and captured by the daemons in area **D2**, Vordakai had her brought to this prison. After ensuring the centaur was under the effects of his paralyzing touch, he stayed long enough to mock her before leaving her to her pain.

Xamanthe remains paralyzed by the lich's touch, her mind in a delirious state brought on by malnutrition and fear. Once every few days or so, Vordakai makes sure to send a minion (usually the piscodaemon in area **E4**) to feed the prisoner a pan of watery gruel—just enough to prevent her from dying of thirst or starvation, but far from enough to allow her to recover from her trials.

The paralysis effect Xamanthe suffers is a permanent affliction, the result of a critical failure against Vordakai's paralyzing touch. Removing this effect requires magic capable of counteracting a magical paralyzing curse (6th level, counteract DC 28). Characters who lack these capabilities can still rescue the paralyzed centaur, but getting her out of the tomb will be more difficult as long as she can't move on her own. A dose of the *panacea* found in area **F4** has an excellent chance to free Xamanthe from paralysis.

If she's rescued, Xamanthe can describe how she broke her people's taboos and disobeyed her mother's commands to investigate the Valley of the Dead, and she can tell of how she took the strange pathway leading up into the mountains. She ruefully admits her curiosity got the better of her, but she stubbornly says that she'd do the same if she had the chance again—though she'd be a bit more cautious! After she was defeated by the leukodaemons in area **D2**—she doesn't realize how fortunate she is to have avoided contracting any diseases from that fight—she has only flashes of memories: periodic visits by a "tentacled fiend" who brought her foul-tasting food, pain-filled dreams and nightmares, and a growing sense of despair. She has a particularly disturbing memory of a nearly skeletal cyclops with a glowing red gem wedged in his otherwise-empty eye socket, who whispered the following to her at some point during her ordeal after she'd been imprisoned here: "You should be honored to be a guest of Vordakai. I shall return once your fear and dread drive all semblance of will and self from your mind, at which point you will thank me for these gifts

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of pain." Xamanthe is relatively certain this hateful creature is the one who paralyzed her, but she knows little more apart from the fact that the name the creature used is the same as one long used by her people as that of a sort of ancestral, legendary boogeyman.



XAMANTHE SILVERFIRE

If invited, she readily joins the PCs in helping them explore the tomb, but she knows she may well be out of her depth here. Without an invitation, she asks only for an escort out of the tomb; from there, she's confident she can make the return journey to her people (provided, of course, she receives healing). She has no gear to offer the PCs in reward, but she does describe to them her magic spear and says that they are welcome to keep it if they find it, wherever it may have ended up in this tomb. (This *+1 cold iron shifting spear* is currently amid the other treasures in area **F4**).

XAMANTHE SILVERFIRE CREATURE 5

Female centaur scout (page 267)
Initiative Perception +13
HP 75 (currently 3)

E6. CENTRAL CRYPT MODERATE 9

This chamber's walls are composed of burial alcoves. All are empty save for assorted bits of pottery.

This was the main burial chamber for Vordakai's minions. All of them were roused when Willas Gundarson disturbed the cairn—some can now be found elsewhere in this tomb, but others made their way out into the surrounding wilderness.

Creatures: Vordakai used *planar binding* to summon a quartet of soul eaters in this chamber as guardians. The eerie monsters float near the central pillars and swiftly move to attack any living creatures that enter the room.

SOUL EATERS (4) CREATURE 7

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 247
Initiative Perception +15

E7. VESTIBULE

The walls of this chamber are covered in plaster and bear frescoes whose colors are still vibrant. This artwork depicts one-eyed humanoids rendered in a sway-backed style.

The frescoes are all in the ancient cyclops style and show scenes relevant to Vordakai's life millennia ago. They provide glimpses into the ancient cyclops culture and would be of great interest to a historian seeking more information about ancient Iobaria's culture.

E8. SACRISTY

A stone bench sits at shoulder height against the far wall of this chamber; upon it rest a number of stone vessels and bronze tools. A human-sized statue of a sway-backed humanoid, its hand clamped over its single eye, stands against the wall.

This chamber was used to prepare bodies for interment and houses an assortment of funerary tools, though none are of particular value. A PC can find the secret door behind the statue by succeeding at a DC 25 Perception check. This secret door is locked with both an excellent mundane lock and a heightened *lock* spell—it requires a successful DC 30 Thievery check to Pick the Lock or a DC 30 Athletics check to Force Open the door.

E9. OCULUS FOCUS

The walls of this room bear eye-shaped patterns and carvings, all of which seem to be looking at a point on the south wall where a single carving of a giant, stylized eye looms. The eye's pupil is an intricately engraved relief roughly the size of the palm of a hand.

The southern eye carving radiates strong conjuration and divination magic, and is part of a specialized *teleportation circle* linked to the *Oculus of Abaddon* carried by Vordakai. If the *Oculus of Abaddon* eyepiece is placed in the engraving's pupil (or if its current wearer merely touches the pupil), the walls of the room glow briefly before the chamber magically teleports everyone within into area **F2**.

If the eye carving is broken (hardness 22, HP 80, BT 40), the *Oculus of Abaddon* cracks inside of Vordakai's eye socket. This sends a searing jolt of pain through the lich's mind, removing the *Oculus*'s ability to use *true seeing* and *familiar farsight*. If the eye carving is fully destroyed, whenever Vordakai attempts to cast a spell, he must first succeed at a DC 5 flat check or the spell is lost. In either event, Vordakai immediately mobilizes and seeks out the PCs after casting his preparatory spells—he uses *dimension door* to enter this room and then begins tracking down the PCs from there.

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E10. TAR POOL MODERATE 9

This wide chamber appears to have been naturally formed; its ceiling rises twenty-five feet and is festooned with stalactites. The stink of sulfur and tar are strong, as a huge lake of bubbling black tar dominates the chamber. From rock outcrops here and there on the walls bubble small springs of milky-looking water from which clouds of steam rise. Across the chamber, a stony shelf provides purchase for a door stoop before a black wooden door swollen in its frame. The broken stumps of two support posts protrude from the rock of the shelf as well as that of the main entrance near the pool's edge, showing where a wooden bridge once spanned the inky soup.

This chamber is quite inhospitable to living creatures—see the Hazard below. A PC can discover the secret door in the northwest wall by succeeding at a DC 25 Perception check. Flight allows a character to navigate this room without being exposed to the tar, of course, as does climbing along the walls (with a successful DC 25 Athletics check).

Originally, a bridge did indeed once allow easier access over the pool from north to south, but when the tomb neared completion, Vordakai had the bridge destroyed to limit access to the chambers beyond.

The mist and steam in the air impose a –2 circumstance penalty to Perception checks in this room.

Creature: While some of Varnhold's citizens have perished as a direct result of Vordakai's necromantic tortures and interrogations, others were not so lucky. One such doomed soul was the wizard Cephal Lorentus, who now serves Vordakai in undeath as a particularly violent undead thrall. In life, Cephal was a middle-aged, bearded man of above-average height. In undeath, his flesh is foul and blackened, in part due to the fact that he's been charged with guarding this room from intruders. He still wears tatters of his wizardly robes, and his head hangs to the side after his neck was broken by Vordakai's crushing grip (he is still capable of hissing out speech or verbal components for his spells, though). While Cephal lost most of his wizardly abilities in the transition to undeath, the arcane spells he had prepared in life have become innate spells as a result of his necromantic transformation.

Cephal stands motionless on the ledge before the door in the southern part of the chamber, impassively watching the room and waiting with endless patience for enemies. His first act upon noticing intruders is to cast *fly* on himself, but he remains at the southern ledge for most of the fight, relying upon his ranged spells to harry the PCs. If anyone closes to melee, he flies out over the tar to maintain distance. The use of *telekinetic maneuver* to shove a PC into the tar pool could be particularly deadly. If reduced to fewer than 60 HP, Cephal takes a moment to cast *sending* to warn Vordakai of the danger—the lich won't react directly to aid Cephal (who thereafter fights until destroyed), but Vordakai does prepare for the PCs' arrival as a result.



CEPHAL LORENTUS CREATURE 9

UNIQUE NE MEDIUM UNDEAD

Unique male undead

Perception +18; darkvision

Languages Common, Draconic, Hallit, Jotun, Sylvan

Skills Arcana +20, Diplomacy +17, Nature +19, Society +19, Survival +17

Str +0, **Dex** +2, **Con** +0, **Int** +6, **Wis** +2, **Cha** +4

Items *+1 dagger*, *ring of wizardry I*, tattered robes

AC 28; **Fort** +15, **Ref** +15, **Will** +21

HP 140, negative healing; **Immunities** death effects, disease, paralyzed, poison, unconscious; **Resistances** bludgeoning 10, piercing 10

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ *dagger* +18 (agile, finesse, magical, versatile S), **Damage** 1d4+2 piercing plus 4d6 negative

Melee ❖ jaws +15, **Damage** 2d6+2 piercing plus 4d6 negative

Arcane Innate Spells DC 29, attack +20; **5th** *fireball*, *sending*; **4th** *dispel magic*, *fly*, *resist energy*; **3rd** *lightning bolt*, *slow*, *vampiric touch*; **2nd** *acid arrow*, *mirror image*, *telekinetic maneuver*; **1st** *command*, *feather fall*, *magic missile*, *mending*, *unseen servant*; **Cantrips (5th)** *detect magic*, *electric arc*, *light*, *message*, *shield*

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VORDAKAI'S TOMB: THIRD LEVEL
ONE SQUARE = 10 FEET

Feasting Bite If Cephal critically succeeds at a jaws Strike against a foe or successfully hits a helpless foe with a jaws Strike, he gnaws upon the foe's flesh and drains its life force to bolster his own health. This restores 3d6 HP to Cephal (he gains any excess HP as temporary HP, and also becomes quickened 1 during his next turn; he may use his extra action only to make a jaws Strike).

Hazard: The lake of bubbling tar that fills most of this chamber steams and sputters a few feet below the various ledges in this room. The tar is only 3 feet deep, but moving through it counts as greater difficult hazardous terrain that inflicts 2d6 fire damage each turn. *Water walk* allows a character to move across the surface of the tar at normal speed but doesn't protect from the heat hazard presented.

In addition, the fumes put off by the bubbling lake of tar in this cavern has made the air itself toxic to breathe, causing eyes to water, throats to burn, and lungs to ache within a few seconds. All breathing creatures who inhale the air in this chamber are automatically exposed to the toxins and must attempt a DC 26 Fortitude save. On a failure, they become sickened 2; on a critical failure, they also become enfeebled 1 for 1 hour.

SCALDING TAR LAKE — HAZARD 9

UNCOMMON | COMPLEX | ENVIRONMENTAL

Stealth DC +0 (the tar lake is blatantly obvious, and its effects occur near the end of each round)

Description The bubbling tar churns and seethes, periodically bursting in a burning hot splatter of scalding sludge and gas.

Disable DC 30 Survival check to throw rocks or other bits of debris into areas within the tar lake that are about to burst, allowing the lake to vent harmlessly for that round (on a critical success, this prevents the lake from venting for 3 rounds); permanently disabling the tar pit would require powerful magic or long-term engineering projects (subject to the GM's discretion).

Scalding Burst ↻ **Trigger** A creature attempts to move through the tar; **Effect** A scalding burst of hot tar burns the creature, which must immediately attempt a DC 28 Reflex save.

Critical Success The creature takes no damage.

Success The creature takes 3d6 fire damage.

Failure The creature takes 6d6 fire damage and 1d6 persistent fire damage.

Critical Failure The creature takes 9d6 fire damage, 2d6 persistent fire damage and takes a –10-foot status penalty to its Speed as long as it continues to take the persistent fire damage from the hot tar clinging to it.

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Routine (1 action) The bubbling lake of tar churns and sputters. One randomly determined target within 5 feet of the tar lake is targeted by a Scalding Burst.

E11. SECONDARY ENTRANCE

Hewn stairs rise to the north from this room, and the air is foul with the stink of sulfur and tar.

The air in this room and the hallway leading up to area **C4** to the west is foul smelling due to air seeping through the secret door's cracks from the tar lake , but not quite noxious enough to cause problems. A PC can discover the secret door in the southeast wall by succeeding at a DC 25 Perception check.



WILLAS GUNDERSON

E12. SECONDARY CRYPTS LOW 9

This crypt stretches into darkness. The floor is strewn with rubble and the filth of opened graves. Sprawled on the floor is a fairly fresh corpse of a middle-aged Ulfen man, no more than a week or two old.

These secondary crypts once held additional servants of Vordakai, not all of whom were converted into festering undead horrors. The bones of the rest of them lie scattered upon the floor. The Ulfen corpse is none other than Willas Gundarson, who recovered from Vordakai's beckoning enchantment just as the feasting began in room **E13**. Willas retreated here and fought valiantly for his life with nothing more than the hunting knife at his belt, but he ultimately fell to the undead cyclopes.

Creature: A combination of horror at the fate of his fellow colonists and overwhelming guilt over his role in bringing it about caused Willas to give in to despair as he finally fell to his attackers. His troubled soul now haunts the crypt as a powerful dread wraith. He doesn't leave this chamber but mercilessly attacks anything that enters. The dread wraith has no memories of life and seethes now only with a hatred of the living. He fights until destroyed.

WILLAS GUNDARSON CREATURE 10

Elite dread wraith (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 6, 298)

Initiative Perception +21

E13. FEAST HALL MODERATE 10

Thick pillars ascend to this large chamber's twenty-foot-high ceiling, while a wide stone staircase climbs to a darkened gallery above. A long table surrounded by chairs sits in the middle of the room.

The purpose of the chamber is apparent from the great stone table running across its center. Dozens of seats have been set about this massive affair and propped upon them is a thing of horror. Each chair holds the corpse of a human locked in its death throes, its mouth agape in anguish, the top of its cranium brutally removed, and the brains within excised.

The dead bodies are 33 of Varnhold's colonists. If the PCs have interacted with any of Varnhold's citizens, a PC who succeeds at a DC 15 Society check to Recall Knowledge can recognize a few faces. No check is needed to recognize the body seated at the head of the table: Maegar Varn himself. Also

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present is a corpse wearing the trappings of a priest of the faith of Erastil—Maegar's longtime companion, the cleric Caspar Morgarion. All of these poor souls are victims of the cyclops lich Vordakai. Unlike the lich's undead minions, which are compelled to feed out of their necromantic nature, Vordakai feeds on the brains of the recently dead not to satisfy an aberrant hunger for flesh but out of a darker hunger for knowledge. Consuming the brain of a living creature doesn't grant the lich increases to his mental ability scores or other quantifiable boons, but he does have the ability to absorb snatches and bits of memory from those he feeds upon—yet another way in which he is fitting himself to the new world he has found himself in.

This adventure assumes that the victims in this room have already been judged by Pharasma and cannot be raised from the dead, but if you wish to allow the PCs to resurrect Maegar Varn, Caspar Morgarion, or any other villagers, feel free to do so; such resurrected NPCs will doubtless become loyal allies to the party in return for the mercy granted.

The stairs to the east lead upward to area **F1**.

Creatures: Guarding this chamber are four cyclops zombies. When they notice the PCs, the undead cyclopes spread out and attack, fighting and pursuing until destroyed (although they won't pursue the PCs out of the tomb entirely).

CYCLOPS ZOMBIES (4) CREATURE 7

Page 275

Initiative Perception +8

F1. BALCONY

This balcony has no rail and overlooks room **E13**, 30 feet below. A PC can find the secret door to area **F3** by succeeding at a DC 25 Perception check.

F2. OCULUS CHAMBER

The walls of this octagonal chamber, which vaults to a twenty-foot-high ceiling, are composed of multiple slabs of opaque, white crystal fitted together to form a dome in the distinctive shape of an inverted eye, its gaze focused into the room below. This white crystal gleams with a subdued moonlike glow. The walls of the chamber are covered with arcane symbols, stylized line art, and images of cyclopes. A twenty-foot-diameter circle is incised into the stone of the floor directly beneath the great eye-shaped dome.

This chamber is sacred to the daemonic demigods of Abaddon and has existed longer even than the tomb itself—this chamber being one of the central reasons Vordakai chose this site for his tomb in the first place. His only change to the room was to eradicate the previous wall carvings and replace them with the current designs; the original carvings were too horrid for even the cyclops to stomach. This room is where Vordakai discovered the *Oculus of Abaddon*, and it's the original force behind Vordakai's descent from cruelty into true evil.

The Oculus Chamber radiates an aura of overwhelming conjuration and divination and serves as a focal point of daemonic energies in ways that even Vordakai does not yet fully understand. A character who attempts to Identify Magic in this chamber can, with a successful DC 30 Occult or Religion check, confirm the basic function of the room. A critical success at this check confirms to the PC that the planar boundaries here between the Material Plane and Abaddon are unusually tenuous.



CYCLOPS ZOMBIE

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F3. POOL GUARDIAN — MODERATE 9

A burbling fountain and pool that stinks of sulfur occupies the center of this chamber. A shallow channel cut into the stone of the floor passes beneath bronze double doors, funneling the foul-smelling water out to the south.

This chamber, the foyer to Vordakai's throne room, contains a naturally occurring sulfur spring. The water tastes horrible, and anyone who drinks it must succeed at a DC 25 Fortitude save or be sickened 1 (sickened 2 on a critical failure).

Creature: Dwelling within the sulfurous pool is an elemental creature twisted by the archdaemons an age ago and left here as a guardian: a neutral evil elemental tsunami that obeys the commands of anyone who wears the *Oculus of Abaddon*. Vordakai has commanded it to attack anyone who enters the chamber; if he casts *dominate* on a PC, he takes a moment to inform the elemental tsunami that this victim is to be allowed to pass unharmed as well. Otherwise, the tsunami fights to the death.

ELEMENTAL TSUNAMI — CREATURE 11

Pathfinder Bestiary 153
Initiative Perception +22

F4. THRONE OF BONES — SEVERE 9

A channel of sulfurous water runs down the center of this chamber into a placid pool tinged in red and surrounded by kneeling forms. Just inside the room, a small stone shrine decorated with several freshly severed human heads sits in a small alcove to the west. To the east, a collapsed staircase leads nowhere. Deeper into the room, a large workspace to the north houses a large stone table. Across from it to the west, a hideous throne made of bones looms over the pool. At the southern end of the room, a staircase rises into the darkness and a hallway leads out of sight.

This is Vordakai's throne room—the chamber wherein he slept for countless ages and where he now toils on new plans of destruction at the behest of visions granted by the Four Horsemen. A PC who succeeds at a DC 20 Religion check to Recall Knowledge identifies the shrine as being dedicated to the Four Horsemen. The heads on it are recently "released" Varnhold victims; their bodies are the forms huddled around the pool, eviscerated such that their entrails are laid out in intricate patterns sacred to Vordakai's daemonic overlords. The ruined staircase once led to the top of the cairn, but it's now collapsed and useless.

The workspace to the east consists of Vordakai's library and laboratory. Here, the PCs can find numerous stone tablets, crumbling scrolls, and even some strangely intact ancient tomes, all of which concern the worship of the Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse and methods by which to engineer great disasters in the world to feed their insatiable gluttony for souls. Among these records are several newer notes concerning Vordakai's confusion about how the world has changed in the last 10,000 or so years, his frustration at having forgotten so much of his knowledge and wizardly skills in that span of time, and his desire to learn more about this new world before he attempts to resurrect his empire. The abduction of Varnhold to use their citizens as research tools is but the first step in this mission. It should be obvious to anyone who studies the information here that, while it would be many years before Vordakai was in a position where he was ready to attempt his plans for the world, if the lich had been left to his own devices, he could have swiftly become a terrible danger to both Brevoy and the River Kingdoms—and perhaps beyond. All of these notes are written in Cyclops.

The hallway to the southwest remains unfinished to this day and leads nowhere.

Creatures: Vordakai sits upon his throne of bones in this chamber, staring into his bloody oracular pool and arrogantly awaiting the PCs while he pores over one of his tomes and puzzles out the mysteries of this strange new world he has awakened into. The cyclops lich's power has waned over the centuries, but he remains a powerful foe; his tactics in combat can be found alongside his statistics on page 606.

VORDAKAI — CREATURE 12

Page 606
Initiative Perception +23

Treasure: Beyond his spellbook and gear, Vordakai keeps his treasures in neatly organized mounds and piles behind his throne. The majority of this treasure consists of ancient coins (24 pp, 200 gp, and 1,300 sp) and various art objects altogether worth an additional 200 gp—among this collection is the 20 gp "bracelet" stolen by Willas after Horagnamon retrieved it for Vordakai. In addition to the ancient treasures, several magic items Vordakai found on his victims can be found here. These include a pair of *eyes of the eagle*, a *moderate sturdy shield*, a *greater hat of disguise*, a pouch holding three *panaceas*, and a *+1 cold iron shifting spear* (taken from Xamanthe).

Perhaps an even greater treasure can be found in the area that serves as Vordakai's laboratory. The preserved knowledge of ancient Casmaron to be found here is contained in dozens of stone tablets weighing nearly 1,000 pounds in all. The tablets are worth 500 gp to a scholar of this ancient land (such as Tamerak

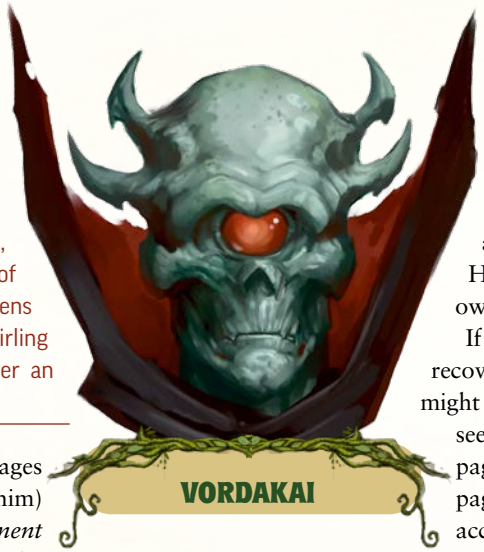
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Elenark—see page 529—though he would need several weeks to arrange for the funds to be brought to the PCs' capital).

F5. DUNGEON OF SOULS

The walls of this room are filled with stone niches, each bearing a number of strange glass jars. Each jar is about a foot tall, is stoppered with a clot of black wax, and contains a swirling plume of glowing white smoke. There are dozens of these jars on display, and the swirling light each emits gives this chamber an otherworldly feel.



VORDAKAI

Vordakai built this chamber ages ago, using his (now lost to him) knowledge of the *imprisonment* ritual to build a prison in which he planned to build a sort of "library" of experts to keep on hand to interrogate as needed. Although the ability to use *imprisonment* is now beyond his ability, the jars in this room each retained the capability to absorb a soul. A PC who succeeds at a DC 26 check to Identify Magic can discern the basic use of this room (including the fact that the jars contain trapped souls that can be released by breaking or opening them). A PC who critically succeeds at this check reveals that the jars were enhanced long ago via use of an *imprisonment* ritual, but since they currently contain souls, they cannot be used to do so again.

Vordakai managed to create 42 of these soul receptacles before he was defeated, and today, each holds a citizen of Varnhold, among them Maestro **Ervil Pendrod** (LN male human bard 5). A character who touches one of these jars can communicate telepathically with the soul trapped inside. By breaking, opening, or simply removing a jar from this room, the jar becomes nonmagical and disgorges its trapped soul in a plume of smoke, re-forming into the trapped victim's physical body in the same condition they were in when they were captured.

The prisoners are extremely grateful if rescued and confused about how they got here. While mournful for those among their number who have already been slain (particularly their leader, Maegar Varn), they remain quite anxious to escape this prison and return to Varnhold.

CONCLUDING THE ADVENTURE

With the destruction of Vordakai and most (if not all) of his monstrous minions, an ancient threat has finally been expunged from the Stolen Lands. This is far from a minor accomplishment—not only do the surviving villagers of Varnhold swiftly pledge their loyalty to the PCs and their nation, but the Nomen centaurs are impressed as well and vow to live peacefully with the human settlers in deference to the great work the PCs have accomplished. All the centaurs ask is that they be left the Nomen Heights (zone 8) as part of their own territory.

If the PCs rescued Xamanthe or recovered *Skybolt*, the Nomen centaurs might have further rewards for the PCs; see the Rescuing Xamanthe quest on page 269 and the *Skybolt* quest on page 267. In any event, the PCs have accomplished something neither Taldor nor Brevoy could achieve: peace with the Nomen centaurs.

As for Brevoy to the north, events continue to escalate as tensions between Issia and Rostland grow, while to the west, another kingdom is most assuredly not ignoring the growing power in the eastern Stolen Lands. Self-proclaimed King Irovetti of Pitax has already defeated and displaced the Brevic agents who dared attempt to colonize the Glenebon Uplands and the Slough, and as the PCs' nation grows, so does Irovetti's jealousy—jealousy destined someday soon to ignite a new war in the River Kingdoms, where blood will be traded for blood until only one leader rules the Stolen Lands.

ANNEXING VARNHOLD

With the rescue of Varnhold's citizens and the defeat of the spriggans and Vordakai, the PCs have earned more than the gratitude of the devastated town. Before the vanishing, Varnhold had established a sizable territory of its own, including a road along much of the Kiravoy Bridge and a fair amount of farmland. By rescuing Varnhold's remaining citizens from captivity in area **F5** and gaining the allegiance of these citizens, the PCs can readily annex Varnhold. If they do, they immediately integrate the town as if they'd achieved a critical success on a Pledge of Fealty activity (page 520). Details of Varnhold's resources and structures appear on page 90 in Chapter 2. Furthermore, all checks on Region activities taken in hexes adjacent to Varnhold have their results improved one degree of success, representing eager help from the rescued citizens. In time, Varnhold will recover from its vanishing, provided the PCs continue to provide for the citizens.

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CHAPTER 7

BLOOD FOR BLOOD

BY NEIL SPICER

PART 1: TROUBLE IN TATZLFORD 288
The PCs should be 10th level when they begin to build their armies and move to defend Tatzlford.

PART 2: FORT DRELEV 300
The PCs should be 11th level before they begin their infiltration of Fort Drelev.

PART 3: THE TWICE-BORN WARLORD 318
The PCs should be 12th level before exploring Armag's Tomb.

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PART 1:

TROUBLE IN TATZLFORD

More than 40 years ago, when a cabal of cultists known as the Sisters of the Bloodshot Eye fled Brevoy after their sinister actions united the populace against them, they foretold the coming of Armag the Twice-Born. According to their prediction, the Twice-Born would be a child formed from the spirit of the original Armag, a warlord who terrorized the northern plains during the Age of Destiny. However, because prophecy had ceased being a trustworthy source of prognostication with the onset of the Age of Lost Omens, the foretelling of Armag the Twice-Born took shape as little more than a wishful curse uttered against the Sisters' enemies. So when no reborn warlord rose to give flesh and fury to the cult's prediction, the sisters did not remain idle: they vowed to take an active hand in forcing their prediction to come true and retreated into the Stolen Lands where they abducted a Tiger Lord out on his first hunt. For years, they raised their pawn in the ways of spite and rage and gave him the name Armag.

The Sisters convinced their pawn that the spirit of the original Armag lay within him, and that they would serve as his guides to aid him in setting his ancestral might free. By advising and strengthening Armag, they planned to guide him to his rightful place among his people, uniting them to fulfill their own prophecy and strike back at Brevoy with an army of nomadic warriors eager to please their reincarnated warlord of old. Armag embraced these goals as his own, aspiring to lead the Tiger Lords. Empowered by the deceptive

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touch of Gyronna's faithful, he slew a Tiger Lord boss and assumed the mantle of leadership.

Then settlers arrived from Brevoy. A group of soldiers and diplomats led by Baron Hannis Drelev spread south into Tiger Lord lands along the East Sellen River. These settlers not only established a fort on the shore of Lake Hooktongue, but they also sought out and looted several ancient tombs and burial sites sacred to the Tiger Lords. The final insult came when Drelev's soldiers tried to establish an unfair alliance with the Tiger Lords. Armag saw through their trickery and ordered his people to attack, but he underestimated his enemy, assuming that "soft diplomats" would not be able to stand in combat. Drelev's soldiers proved an able match for Armag's kin and, after three nights of battle, the Tiger Lords fell back. Not only did Armag see his destiny of raiding Brevoy endangered, but suddenly he and his people were on the defensive, losing territory to Drelev's expansion. However, as Armag fell back deeper into the hills, he found a new ally from an unexpected source: the realm of Pitax.

King Irovetti, ruler of Pitax, had already become concerned with Rostland's expansion into the Stolen Lands, and when he heard rumors that other Brevic agents were expanding south into more distant borderlands and displacing some of the Tiger Lords—a culture Pitax had often clashed with over borders—his paranoid fears saw opportunity. If Irovetti's forces and the Tiger Lords could work together, they could swiftly defeat these intruders. And if events could be engineered so that the Tiger Lords were at the front of the battle, the bulk of the losses would be from among their troops, further reducing opposition to Pitax's slow but eventual expansion into the Stolen Lands.

And so Irovetti and his guards traveled northeast to contact the Tiger Lords and establish a truce. Working together, they descended upon Fort Drelev with a fury and conquered the invaders in a single bloodless wave, for as Hannis Drelev saw the combined forces of Armag's warriors eager for revenge and Irovetti's armies readying their siege engines, he made a fateful choice. Always a realist, he saw immediate surrender as the only option to save his life.

The craven noble sent three riders under a flag of truce to plead with Armag and Irovetti to spare his region, proposing instead to ally with the bandits and to turn control of Fort Drelev to them. His offer to provide information on Rostland and PCs' kingdom intrigued Irovetti but frustrated Armag, who had hoped for more bloodshed. To force the loyalty—and obeisance—of Drelev's people, and to help appease the frustrated Tiger Lords, Irovetti accepted Drelev's surrender, but only on the condition that Drelev's settlers hand over five of their own as hostages until Drelev himself could prove his loyalty through servitude to Pitax.

Over the objections of his own men, Drelev did as Irovetti requested, commanding his senior officers to give their eldest sons and daughters to the warlord. However, one captain—a lord-knight named Terrion Numesti—refused. Drelev chose to make an example of Numesti by throwing him in jail and handing his daughter over to the Tiger Lords. Drelev justified this action to his people by assuring everyone it would save their lives and reiterating Armag's promises that the hostages would eventually be returned unharmed.

In truth, Drelev cares little for anyone or anything that doesn't advance his personal agenda. Jealous of the success garnered by the neighboring kingdoms—particularly that of the PCs—he believes his alliance with the Tiger Lords and Pitax will finally give him the means to take over the entire frontier. And with such a large nation under his command, he'll be able not only to strike back against the Tiger Lords and Pitax, but he will perhaps be able to expand his control into Brevoy itself. In an attempt to sweeten the alliance, Drelev has returned several of the artifacts and treasures he and his soldiers looted from Tiger Lord burial tombs, something that Armag quite appreciated.

When Armag returned to his people with these artifacts, though, the Sisters recognized them as ancient relics in the style of the nomadic warriors of the original Armag's time. Correctly assuming the barrow mounds these treasures came from would hold even greater treasures that could legitimize and spread their champion's influence over his people, the Sisters advised the Twice-Born warlord to claim them as his own. To encourage his choice, they cited legends of how a Kellid shaman laid the original Armag to rest within the same hills along with his famous sword, *Ovinrbaane*, a weapon blessed by Gorum to win any war and triumph in every conflict.

KINGDOM IN THE BACKGROUND

With the PC's defeat of Vordakai and the rescue of Varnhold, that town joins the PCs' kingdom. With this success, the citizens finally put behind them the fears of the Season of Bloom, and the kingdom enters a growth spurt, expanding south up to the Tors and north beyond the Narlmarches. But as the kingdom grows, rumors and whispers that Pitax is growing nervous about their neighbor begin to spread. When running the troll attack on Tatzlford, simply have the mass combat elements play out in the background; focus instead on the PCs' fight against Ameon Trask and his troll king allies. By the end of the adventure, the kingdom expands north of Hooktongue and talks of annexing Drelev may be afoot.

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Greetings, my lieges!

Would that I had the opportunity to contact you via missive in gentler times. Since its founding, Tatzlford has faced many challenges, but recent rumors of a much more disturbing sort abound. A woman named Kisandra Numesti has come to Tatzlford bearing warnings that, if they are to be believed, indicate we may face a terrible threat. She speaks of armies of bandits, hordes of Tiger Lords—and worse!—organizing to the west beyond Hooktongue Slough. To date we have had no trouble with these elements, but this woman is quite convincing. She tells us an army from Drelev is marching on Tatzlford. If this is true, we will need your aid in defending our homes. Please come as soon as you can.

—In good faith, your faithful friend and humble servant,
Mayor Loy Rezbin

HANDOUT 7-1

Now, while Armag is distracted with attempts to delve the tombs of his ancestors and Irovetti has returned to Pitax to prepare for his next audacity—an attempt to lure the PCs out of their kingdom so he can attack their homes in secret (a treachery detailed in full in the next chapter)—Lord Drelev has spent much of his time plotting and brooding. He hopes Armag meets a terrible fate in his people's tombs, but he isn't aware that Armag intends to collect the ancient weapon *Ovinrbaane*—and therefore Gorum's blessing—and use it to raise his own army. Left unchecked, a mighty champion of war will walk Golarion again, brushing aside all opposition in the River Kingdoms and beyond.

TATZLFORD

This chapter begins after the PCs have solved the problems facing Varnhold and, hopefully, have not only rescued many of that village's citizens from the clutches of the cyclops lich Vordakai but have also secured a treaty of peace with Nomen centaurs. Whatever the resolution of the previous chapter, give the PCs some time to pursue Downtime activities or explore more of the Stolen Lands. You can start this chapter the day after the PCs solve the vanishing at Varnhold, or you can start a year (or two, or five) later—whatever works best for your campaign. Of course, if your players seem anxious to get on with Kingmaker's story or are eager to begin exploring Hooktongue Slough, such desires should also trigger the beginning of this chapter.

In Chapter 4, the PCs were likely approached by an energetic couple—the Rezbins—who offered to establish a village deep in the Narlmarches at a ford on the Skunk River (located at the site where a pair of mated tatzlwyrms previously dwelt in encounter area **GB16**). If the PCs have managed to claim several hexes in the Narlmarches, including the one containing Tatzlford, everything is already set up for you. If the PCs haven't officially integrated Tatzlford into their kingdom yet, it remains a freehold; the event that kicks off this chapter will provide the PCs the opportunity to integrate it into their kingdom.

This chapter details Tatzlford as a thriving settlement 466 residents strong. If the PCs have developed Tatzlford differently, adjust the map and other information in this section as needed to reflect your campaign. You could even have these incidents take place in a different settlement altogether.

Once you're ready to begin the main adventure, a short message from Tatzlford's mayor, Loy Rezbin,

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is delivered via messenger bird to the PCs, indicating treachery and trouble brewing in the village. This missive is presented as **Handout 7–1**.

If the PCs come to the settlement's defense and save it from the attack before they've added the settlement to their kingdom, Loy Rezbin pledges Tatzlford to the PCs; treat this as if the PCs had achieved a critical success in a Pledge of Fealty activity with Tatzlford. At that time, Rezbin sends a gift of lumber and supplies to the PCs; their kingdom gains 5 Lumber Commodities, and at the start of the next Kingdom turn, they gain 2 bonus RP dice.



LOY REZBIN

Tatzlford's stats below represent the current state of the settlement—it has grown from a village into a town since it was founded during Chapter 4. Currently, Tatzlford has one water border with a wooden bridge, and occupies four blocks of its Urban Grid. All but one of the town's 16 lots contain structures (note that some of these structures take up more than 1 lot): 4 house lots, a brewery, a festival hall, a general store, an inn, a library, a popular tavern, a shrine, a smithy, a specialized artisan, and a town hall.

TATZLFORD — SETTLEMENT 3

NG TOWN

Imperiled forest town

Government autocracy (mayor)

Population 466 (426 humans, 18 half-elves, 12 half-orcs, 10 other)

Languages Common, Hallit

Religions Erastil

Threats Ameon Trask's warband, dangerous Narlmarch denizens and predators

Coren Lawry (NG male human fighter 3) Captain of the Tatzlford guard.

Emraeli Emfaun (CG female elf wizard 4) Librarian and Tatzlford's teacher.

Latricia Rezbin (LG female human cleric of Erastil 5) Priestess of Erastil and counselor of Tatzlford.

Loy "Tanner" Rezbin (NG male human ranger 5) Mayor and founder of Tatzlford.

GATHERING ARMIES

With this chapter, the PCs are presented with the first scripted war encounter in the *Kingmaker Adventure Path*. War encounters are streamlined encounters that resolve mass combats; they are fought by entire armies rather than individual characters. Full rules for building armies, maintaining them, hiring specialized armies, and playing out war encounters appear in Appendix 3 (starting on page 566). This chapter assumes the PCs have not yet started to build up armies, and that they will rely upon defenders already in place at Tatzlford to handle an attack by a band of trolls and mercenaries, after which the PCs should realize they'll need to start building up their own kingdom defenses over the following Kingdom turns. The Adventure Path doesn't confront the party with war encounters again until the next chapter, which should give the PCs plenty of time to build up their military, even if they haven't begun that process until now.

WATCHING THE BORDERS

If Drelev's forces must pass through areas directly controlled by the PCs' kingdom before reaching the hex that contains Tatzlford, the PCs have a chance to learn of the attack even before Rezbin's urgent missive reaches the PCs. In this case, ask the PCs to attempt a DC 27 check using one of the following Kingdom skills: Defense, Exploration, Intrigue, or Magic. On a success, they'll hear rumors that a large band of mercenaries was spotted in the western Narlmarches. On a critical success, they'll hear that those forces consist of soldiers, Tiger Lords, and some trolls, and that they seem to be headed for Tatzlford. In this case, the PCs should have time to reach Tatzlford with any armies they bring along with them in ample time to bolster the town's defenses, and they might even intercept the courier bearing Rezbin's message en route!

TATZLFORD FEATURES

Tatzlford is a cozy town located in encounter area **GB16**, in a large clearing deep in the Narlmarch woods, just south of a ford in the Skunk River. The beginnings of a road lead north and south from the town, but unless the PCs have taken the time to further develop these roads, they do not go far before petering out at outlying homes and farms.

Tatzlford is governed by mayor Loy "Tanner" Rezbin, a retired ranger, although most of the important decisions are made by his wife Latricia, the town's priestess of Erastil. Together, they founded Tatzlford with the intent to help build up the PCs' new nation as it rises in the Stolen Lands. The settlement has attracted settlers from all around, primarily from Pitax, Mivon, and Rostland. A small wooden fort sits at the heart of the town, but the settlement has outgrown the defense

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this walled complex can provide. Construction of a larger stone wall around the village has been started but is not yet complete. The map of Tatzlford indicates several locations of interest, each of which is described here in brief.

A1. Able's Inn

A no-nonsense man named Able Morkentian runs this cozy two-story inn. The building has only five rooms, but they're all clean.

A2. Gnori's Gems

Gnori Berwekertan is Tatzlford's only gnome resident—a fact that he takes a strange bit of pride in, often introducing himself as "Tatzlford's only official gnome." A gifted gem cutter, he's told no one in town that he's on the run from a thieves' guild in distant Tamran. He hopes to build his humble workshop into a true luxury store.

A3. Ironhand Smithy

Kole Jhargee, a mountain of a man, provides for all of Tatzlford's smithing needs. He and his family are from Brevoy, but he has few kind words to say about his previous home.

A4. River Run Alehouse

Owned by Killough Margrom (also the proprietor of Tatzlford's only tavern), this small brewery has already established a reputation for producing fine huckleberry mead and sweet ale.

A5. Skunk River Bridge

Built over the ford in the Skunk River where once a pair of tatzlwyrms laired, this wooden bridge is sturdy and safe.

A6. Tatzlford General Store

Karl Roschinder owns and runs Tatzlford's general store. He keeps several chairs on his front porch to encourage locals to gather, gossip, and relax, and he even supplies them with free lunches when the mood strikes him.

A7. Tatzlford Library

This building houses a sizable collection of important works focusing on history, literature, and mathematics. The library also functions as a school for a few dozen children. The teacher and librarian is a lonely (but still generally quite pleasant and kindly) elven woman named Emraeli Emfaun.

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A8. Tatzlford Lodge

This lodge is a holy shrine devoted to Erastil. Its substantial communal area has seen frequent use for town meetings of late, as the smaller chamber in the town hall can no longer fit enough people. The temple is overseen by Latricia Rezbin.

A9. Tatzlford Fort/Town Hall

The fort at the heart of town is used mostly as storage and as a residence for the village's mayor, Loy Rezbin.

A10. Tatzlwyrm Tavern

Primarily serving locally brewed ale and mead, and with a menu that never strays far from venison and fish, the Tatzlwyrm Tavern's claim to fame is a taxidermy tatzlwyrm coiled above the bar.

A11. Thrillseekers

The newest business to appear in town, this gaudy structure presents a facade promising games of chance and fun. It also is building up a reputation as a brothel, spurring many local arguments about who goes there.

ARRIVING AT TATZLFORD

As soon as the PCs arrive, they immediately gain the attention of everyone in town unless they do so stealthily or undercover. Captain Coren Lawry, commander of the Tatzlford guard, meets the PCs on the outskirts of town and quickly offers to escort them to the Tatzlford Lodge so they can meet Mayor Rezbin and speak with the woman who has brought them news of war. He can also give the PCs a quick tour of the town, pointing out shops and key sites, so they can learn their way around town.

Mayor Rezbin does his best to greet the PCs in a manner befitting their status as the highest dignitaries to ever visit Tatzlford. Short and unassuming, he has put on weight since retiring and seems ill-suited for the stress and rigors of governing a settlement. Despite this, Rezbin comes across as likable, down-to-earth, and loyal. He has no hidden agenda, only a desire to do what's right for those who put their trust in him. He is accompanied by his wife Latricia.

WARNING FROM THE WEST

Even as the PCs arrive in Tatzlford, a sizable force of bandits, Tiger Lords, and hired trolls approach the town from the west through the Narlmarches. Led by a man named Ameon Trask, this assault force is Baron Drelev's first attempt to impress King Irovetti by launching an attack against the PCs' kingdom.

Yet several days before this small army set out on their march, a woman named **Kisandra Numesti** (NG female human rogue 5), the youngest—and most free-spirited—daughter of a knight and aristocrat stationed at Fort Drelev, made a risky decision. Her father, Terrion Numesti, was the commander of Fort Drelev's garrison until he refused to ally with Armag and allow his oldest daughter Tamary to serve as a hostage. After Kisandra's father was thrown into Drelev's dungeon and her sister was given to the Tiger Lords, she fled Fort Drelev and came to Tatzlford to warn them of the imminent attack.

After the PCs meet with the mayor, Kisandra presents herself to the PCs and is willing to answer any questions they may have. Her responses to likely questions are listed below.

Who are you? "My name is Kisandra Numesti. I come from the Drelev Demesne, northwest of here on



KISANDRA

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INTERCEPTING THE ENEMY

The PCs may decide not to wait for the fight to come to Tatzlford, and instead ride out with their army to intercept (or even ambush) Ameon Trask and his forces on the march. If the PCs have only Tatzlford's army to attack with, Rezbin is wary as he rightfully points out that the town's guards would be at a severe disadvantage in an open battlefield; by using the town's fortifications as defenses, they'll even up the odds.

If the PCs insist, Rezbin relents, especially if the PCs have brought their own forces. If the PCs ride out to try to intercept the enemy, have them attempt a DC 27 Exploration or Wilderness Kingdom skill check. On a success, they find the army camped in a large woodland clearing. On a critical success, they gain a +4 circumstance bonus on their initiative checks in the resulting war encounter. On a failure, they don't find the army and, upon returning to Tatzlford, find Trask's forces have seized the town; in this event, Trask's forces gain the defensive advantages of the town, rather than the PCs' forces.

If the PCs fight in a forest clearing, the battlefield offers no terrain advantages for either side.

the far side of Hooktongue Slough—it was established by Baron Hannis Drelev of Brevoy. My father is Lord Terrion Numesti, a knight who once served the baron but then rebelled against him and was thrown into the dungeon as punishment. I came here to warn you of an imminent attack on this town."

Who's attacking Tatzlford? "Baron Drelev's troops, Tiger Lords, and trolls! I left Fort Drelev as soon as I could and raced here to warn you. They can't be that far behind me—a few days at most!"

Why would Drelev attack us? "To save himself. And so he can claim everything you've built. Drelev surrendered to the Tiger Lords and the Lord of Pitax so they wouldn't overrun his kingdom. I suspect he sees attacking you as a way to prove his worth to his new master, King Irovetti, but he's long been jealous of your success. He covets just about anything he deems more valuable than what he already has. I'm afraid your kingdom is no exception."

Why did your father rebel? "My father refused to play along with Lord Drelev when the Tiger Lords demanded a tribute of several nobles—including my sister—as hostages. Baron Drelev has lost his way—he wants only to impress King Irovetti by allying with the Tiger Lords and defeating your kingdom in hopes of becoming a vassal state to Pitax, and my father would have none of it. So Drelev threw him in prison and sent my sister to the Tiger Lords anyway. The monster!"

How do we know you're not trying to trick us? "Any loyalty I may have once owed to Baron Drelev died as soon as he sent my sister off to those murderers and imprisoned my father for refusing to obey his orders. I hoped that by warning you I might earn your favor and obtain aid in freeing my family, but even if you choose not to help me, I can't sit idly by and watch as the baron's forces attack this town."

PREPARING FOR BATTLE

Kisandra's estimate is accurate, and it won't be long before Fort Drelev's forces arrive at Tatzlford and launch their attack. Without reinforcements, the battle against the army will be tough, but not impossible, and its ultimate success will depend heavily on the success of the PCs' own simultaneous attack on the army's leadership. If the PCs traveled with an army or armies of their own, they can add those forces to the battle, but otherwise there may not be enough time to deploy any of their other armies to this location. Normally, the Deploy Army activity must be taken during a Kingdom turn, but if you wish, you can allow the PCs to attempt to Deploy Armies that are relatively close to Tatzlford. On a failure, the army won't arrive in time (and on a critical failure the army becomes lost as normal for a Deploy Army activity). On a success, if the army had to travel no more than 2 hexes, it arrives at Tatzlford in time to aid in the battle, while on a critical success, an army that had to travel no more than 4 hexes can arrive in time. Regardless, the forced march causes any army deployed in this way to increase its weary condition by 1.

Thankfully, Kisandra's warning affords the PCs enough time (barely) to mount a defense of Tatzlford. She can tell the PCs that the attacking group consists of 100 human mercenaries armed with longswords and composite longbows, 50 human Tiger Lords armed with axes, and a dozen immense trolls. The group is commanded by one of Drelev's right-hand thugs—a pig of a man named Ameon Trask.

Kisandra can tell the PCs that Ameon's forces are somewhat disorganized and sloppy—Ameon's not all that great of a leader and his tactics for the attack are likely to be little more than orders to charge the village en masse while he hangs back with a few guards to observe the clash from afar. The number of trained soldiers and grizzled nomadic warriors he commands more than makes up for these blunt tactics with sheer force; if Tatzlford's guards were to meet Trask's forces on even ground, the result would likely be a slaughter. She finishes by pointing out that since Ameon is likely to hang back to observe rather than take part in the battle, a targeted strike on him by the PCs could sway the battle in their favor.

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TATZLFORD'S FORCES

The PCs have precious little time to prepare a defense of the town, but if they do, the battle will go much better for them. In the last few days, Tatzlford has managed to scrabble together two relatively small armies to defend itself.

Statistics for these two armies are presented below; unlike armies recruited by the PCs, these armies do not adjust their level to match the Kingdom's level. If the PCs wish to keep either or both of these armies on after the Battle for Tatzlford is over, they can automatically recruit them, at which point they adjust their level upwards to match the Kingdom's level. If the PCs prefer not to take on the additional consumption these two armies bring, the guards and hunters disband and return to their normal jobs after the battle.

Perhaps the greatest asset available to Tatzlford, though, are the PCs themselves. If the PCs don't act on Kisandra's suggestion, Loy pleads that they reconsider while the battle rages, the PCs should skirt around the battlefield to confront its commander, Ameon Trask. Overpowering him could make the difference between victory and defeat, depending on how the tide of battle goes in Tatzlford itself.

TATZLFORD TOWN GUARD — ARMY 7

NG INFANTRY

Scouting +15
Recruitment DC —; **Consumption** 1
Description Tatzlford's town guards have been organized into an impromptu army armed with longswords and led by Captain Coren Lawry.

AC 25; **Maneuver** +12 (low); **Morale** +18 (high)
HP 5 (RT 2)
Melee longswords +18
Tactics Hold the Line, Toughened Soldiers

NARLMARCH HUNTERS — ARMY 6

NG SKIRMISHER

Scouting +14
Recruitment DC —; **Consumption** 1
Description This army is a band of hunters and trappers who have gathered into a ragtag group of archers led by Mayor Loy Rezbin.

AC 24; **Maneuver** +17 (high); **Morale** +11 (low)
HP 4 (RT 2)
Melee hatchets and shortswords +15
Ranged longbows +18 (7 shots)
Tactics Efficient Ammunition, Sharpshooter

THE BATTLEFIELD

While Tatzlford has no siege engines, it does feature some partially completed walls along steep escarpments, a river with a single bridge that serves as a choke point, and a fortified town hall. These features provide three significant benefits to armies that begin the battle entrenched in the town.

Advantageous Positioning: Being able to fight in and around the houses of Tatzlford and its defenses grants armies that start the War encounter defending the town a +2 item bonus to AC and to saving throws for the first 3 turns.

Fortification: One army can start the battle fortified within the Tatzlford town hall (AC 20, HP 2; see page 578 in Appendix 3 for more information about battlefield fortifications).

The Skunk River: Attacking armies who approach from the north must contend with the Skunk River, and on the first 2 turns of the War encounter are treated as if they are in difficult terrain—they take a –2 penalty on Maneuver checks during these first two turns.

Additional Defenses

As soon as the meeting with Kisandra is over, Loy Rezbin suggests the PCs take a quick tour of Tatzlford to see what sort of defenses can be prepared.

ASSESSING TATZLFORD'S DEFENSES

CONCENTRATE EXPLORATION

The party takes an hour to tour Tatzlford to assess potential improvements to the town's defenses. They automatically come to the conclusion that erecting barricades will help, giving them access to the Erect Barricades activity below. Attempt a single DC 23 Defense check or DC 27 Warfare kingdom check to identify additional defensive improvements, potentially allowing access to the Post Snipers, Prepare Firepots, Recruit Wildlife, or Set Traps activities below. If the players come up with any of those ideas on their own (or at your discretion, similar enough ideas) they gain access to the corresponding activity regardless of the check result.

Critical Success The party gains all four additional defensive actions.
Success The party gains two additional defensive actions, determined randomly.
Failure The party gains one additional defensive action, determined randomly.
Critical Failure Only the Erect Barricades defense suggests itself to the PCs.

Setting Up Defenses

Once the PCs have assessed Tatzlford, there's enough time before the battle begins for each PC to choose and attempt one of the defensive activities the party gained access to; each action other than Erect Barricades may be chosen by no more than 1 PC. On a non-critical failure, the attempt produces no significant advantage or disadvantage to Tatzlford's defenders.

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A QUICK-PLAY ALTERNATIVE

If you'd rather not run a warfare encounter at this point, but you don't want to simply have the battle play out in the background, you can simulate the battle by simply having the party roll a DC 30 Warfare check to determine if the town is successful in defeating the enemy. For each defense other than Erect Barricades that the PCs successfully put in place, this DC is lowered by 2. If this check results in a failure (but not a critical failure), the PCs can improve the result to a success by defeating Ameon and his troll bodyguards in the Attacking Trask encounter.

Enough time passes during these downtime events so that the PCs finish in the late afternoon. At this point, a breathless scout races into town with alarming news: Trask's armies are drawing near and the attack on Tatzlford is imminent!

ERECT BARRICADES

DOWNTIME | MANIPULATE

Open gaps in the walls, in alleys, or even on streets can be fortified with barricades to prevent easy passage into town, using lumber, trees, barrels, wagons, rubbish, and even sharpened poles. Erecting a Barricade requires a Crafting check. This activity can be performed by more than one PC to create more than one barricade.

Critical Success The barricade is a success. When a defending army takes the Guard action, it gains a +2 item bonus on its Maneuver check. A barricade can grant this bonus only twice before it is ruined by enemy attacks.

Success As critical success, but the barricade only works for one Guard action.

Critical Failure A catastrophic accident occurs! Not only is the barricade ruined, but the PC attempting to erect the barricade takes 10d6 points of bludgeoning damage (DC 25 basic Reflex save).

POST SNIPERS

DOWNTIME | MANIPULATE

The Narlmarch Wardens are skilled hunters, but by taking a few of these archers out of the army's ranks and posting them on hidden locations on rooftops or in trees throughout the battlefield, the PCs can maximize their potential.

Critical Success The snipers are posted in several key positions. At the end of a turn during the Battle for Tatzlford, attempt a +18 ranged Strike against any army that is not engaged. The snipers deal 1 point of damage on a hit (2 points on a critical hit). The snipers can perform this bonus attack up to 3 times during the Battle for Tatzlford, but no more than once at the end of any one turn.

Success As critical success, but the snipers can perform the bonus attack only once during the battle.

Critical Failure Not only are the snipers posted in areas that end up not proving advantageous, but the PCs drew too many archers from the ranks. The Narlmarch Hunters suffer a –2 penalty on ranged attacks during the Battle for Tatzlford.

PREPARE FIREPOTS

DOWNTIME | MANIPULATE

With the knowledge that there are some trolls in the army, preparation of firepots containing alchemical fire, oil, or some form of quickly combustible material may be invaluable to the battle. Preparing Firepots requires a Crafting (trained) check.

Critical Success Enough firepots are created that they are quickly available at all points in the battlefield, and as a result, the troll army that attacks Tatzlford loses its regeneration tactic.

Success Not enough firepots are created to ensure quick deployment. At the end of the troll army's turn, it must attempt a DC 20 Mobility check. If it fails, it loses its regeneration tactic until the end of its next turn.

Critical Failure The attempt to prepare firepots results in a spectacular explosion that inflicts 10d6 points of fire damage to the PC (DC 25 basic Reflex save).

RECRUIT WILDLIFE

DOWNTIME | MANIPULATE

A fair amount of wildlife dwells in the forest surrounding Tatzlford. While the animals can't be organized into an actual army, the PCs can still attempt to use their skills to turn the local fauna to their advantage. Recruiting Wildlife requires a Nature (expert) check. If a PC has Wild Empathy or can cast spells like *speak with animals*, they can opt to attempt this check using Diplomacy (trained) instead.

Critical Success The PCs interpret animal reactions to the enemy armies' approach, giving their armies a +3 circumstance bonus on initiative checks made during the Battle for Tatzlford. In addition, at one point during the battle, a pack of hungry brush thylacines attack an enemy army. This attack takes place at the end of a turn chosen by the party, at which point the PCs can attempt a +20 melee Strike against any non-engaged army. The thylacines do 1 point of damage to that army on a hit (or 2 points on a critical hit) before the animals flee back into the woods.

Success As success (including the thylacine attack), but the circumstance bonus on initiative checks is only +1.

Critical Failure Not only do the local animals refuse to aid, the PCs actions accidentally send a pack of crazed brush thylacines into town to attack. The Tatzlford Town Guard manages to defeat the attack, but they start the war encounter with 1 point of damage.

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SET TRAPS

DOWNTIME MANIPULATE

By setting a number of quickly built traps in the surrounding woods or in narrow alleys, the PCs can impede the attackers' movement and even injure some of them. Setting Traps requires a Survival (trained) check.

Critical Success At the end of each turn during the Battle for Tatzlford, one enemy army of the PCs' choice becomes mired 1 and takes 1 point of damage.

Success At the end of each turn during the Battle for Tatzlford, one enemy army of the PCs' choice becomes mired 1 or takes 1 point of damage.

Critical Failure The attempt to set traps not only fails, but one of them misfires spectacularly during setup: An attempt to rig a timber covered with spikes fails, smashing the PC against a building wall. That PC takes 5d6 piercing and 5d6 bludgeoning damage (DC 25 basic Reflex save).

THE BATTLE FOR TATZLFORD

Once the PCs have completed any last-minute defenses of the town, the Battle for Tatzlford begins as Ameon's army of Tiger Lords, bandits, and trolls lumbers into view along the Skunk River. With a roar of challenge, this ragtag group charges. Ameon's plan is simple: rush east along the Skunk River's northern bank, storm across the bridge and race into Tatzlford, killing anyone they meet along the way.

This battle plays out using the rules for War encounters in Appendix 3. Ameon's soldiers consist of two armies, detailed below. These armies are meant to have an advantage over the forces stationed in Tatzlford, but this advantage can fade quickly if the PCs were effective in planning ahead. If the PCs brought their own armies, they may well be able to defeat Trask's forces with ease; in this case, let the PCs revel in their victory—there'll be plenty more difficult battles to fight in the next chapter!

DRELEV IRREGULARS ARMY 7

CE INFANTRY

Scouting +15

Description The Drelev Irregulars are composed of equal parts Tiger Lords and mercenaries who were once bandits. Their fighting style is more akin to a mob than a disciplined force; while this allows the irregulars an advantage in mobility, it decentralizes their command structure and lessens their morale.

AC 25; **Maneuver** +19; **Morale** +11

HP 4 (RT 2)

Melee swords and axes +18

Tactical Training (unique tactic) The Drelev Irregulars can use the All-Out Assault, Counterattack, and Dirty Fighting tactical actions.

Unpredictable Movement (unique tactic) It's difficult to do significant damage to the Drelev Irregulars with ranged attacks, as the mob moves about in a haphazard manner. All ranged attacks against the Drelev Irregulars suffer a –2 circumstance penalty as a result.

TROLL MARAUDERS ARMY 8

NE INFANTRY

Scouting +14

Description There are only a few dozen trolls in this army, but their ferocity and regenerative capability make them a dangerous force nonetheless.

AC 28; **Maneuver** +13; **Morale** +19

HP 5 (RT 1)

Melee claws and fangs +20

Brutal Assault ❖❖ (unique tactic) The Troll Marauders can use the All-Out Assault action. When they do, an army damaged by the assault must succeed at a DC 24 Morale check to avoid becoming shaken 1 (or shaken 2 on a critical failure) as a result of the brutality of this attack.

Darkvision (unique tactic) The Troll Marauders possess the Darkvision tactic for free–this tactic does not count against the maximum number of tactics the Troll Marauders can possess.

Frightening Foe (unique tactic) The Troll Marauders can use the Taunt tactical action. When they do, they gain a +2 status bonus on their Morale check if they used the Regeneration tactic this turn.

Regeneration (unique tactic) At the beginning of its turn, the Troll Marauders regain 1 Hit Point. The Troll Marauders cannot be destroyed as usual unless they lose this tactic. The PCs can cause the trolls to lose the Regeneration tactic via prepared firepots (see page 296); while the trolls' Regeneration tactic is lost, their RT increases to 3. Otherwise, an army that engages the Troll Marauders while they are defeated can take a three-round action to burn the trolls and destroy their army.

ATTACKING TRASK SEVERE 10

With Kisandra's news that the enemy forces' leader, Ameon Trask, intends to hang back and observe the battle from afar rather than take part in the fight, the PCs can do something of the same—leave the Battle for Tatzlford to be fought out by the armies while they head across the Skunk River to confront Ameon personally. If the PCs don't, the outcome of the Battle for Tatzlford will worsen (see After the Battle below). If the PCs win the battle without confronting Ameon, he flees back to Drelev, and the PCs can encounter him in Part 2 of this chapter as you see fit.

The War encounter and the PCs' clash against Ameon Trask happen simultaneously, but for pacing reasons, it's best if you resolve the War encounter then proceed with this one.

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Ameon chooses to observe the battle from the relative safety of one of the smaller isles in the river, just north of the Skunk River Bridge. You can use the map for the tatzlwyrm encounter for this fight (see page 68), with the Skunk River Bridge running across the southern banks of the largest isle and the rubble and deadfall to the middle cleared away.

Ameon is a bit shocked and astounded to be personally confronted, but revels in the opportunity to show off his battle prowess against the heroes. After all, if he can defeat the leaders of the kingdom in this fight, he'll have succeeded in his plans beyond his initial expectations. The two troll kings he's retained at his side serve him as bodyguards, but much prefer to serve as murderous killers; they fight to the death. Ameon Trask is far less devoted to the cause, and if reduced below 70 hit points he uses his potions to try to escape. If reduced to 0 hit points, consider using the dying rules instead of having him be instantly slain, so the PCs can potentially capture him for questioning.



AMEON TRASK

AMEON TRASK CREATURE 10

UNIQUE | LE | MEDIUM | HUMANOID | HUMAN

Male human mercenary

Perception +16

Languages Common, Skald

Skills Acrobatics +21, Athletics +19, Deception +20, Intimidation +20, Warfare Lore +16

Str +3, **Dex** +5, **Con** +3, **Int** +0, **Wis** +0, **Cha** +4

Items *+1 chain mail*, composite shortbow (20 arrows), *+1 striking short sword*, cold iron short sword, *invisibility potion*, *moderate healing potion*, 50 gp

AC 30; **Fort** +19, **Ref** +21, **Will** +16

HP 175

Attack of Opportunity ↷

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ *short sword* +23 (agile, finesse, versatile S); **Damage** 2d6+9 piercing

Melee ❖ cold iron short sword +22 (agile, finesse, versatile S); **Damage** 1d6+9 piercing

Ranged ❖ composite shortbow +22 (deadly d10, propulsive); **Damage** 1d6+9 piercing

Sneak Attack Ameon Trask deals 2d6 extra precision damage to flat-footed creatures.

Twin Feint ❖❖ Ameon Trask makes a series of attacks with both short swords, using the first attack to throw his foe off guard against a second attack at a different angle. He makes one Strike with each of his short swords, both against the same target. The target is automatically flat-footed against the second attack. Apply Ameon Trask's multiple attack penalty to the Strikes normally.

Twin Parry ❖ Ameon uses his two short swords to parry attacks. He gains a +2 circumstance bonus to AC until the start of his next turn, but loses this bonus if he no longer wields a weapon in each hand.

TROLL KINGS (2) CREATURE 10

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Initiative Perception +19

AFTER THE BATTLE

The Battle for Tatzlford ends once you've played out the War encounter and once the PCs have had the opportunity to defeat Ameon Trask. Determine victory or defeat as detailed on page 578 of Appendix 3; if the PCs managed to kill or capture Ameon Trask, the

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result is improved by one degree, but if the PCs didn't bother to attack Ameon at all, the result is worsened by one degree.

Successful Victory: If Tatzlford won the battle and the party achieves at least a success when Determining Victory, award the PCs 120 Kingdom XP, reduce Unrest by 1d4, and reduce one Ruin of the PCs' choice by 1.

Costly Victory: If Tatzlford won but the party failed when Determining Victory, or if Tatzlford lost the battle but the PCs achieved at least a success when Determining Defeat, they have a costly victory. The PCs earn 60 Kingdom XP and must attempt a DC 27 Defense check. On a failure, 2 structures (chosen by the players) in Tatzlford's Urban Grid are destroyed; on a critical failure, 4 structures are destroyed.

Total Defeat: If Tatzlford lost the battle and the party fails when Determining Defeat, Tatzlford suffers extensive damage (8 structures of the GM's choice are destroyed) and is controlled by Ameon Trask. The PCs earn 20 Kingdom XP. Increase Unrest by 1d4 and increase one Ruin of the PCs' choice by 1. If the PCs had claimed the hex, they lose it. If they act quickly and have more armies, they can attempt to retake Tatzlford, but this time Ameon's forces gain the battlefield advantage. Alternately, they could sneak into the village to try to remove Ameon Trask from control; this causes the troops occupying the town to quickly panic and disband, at which point the PCs can reclaim the village. Over time, feel free to augment Ameon's armies with additional forces or even have them attack other areas in the PCs' kingdom; see Chapter 8 for advice on how to handle wartime events like these.

AFTERMATH

If Ameon escapes, he returns to Fort Drelev. The baron is displeased with his failure, but not enough to throw the man into the dungeon. In this case, the PCs can encounter Ameon again in Drelev Keep, either in his quarters plotting a new campaign against the PCs' nation or leading the keep's guards in battle.

If the PCs capture Ameon alive, his attitude is hostile. He remains silent unless made friendly, whether with Diplomacy to Make an Impression, Intimidation to Coerce, or magic such as *charm*, at which point he can reveal much about Fort Drelev and its baron (see page 301 for more details). If made helpful, Ameon even agrees to accompany the PCs back to Fort Drelev to aid them in putting the baron down.

KISANDRA'S PLEA

After the PCs recover from the battle, Kisandra praises the PCs for their skill and renown for problem-solving and asks them to save her father from the dungeons of Drelev Keep and her sister from the clutches of the Tiger Lords. She further explains the recent developments in the Drelev Demesne, providing details about the arrival of Armag. She tells the PCs that Baron Drelev is a craven bully who, if left in charge of the Drelev Demesne, will cause the death of hundreds. She urges them to save her people from Armag and the Tiger Lords and to repay Drelev for his treachery by forcing him to cede control of his domain.

Kisandra has little in the way of personal wealth to offer in payment for these requests, but she does pledge her family's loyalty to the PCs if they accept her quests. She also points out that if they can liberate Fort Drelev, its beleaguered citizens will certainly treat them as heroes and join their nation.

Despite her worries for her father and sister, Kisandra is not willing to accompany the PCs. She fears Baron Drelev and does not want to return to the fort until he has been dealt with. She sketches a map of the town for the PCs, and she offers the name of a possible ally in the town: Satinder Morne, the proprietor of Fort Drelev's gaming hall and brothel. Kisandra gives the PCs a jade ring (worth 40 gp) that can show Satinder that they're friends. Kisandra is hesitant to admit how she knows Satinder—they are secretly lovers—she tells the PCs that Satinder is no friend of Baron Drelev despite the fact that the mercenary guards who now serve as the city watch are among her best customers. If the PCs are looking for a safe place to hide in Fort Drelev, they should mention Kisandra's name to Satinder and give her the jade ring with a long-stemmed flower threaded through the ring itself.

KISANDRA'S PLEA

80 XP | 80 KINGDOM XP

Kisandra asks the PCs to rescue her father Terrion from the dungeons below Drelev Keep, to retrieve her sister Tamary from the Tiger Lords, and to remove Baron Drelev from power and seize control of the city of Fort Drelev, thus liberating its citizens from the baron's despotic rule.

Source: Kisandra Numesti.

Completion: The three portions of this quest can be completed in any order. Kisandra's father and sister must be delivered to safety from their respective locations. Fort Drelev counts as a safe location once the baron is removed and Irovetti's mercenaries are routed; to liberate Fort Drelev, the PCs must earn 20 Liberation Points in the city and either kill or capture Baron Drelev. See page 301 for how the PCs can earn Liberation Points.

Reward: Completing this quest allows the PCs to claim Fort Drelev and its lands without increasing their nation's Unrest; see Claiming Drelev on page 317 for details on how they can gain favor with the citizens of Drelev and successfully annex their lands.

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PART 2:

FORT DRELEV

Fort Drelev is the seat of power from which Baron Hannis Drelev once governed his chartered holdings on behalf of Brevoy. Although he and his companions managed to develop Fort Drelev into an impressive town, times have not been good there of late. Ever since the baron capitulated to Irovetti and Armag, the town has been under a pall of fear and gloom. Many of the fort's original complement of Brevic soldiers are dead, replaced by mercenaries, not-quite-reformed bandits sent from Pitax; morale is made worse by the fact that many of these mercenaries represented the dregs of Pitax's militia in the first place.

Today, the citizens of Fort Drelev are a downcast and desperate lot. There's very little activity in the streets, and while shops and markets remain open and farmers and craftsmen continue to ply their trades, they do so quietly and without much noise. No one wants to draw attention to themselves in Fort Drelev, not with the surly and easily angered mercenary guards patrolling the streets and, increasingly, taking what they want from the citizens, be it food or gold or wares. The fact that there's little indication from the baron or his guards that things will be changing soon has many of the town's citizens on the edge of revolt, but they lack the courage or conviction to rise up—especially in light of the cruelty often displayed by the guards. The town is under martial law, with a curfew running from an hour before sunset to an hour after sunrise. Those who break curfew are sent to Drelev Keep for punishment. Few have emerged, and whispers of what fate awaits those in the keep's dungeons grows increasingly grim as more and more citizens vanish into them.

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INTO FORT DRELEV

Fort Drelev is a sizable town, but the baron has overbuilt. Many of the buildings were empty or partially completed even before he capitulated to Irovetti. Since then, the town's population has decreased further as citizens succumb to illness or starvation, are imprisoned or beaten to death by unruly mercenary guards, or manage to build up enough courage to flee the town.

FORT DRELEV **SETTLEMENT 3**

NE TOWN

Government overlord

Population 2,758 (2,400 humans, 118 dwarves, 88 half-elves, 59 elves, 44 halflings, 40 half-orcs, 9 other)

Languages Common

Religions none

Threats corruption from within

Oppressed Until Fort Drelev is liberated, it is treated as a neutral evil 3rd level settlement. If liberated and allowed to remain a freehold, it returns to being a neutral 4th level settlement after a month, unless the PCs take action to adjust the settlement's alignment further.

Hannis Drelev (NE male human baron 12) Scheming philanderer and Lord of Fort Drelev.

Pavetta Stroon-Drelev (NE female human baroness 9) Imperious socialite.

Imeckus Stroon (LE male human wizard 12) The baroness' brother; advisor to the baron.

Quintessa Maray (CN female human bard 11) An opportunistic spy from Daggermark; the baron's mistress.

Satinder Morne (CN female human cleric of Calistria 6) Priestess of Calistria and ally of Kisandra Numesti.

B1. WATCHTOWER

This watchtower is staffed at all times by six Drelev guards (page 304). They spend most of their time watching the gap in the wall, hoping to spot anyone trying to escape the town, than they do looking outward for anyone approaching. The wall gap itself is evidence of the unfinished defense—the baron has promised to finish the job once things "settle down" in town, but most locals assume the job is as finished as it'll ever get.

B2. DRELEV KEEP

This large structure of stone and wood is the home of Baron Drelev, his family, and his allies. This location is fully detailed starting on page 306.

B3. SUTTON'S STABLES & SMITHY

Gask Sutton's (N male human stabler 5) horses have all been given over to the Tiger Lords and Pitax as tribute. Gask himself spends his days toiling at building more weapons to arm the guards with or to ship to Pitax.

B4. TEMPLE OF ERASTIL

This large stone building is only a shell—the interior is incomplete and empty. The three priests who were to officiate here were all taken into the keep the day the baron surrendered, and there has been no sign of them since (all three were fed to the oozes in the caves below the keep).

B5. SECRET ESCAPE TUNNEL

At the base of a 30-foot-high bluff is the secret entrance to the escape tunnel Satinder mentions to the PCs (see page 305). Spotting the hidden door from nearby requires success at a DC 35 Perception check; with Satinder's advice, the DC to locate the entrance drops to 25. The tunnel beyond leads to area **C51**.

B6. BELLWEATHER'S SOUP N' KETTLE

This tavern and eatery is one of the only busy establishments in town—although the mercenaries who frequent it don't pay for their meals. **Asaia Bellweather** (N female human cook 5) and her four children provide these meals anyway, fearing reprisals should they do otherwise.

B7. IRON STEEPLE INN

Once Fort Drelev's largest inn, this building is empty.

B8. THE VELVET CORNER

This is Fort Drelev's only gambling hall and brothel, an establishment owned and run by a priestess of Calistria named Satinder Morne. She does brisk business these days, but an increasing amount of her time is spent making sure her rowdy customers don't cause too much damage to her equipment or hurt her employees. Satinder Morne could be an important ally to the PCs; see page 305 for details.

B9. THE RAT'S SHRINE

This small stone shrine was originally dedicated to Hanspur, the god of rivers and river travel, but it now stands abandoned—its only priest fled Fort Drelev the day the baron surrendered.

LIBERATING FORT DRELEV

In order to free Fort Drelev, the PCs must accomplish two goals: they must defeat Baron Drelev, and they must reach a total of 20 Liberation Points (LP) by accomplishing certain actions while avoiding others. Methods of gaining and losing Liberation Points are summarized below. (It is possible to have negative Liberation Points.)

Citizen Death: –3 LP per citizen killed by the hill giants or the Drelev guards; –10 LP per citizen killed by a PC (other than those listed below)

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Defeat Drelev Guards: +1 LP for every two Drelev guards defeated

Defeat Hill Giant: +1 LP per Drelev hill giant defeated

Kill/Capture Armag: +6 LP

Kill/Capture Baron Hannis Drelev: +6 LP

Kill/Capture Baroness Pavetta Stroon-Drelev: +2 LP

Kill/Capture Imeckus Stroon: +4 LP

Languishing: –2 LP per day spent without gaining any LP (this penalty cannot reduce LP lower than 0)

Public Destruction: –5 LP per building partially ruined, –10 LP per building destroyed

Public Fight: –1 LP per round combat persists, to a maximum penalty of –5 LP per fight (this penalty is avoided if the fight takes place out of sight of the public or in Drelev Keep)

Rescue Lord Terrion Numesti: +4 LP

Rescue Tamary Numesti: +4 LP

Return Kisandra Numesti to Drelev: +2 LP

After Baron Drelev is defeated, if the PCs haven't yet reached 20 Liberation Points, they can use the following additional methods to earn more points.

Relief Work: If the entire party spends a day of downtime helping restore Fort Drelev (by rebuilding, casting healing magic, entertaining, training soldiers, and so on), they can attempt one of the following kingdom skill checks—a DC 25 Engineering or Industry check or a DC 30 Politics or Trade check. On a success, they earn +1 LP; on a critical success, they earn +2 LP.

Stimulate Economy: If the PCs take a penalty to the next Kingdom turn's Resource Dice, they can stimulate the town's economy. Reduce Resource Dice by 2 on the next Kingdom turn to gain +1 LP. The PCs can repeat this act up to four times for a maximum bonus of +4 LP per month.

ENTERING FORT DRELEV

To reach the baron, the PCs must enter Fort Drelev and gain access to his keep. Storming into town and attacking the city is a bad choice—the resulting panic and collateral damage will erode the PCs' Liberation Point total—but once the PCs can get into Drelev Keep itself, they'll have more freedom to pursue combat.

If the PCs simply stride into town openly, they'll be confronted by a patrol of 4 Drelev guards (see below)—combat quickly ensues unless the PCs take action to deescalate the conflict.

The stealthiest way to enter the keep is via a secret tunnel entrance along the rocky shores of Lake Hooktongue that leads directly to Drelev Keep's

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dungeons, but without aid or directions it's unlikely that the PCs will just happen to stumble across this well-hidden entrance on their own.

INFILTRATION TACTICS

The PCs can infiltrate the town and gather information to assess the situation. Perhaps non-intuitively, daytime is the safer time to do so, as the bulk of the soldiers tend to spend more time sleeping during the day so that they can be more active patrolling the city once its curfew begins. As the town's defenders are more vigilant and numerous during curfew hours—an hour before sunset to an hour after sunrise—the DCs of the skill checks detailed below are increased by 5 during that time.

The following tactics each afford the PCs a number of hours to explore Fort Drelev. At the end of that time, they'll need to bring their infiltration to a grinding halt—if they're moving about in public, they'll be confronted by 4 Drelev guards within an hour during the day, or within 10 minutes during curfew.

For all tactics other than Stealth, the fact that the PCs are leaders and heroes of the neighboring kingdom works against them. A character who succeeds at a Deception check to Impersonate or otherwise disguise themselves against the guards' Perception DC avoids this complication. If the guards recognize even one of the PCs as the enemy, they'll attempt to arrest them, or even attack them if circumstances warrant.

A fight on the streets against a group of guards not only lowers accumulated LP (page 302), but also limits the PCs' options as word of the violence spreads. After the first fight, guards automatically recognize the PCs—if not as enemy leaders, then certainly as troublemakers—forcing the PCs to adopt stealth or disguises to avoid future confrontations. As a general rule, 4 more guards come to investigate a fight within 1d12 minutes of the first fight's beginning. Potentially, the PCs could defeat all of the guards active in the town, after which point they'll be able to explore the town freely—albeit at a significant LP cost!

Bribery: Fort Drelev's current guards are mostly recruited from mercenaries and ex-bandits, and as such, they can be bribed to look the other way. A bribe worth at least 40 gp purchases the PCs 8 hours of time to explore Fort Drelev, but the guards are greedy and word spreads quickly. With each bribe, the minimum price of the next bribe increases by 20 gp.

Deception: The PCs can attempt to Lie to the guards to convince them they're legitimate visitors to the town (perhaps as merchants or traveling mercenaries seeking a place to rest for the night), or to claim that they are in fact citizens of the settlement. The guards haven't bothered to get to know the townsfolk, so this latter lie is just as likely to succeed as claims of being merchants or mercenaries. Attempting to present themselves as friends of the baron will be met with derision and replies like, "The baron's got new friends now!"; resulting Deception checks suffer a –2 circumstance penalty. On a successful Deception check, the PCs earn 8 hours of exploration time (or 24 hours on a critical success), while on a critical failure, the guards sense something is off and threaten to arrest the PCs if they don't immediately leave town.

Diplomacy: The attitude of Drelev's guards is initially unfriendly, but the PCs can attempt to Make an Impression on them. If made indifferent, the PCs earn 1d4 hours of exploration time; making the guards friendly earns 8 hours. Making guards helpful via this method isn't possible, although it can be accomplished with certain types of magic—doing so earns 24 hours of exploration time. If the guards become hostile, they immediately threaten arrest.

Intimidation: The guards are used to intimidation tactics, so any attempt to Coerce them suffers a –4 circumstance penalty. Success on an Intimidation check to Coerce the guards earns the PCs 1d4 hours of exploration time, while a critical success earns 8 hours.

Stealth: The party can use the Avoid Notice and Follow the Expert exploration activities to enter Fort Drelev stealthily. Avoiding the guards' notice requires success on a DC 27 Stealth check (this equals a Drelev guard's Perception DC); on a success the PCs earn 1d4 hours of exploration, while on a critical success they earn 8 hours. On a failure, they can quickly turn back if they were attempting the check to initially enter the city and avoid a confrontation, but on a critical failure—or on a regular failure while already in the city and attempting to extend exploration time—the PCs are confronted by 4 guards.

Drelev Guards

Creatures: The mercenaries sent by Irovetti to aid Baron Drelev in keeping the town secure are numerous There are 36 assigned to the town, and several more in Drelev Keep. At any one time, 6 guards are stationed at the watchtower (area **B1**) and another 16 patrol the streets in groups of 4. The other 16 guards are off duty, relaxing at the Velvet Corner, eating at Bellweather's, or sleeping on the ground floor of the watchtower.

The guards are quick to anger; given any excuse, they threaten to "arrest" the PCs—a poor euphemism for "kill and loot;" these guards aren't interested in capturing the PCs alive unless they recognize who they are, in which case they do attempt to legitimately arrest the PCs so they can present them to the baron.

Killing all the guards assigned to the town is certainly one way to secure safety in exploring the fort, but too

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AN "AUDIENCE" WITH THE BARON

The PCs can attempt to deal with the baron diplomatically, but the baron is not a trustworthy man. If the PCs reveal who they are to the guards and request an audience with the baron, the guards arrest them, stripping them of weapons, armor, and gear before marching them to Drelev Keep. There, the PCs are taken down to the dungeons and imprisoned in area **C46**, while their gear is put in storage at area **C48**. In time, the baron may or may not come to speak to them; it's more likely he'll rely upon Imeckus Stroon to perform these interrogations. The baron is interested in the defenses of the PCs' kingdom and, ultimately, in them surrendering to his rule. He eventually grows bored with interrogations and executes any PCs who are imprisoned rather than risk keeping them around.

Obviously, the party should resist this fate, whether it's at the start by attacking the guards or later in a daring prison break. Full details on the keep itself begin on page 306.

many public battles can panic the populace and thus reduce Liberation Points. News of the slaughter reaches Drelev Keep within a few hours, at which point the baron orders the keep into lockdown (see page 306).

DRELEV GUARDS CREATURE 8

UNCOMMON | NE | MEDIUM | HUMANOID | HUMAN

Human fighters

Perception +16

Languages Common

Skills Athletics +18, Intimidation +16

Str +4, **Dex** +2, **Con** +4, **Int** +0, **Wis** +2, **Cha** +2

Items breastplate, composite longbow (20 arrows), *+1 striking longsword*, steel shield (Hardness 5, HP 20 [BT 10]), 10 gp

AC 27; **Fort** +18, **Ref** +14, **Will** +16

HP 135

Attack of Opportunity ↷

Shield Block ↷

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ *longsword* +19 (versatile P), **Damage** 2d8+8 slashing

Ranged ❖ composite longbow +17 (deadly d10, range 100 feet, reload 0, volley 30 feet), **Damage** 1d8+8 piercing

Formation Fighters A Drelev guard gains a +2 circumstance bonus on attack and damage rolls as long as he is adjacent to at least two other Drelev guards.

Intimidating Strike ❖❖ (emotion, fear, mental) The Drelev guard makes a melee Strike. If he hits and deals damage, the target is frightened 1, or frightened 2 on a critical hit.

Raise Shield ❖

Reward: If the PCs achieve at least a success in any attempt to placate the guards (including successfully bribing them), grant them 60 XP. The PCs can earn this XP award up to 4 times, but no more than once every 24 hours.

Exploring Fort Drelev

Once the PCs succeed at placating the town guards, they'll earn a number of hours during which they can mingle freely with the local citizens, attempt to Gather Information, or simply explore the town. Shortly after their time runs out, the PCs will inevitably be confronted by a patrol of guards, at which point they'll need to interact with the guards again to earn more exploration time.

Gathering Information from the locals is an excellent method to learn about opportunities in Fort Drelev, and some of the information they uncover may lead them to consider alternate plans for accessing Drelev Keep. For instance, by posing as friends of Imeckus Stroon or Lady Quintessa rather than the baron himself, they might manage to Lie their way past the guards and request an audience.

Fort Drelev's citizens aren't eager to talk—it's dangerous to help strangers in town these days—so their attitudes are unfriendly. Locals slam doors in the faces of strangers who appear on their stoops or simply look away and ignore those who approach them in public. As a result, Gathering Information takes 2 hours of work and success at a DC 30 Diplomacy check. A critical failure results in the locals becoming panicked and calling for the town guard; this immediately ends any remaining time the PCs had to explore the town freely and forces a confrontation with 4 guards.

On a successful check, the PC learns one of the following pieces of information (or two pieces of information on a critical success). You can either determine the information learned randomly or pick one that feels appropriate.

- "Things in town are bad. The baron sold us out to bandits and raiders, and now he and his favorites never come out of Drelev Keep. They let those mercenary guards to do what they want by day. There's even giants up by the keep, and now and then the baron lets those lumbering brutes out to patrol the town after dark!"
- "Businesses are still open during the day, but no one's buying anything. The tavern and brothel are busy, but mostly just because of the mercenaries in town, and even then they often don't pay—they 'put it on the Baron's tab' with the expectation that payment will come later, but it never does. Shipments of food come in every week or so from Pitax, but most of that goes to the guards or up

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to the keep. The common folk have to beg or scavenge what they can."

- "Baron Drelev recently gave shelter to a young foreign noblewoman named Lady Quintessa at his keep. She's a lot younger and prettier than his wife, Baroness Pavetta. I'm sure there's more going on there than mere kindness."
- "Shortly after the baron surrendered to Pitax and the Tiger Lords, his wife's brother—a rather brusque, foul-tempered wizard named Imeckus Stroon—came to town. Since then, he's sequestered himself in the keep, rarely emerging. No one in town knows what he's up to."
- "No one knows for sure where the warlord Armag has gone. After accepting Drelev's offer of an alliance in exchange for sparing the town, he took several people as hostages and marched into the hills. He's supposed to return the hostages once the baron has proven his loyalty to Pitax (whatever that means), but most folk assume the hostages are already dead."

Contacting Satinder Morne

Satinder Morne exudes a sense of confidence, bravado, and charm in all she does. She rarely lets her temper show, always smiling and waiting until she has the upper hand on an enemy before releasing her anger and savoring the sweetness of Calistria's revenge. This trait has served her well of late, as her current clientele are growing increasingly hard to manage and control.

If the PCs attempt to contact Satinder, she'll initially assume they're just another batch of mercenaries looking for a good time. Her initial attitude is unfriendly, but if the PCs mention that they're hoping to liberate the town and depose the baron, they gain a +6 bonus on Diplomacy checks to adjust her attitude. Giving her Kisandra's ring and a flower while mentioning her friend's name automatically makes her helpful.

If made friendly, Satinder helps the PCs by giving them three pieces of information from the previous section. More importantly, she'll tell them something she learned some time back: the baron built a secret escape tunnel from his keep that exits onto the shore of Lake Hooktongue just north of town. Satinder gives the PCs directions to this secret entrance's location (area **B5**).

If made helpful, Satinder agrees to let the PCs use the Velvet Corner as a hideout while they're in town; she has several hidden rooms in her establishment that can house the PCs. In this case, time spent in the Velvet Corner (either resting and relaxing or Gathering Information) does not reduce time earned by placating guards. She'll even provide free healing and spellcasting services for the PCs as long as they're in town.

Satinder casts *undetectable alignment* on herself every day. She is a shrewd woman who prefers to fight only when she's absolutely sure she has an overwhelming advantage. In combat, she prefers to turn her enemies against each other with magic, or at least get them to sit the fight out with spells like *blindness*. She targets remaining opponents with debilitating spells like *silence* or *ray of enfeeblement*, saving her damaging spells for foes that she feels deserve it. If reduced to less than 80 Hit Points, she casts *sanctuary* and attempts to flee, but as a worshipper of Calistria she'll be certain to seek revenge on those she escapes from.



SATINDER MORNE

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SATINDER MORNE CREATURE 6

UNIQUE | CN | MEDIUM | HUMANOID | HUMAN

Female human cleric of Calistria

Perception +15

Languages Common, Elven

Skills Gambling Lore +12, Deception +14, Diplomacy +12, Intimidation +12, Religion +13, Society +12, Stealth +12

Str +0, **Dex** +3, **Con** +1, **Int** +1, **Wis** +4, **Cha** +3

Items daggers (6), leather armor, religious symbol of Calistria, ruby ring worth 20 gp, 5 gp

AC 22; **Fort** +10, **Ref** +12, **Will** +15

HP 75

Vengeful Sting ↷ **Trigger** A creature damages Satinder Morne with a melee Strike; **Effect** Satinder Morne makes a melee Strike against the triggering creature. She suffers a –2 penalty on the attack roll but gains a +2 bonus on the damage roll if the Strike hits.

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ dagger +15 (agile, finesse, versatile S), **Damage** 1d4+6 piercing

Ranged ❖ dagger +14 (thrown 10 ft.), **Damage** 1d4+6 piercing

Divine Spells Prepared DC 23, attack +13; **3rd** *blindness*, *enthrall*, *heal*×4), *vampiric touch*; **2nd** *calm emotions*, *silence*, *undetectable alignment*; **1st** *charm*, *ray of enfeeblement*, *sanctuary*; **Cantrips (4th)** *detect magic*, *divine lance*, *light*, *prestidigitation*, *shield*

Cleric Domain Spells 1 Focus Point, DC 23; **1st** *charming touch*

Divine Font *heal*

Sneak Attack Satinder Morne deals 1d6 extra precision damage to flat-footed creatures.

Story Award: If the PCs secure Satinder's aid by making her helpful, award them XP as if they'd defeated her in combat.

DRELEV KEEP

Drelev Keep is a monument to Baron Drelev's vanity and self-interest. The corrupt ruler skimped on the construction of the city's wooden walls in favor of protecting himself with a keep of solid stone. Drelev Keep encompasses almost the entire hill, and the main gates represent the only obvious means of entering the structure. The keep's walls incorporate numerous watchtowers, including a larger main tower housing the baron and his retainers. Climbing the outer walls requires success on a DC 30 Athletics check. All of the outer windows are secured with wooden shutters and a 2nd-level *lock* spell, courtesy of Imeckus Stroon.

The ceilings reach 15 feet in most areas. Doors are made of reinforced wood and can be locked (DC 30 Thievery to Pick the Lock); each patrol of guards carries one master key among them that can unlock most of the keep's doors; a few locks (specified in the text) require unique keys. When combat starts, the guard carrying the key hangs back to provide ranged support; if it seems like the PCs are going to win the fight, the key-carrying guard flees to another group of guards, or performs an Interact action to break the key or throw it somewhere inaccessible rather than risk the PCs taking it.

If the alarm is raised in the keep, or if the PCs make their presence in town widespread (such as if they slaughter most or all of the town guards), Baron Drelev orders the keep into lockdown. In this case, guards move quickly through the building to lock all doors, and all guards on patrol are at heightened alert and gain a +2 circumstance bonus to Perception checks for 8 hours, after which the guards are exhausted and suffer a –2 penalty on Perception checks for the following 16 hours.

Many of the encounters with guards are trivial on their own; you should strive to have guards posted in nearby areas react quickly to the sounds of combat to help make these fights less repetitive and more dynamic and significant when they do occur. The PCs should fight 4 guards for a low-threat encounter, 5–6 guards for a moderate encounter, or 8 for a severe threat.

Drelev Keep encompasses numerous rooms and areas, many of which are not particularly important and are given only brief descriptions with no read-aloud text. Feel free to expand on these locations as you see fit during play—any of them could serve as places to hide or areas for combat to spill over into.

C1. FRONT GATE

The iron gate at the keep's entrance is kept closed and locked at all times (Thievery DC 30 to Pick the Lock).

C2. WATCHTOWERS SEVERE 11

Creatures: A pair of Drelev guards stands watch in each of these four watchtowers, their focus being on the eastern approach to the keep. If a fight breaks out in area **C3**, they'll emerge into the courtyard to join the battle.

DRELEV GUARDS (2 PER TOWER) CREATURE 8

See page 304

Initiative Perception +16

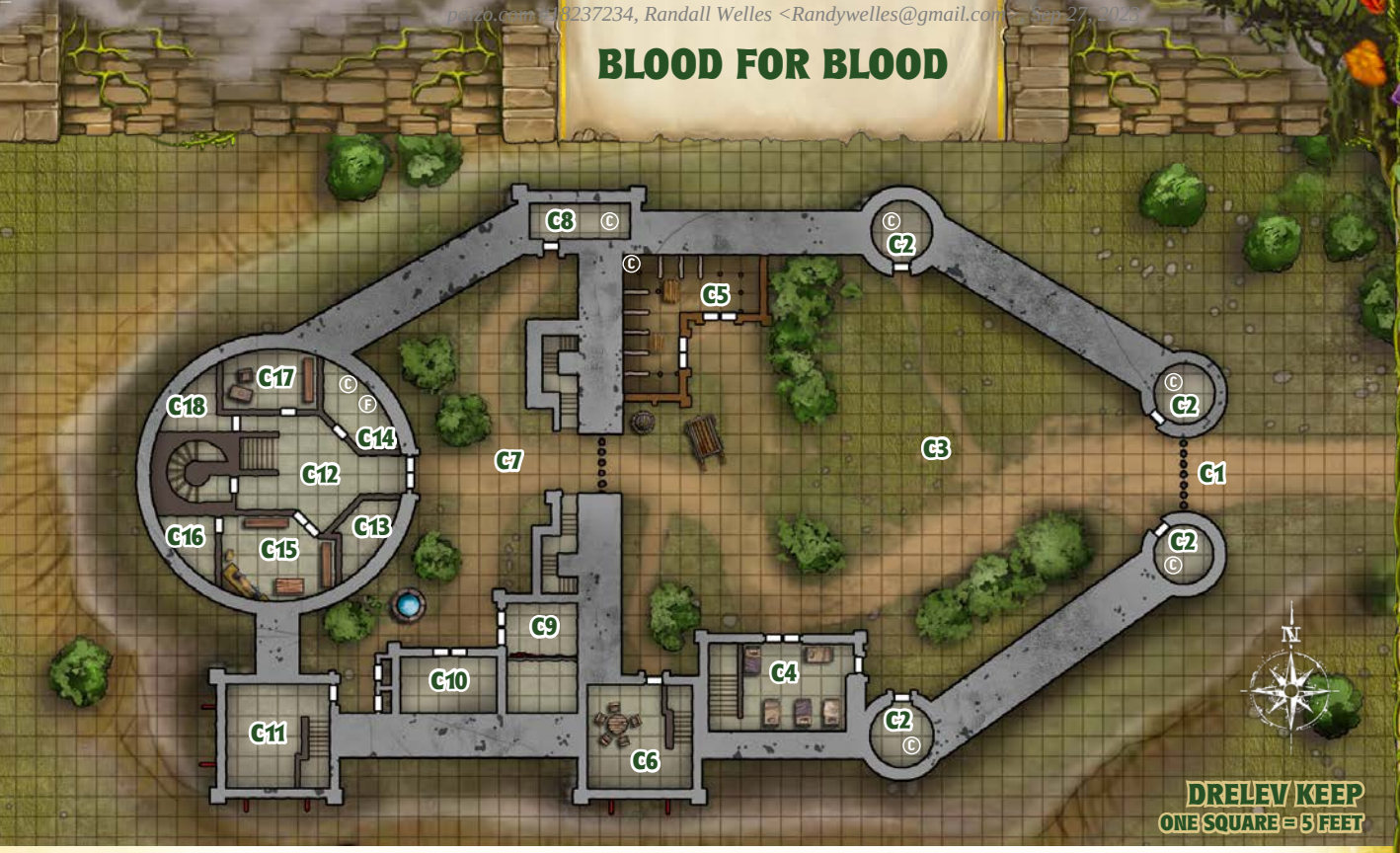
C3. COURTYARD MODERATE 11

A winding path tracks through this courtyard, leading past the windows of a two-story building and a large stable before ending at the inner wall's fifteen-foot gate.

Creatures: Irovetti left a group of six hill giants with the baron, both as a "gift" to help him defend his keep and as an implied threat should he betray Pitax. These giants are well-behaved, as far as hill giants go, since they're amused by the idea of living in a "person house"

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but primarily because Baron Drelev has managed to keep them happy with lots of food—mostly horses and cattle, but now and then an unruly prisoner.

In their spare time, they like harassing the guards. One night each week, the baron turns the giants loose on the city streets, allowing them to prowl at will during curfew. They have orders to not break any houses, but anyone they find breaking curfew is fair game.

HILL GIANT MERCENARIES (6) CREATURE 8

Elite hill giants (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 6, 170)
Initiative Perception +15

C4. BARRACKS MODERATE 11

Creatures: Six off-duty guards sleep in beds here. The stairs lead up to area **C22**.

DRELEV GUARDS (6) CREATURE 8

See page 304
Initiative Perception +16

C5. STABLE

Since all of the horses once kept here have been fed to the hill giants, this stable is now empty. A ladder in the northwest corner leads to area **C20**.

C6. MEETING ROOM

This room hasn't seen much use lately. A stairway leads up to **C23**.

C7. INNER COURTYARD

The gate into this inner yard is identical to the one at area **C1**; the stairs on either side lead up to area **C19**. A well here provides fresh water to the fortress.

C8. STORAGE

This side building is used to store grain, firewood, and other supplies. The stairs lead up to area **C21**.

C9. WASHROOM

This building houses several large tubs serving double duty for bathing and laundry.

C10. SERVANTS' QUARTERS

The keep's six beleaguered and frightened servants (all human commoners) live here. They won't alert the guards to the PCs' presence, but are too frightened to be of much help.

FRIGHTENED SERVANTS (6) CREATURE -1

Human servants (*Pathfinder Gamemastery Guide* 222)
Initiative Perception +9

C11. ARMORY

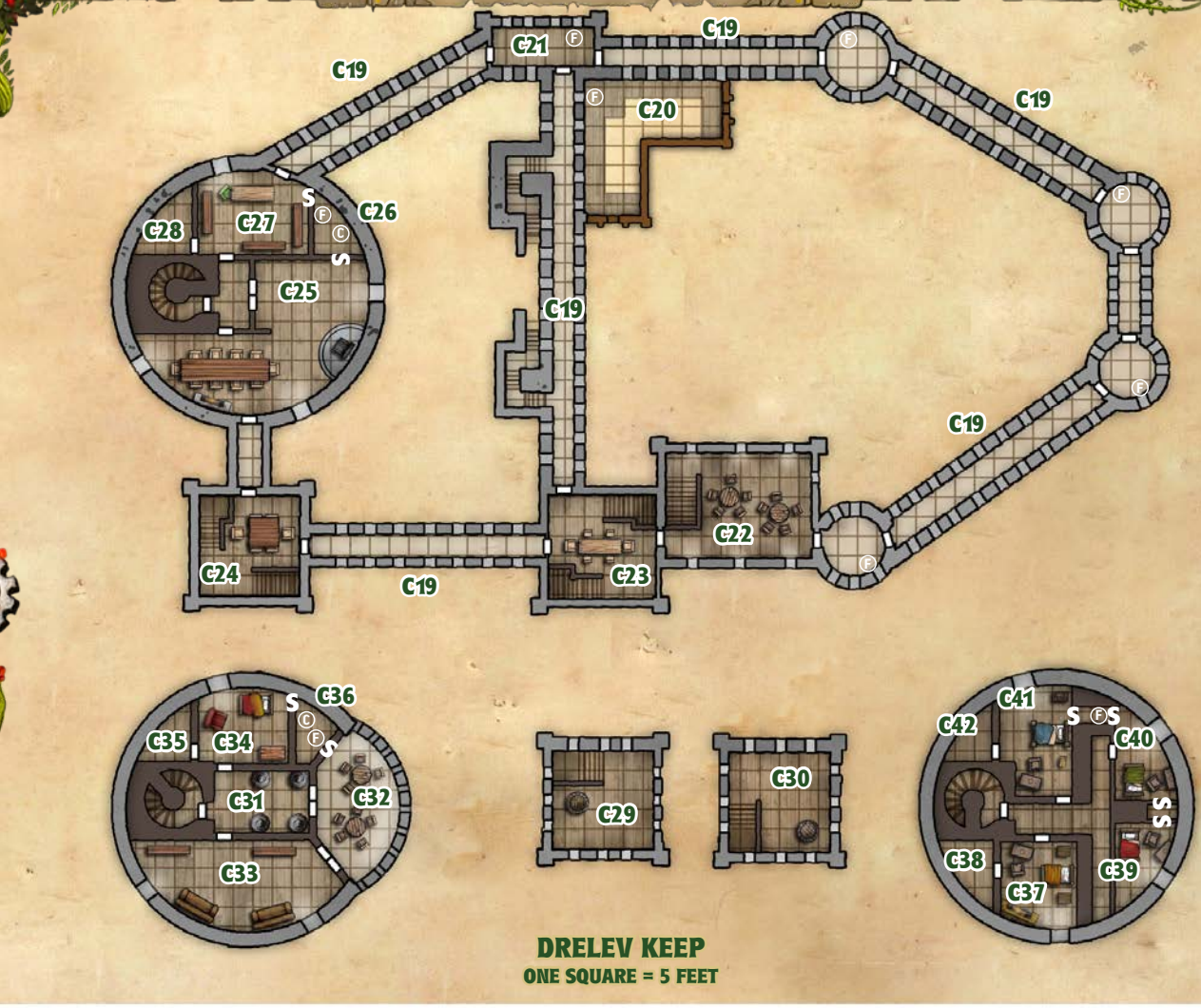
This chamber is used to store weapons and armor. Most of these are currently being used by the Drelev guards, but two longswords, three breastplates, and 120 arrows remain here. The stairs lead up to area **C24**.

C12. FOYER TRIVIAL 11

The flight of stairs to the northwest lead down to area **C43**. Just southwest of these stairs, a spiral stairwell beyond a door leads upward, connecting this floor to the second, third, and fourth floors of the tower above.

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DRELEV KEEP
ONE SQUARE = 5 FEET



Creatures: A pair of Drelev guards stand duty here. If confronted, they fight until one of them is reduced to fewer than 75 HP, at which point both of the guards panic and flee upstairs to the banquet room (area **C25**) to warn the baron rather than continue to fight.

DRELEV GUARDS (2) CREATURE 8

See page 304
Initiative Perception +16

C13. STOREROOM

This storeroom holds a collection of unused linens, tapestries, and seasonal decorations.

C14. CLOAKROOM

This chamber provides access to secret passages on each level of the main tower. Hidden trapdoors (requiring success on a DC 30 Perception check to notice) in the floor and ceiling provide access to ladders leading up to area **C26** and down to area **C48**. The trapdoor leading

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down is locked (DC 32 Thievery to Pick the Lock), but can be opened with a key carried by Baron Drelev.

C15. KITCHEN

This large room contains a stone fireplace set with roasting spits and a hanging cookpot containing a simmering stew.

C16. PANTRY

This storeroom contains cluttered shelves and stacks of crates and casks holding all manner of foodstuffs, seasonings, cooking oils, and preserved goods.

C17. WORKSHOP

This dry, dusty chamber holds a variety of tools and supplies for carpentry, leatherworking, sewing, and mortaring.

C18. WASHROOM

This chamber features a privy and a large washtub.

C19. KEEP WALLS

The tops of these walls are fitted with battlements that provide cover to archers posted here. Scaling these walls requires succeeding at a DC 30 Athletics check.

Creatures: A total of four guards patrol this area. If a fight breaks out in area **C3**, they'll support the hill giants there with ranged attacks, descending down to area **C2** and thence to the courtyard below to fight in melee if they see that the PCs are making their way toward area **C7** or an indoor area facing the courtyard.

DRELEV GUARDS (4) **CREATURE 8**

See page 304

Initiative Perception +16

C20. HAY LOFT

Several moldering bales of hay lie forgotten in this loft. Stealth checks attempted in this area gain a +4 circumstance bonus due to the numerous hiding spots.

C21. STORAGE

The upper floor of this storeroom is used to store extra furniture and tools.

C22. BARRACKS

Six off-duty guards are here, polishing weapons, playing cards, and eating.

DRELEV GUARDS (6) **CREATURE 8**

See page 304

Initiative Perception +16

C23. MESS HALL

The Drelev guards eat at their posts or in area **C22**—this room hasn't been used since the keep's surrender to Pitax. A stairway leads up to area **C30** and down to **C6**.



HANNIS DRELEV

C24. BRIEFING ROOM

Stairs lead down from this room to area **C11** and up to area **C29**.

C25. BANQUET ROOM SEVERE 11

Yellow and brown tiles cover the floor of this chamber, presenting a rich scheme of royal appointments leading to a raised dais and throne against the far wall. A pair of windows flanks the throne.

Creatures: Baron Drelev has taken to having his meals here with Lady Quintessa, though the Baroness refuses to sit at the table with them and has her dinner delivered to her room or to the balcony at **C32**. When Drelev entertains entreaties from his subjects, he sits on the throne. Lately, however, he has refused all appointments, growing more withdrawn as he considers his gamble to ally with Armag and the Tiger Lords. Only Lady Quintessa (area **C40**) helps ease his mind, sometimes keeping him company as he consults Imeckus Stroon for advice. Out of paranoia, he now keeps four guardsmen with him at all times as bodyguards; if the alarm is raised, he sends two of them to area **C37** to guard his wife while he takes the other two up to **C40** to guard his mistress.

Hannis Drelev sees the PCs' defeat as his only way forward. He's already had to surrender once, and his ego won't let him do so again, yet neither does he wish to die. If he's reduced to fewer than 100 HP, he'll flee into the caverns below the Keep and out the secret tunnel to make his way into the wilds. If cornered, he drops his weapons and begs for his life. If he escapes, or if the PCs grant him mercy and exile him, imprison him, or simply let him go, it's up to you to decide if he turns over a new leaf or comes back later as a recurring villain with a grudge and a thirst for revenge.

BARON HANNIS DRELEV **CREATURE 12**

See page 597

Initiative Perception +17

DRELEV GUARDS (4) **CREATURE 8**

See page 304

Initiative Perception +16

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C26. SECRET ROOM

The secret doors and trapdoors (one leads down to area **C14**, while the other leads up to area **C36**) here can be noticed with a DC 30 Perception check.

C27. LIBRARY LOW 11

Large bookcases dominate this room. A reading desk and chair sit by the window and a woolen rug covers the floor.

A parchment on the desk contains a map of the region on which Stroon has marked the location of Armag's campsite. Notes in the margins summarize the legend of the original Armag including the possibility that one of the barrow mounds might serve as his tomb.

Creatures: Stroon's dust mephit familiar, Lintwerth, has made a nest for himself on the top shelves of the library. He hides when the PCs enter the room, then attempts to sneak off to warn Stroon in **C34** (using *sending* if prevented from doing so). If confronted, he uses his breath weapon, then uses *elemental form* to take the shape of an earth elemental to fight, but flees to seek out Stroon if reduced to fewer than 60 HP.

LINTWERTH CREATURE 11

UNIQUE | LE | SMALL | AIR | EARTH | ELEMENTAL

Variant dust mephit (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 112)

Perception +22; darkvision

Languages Auran, Common, Terran

Skills Acrobatics +22, Stealth +22

Str +1, **Dex** +7, **Con** +3, **Int** +2, **Wis** +5, **Cha** +2

AC 32; **Fort** +18, **Ref** +24, **Will** +22

HP 180, fast healing 10 (in dust or sand); **Immunities** bleed, paralyzed, poison, sleep

Speed 20 feet, fly 35 feet

Melee ❖ claw +24 (agile, finesse); **Damage** 1d6+5 slashing

Arcane Innate Spells DC 30; **6th** *elemental form*; **5th** *sending*; **2nd** *glitterdust*

Breath Weapon ❖❖ (air, arcane, earth) Lintwerth breathes a cloud of dust in a 15-foot cone that deals 6d6 slashing damage to each creature within the area (DC 30 basic Reflex save). The air in this area remains thick with dust for the next 4 rounds; while Lintwerth is in this area his fast healing functions normally, but other breathing creatures who end their turn in the area must make a DC 30 Fortitude save or become sickened 1 (sickened 2 on a critical failure) from coughing on the dusty air. Lintwerth can't use Breath Weapon again for 1d4 rounds.

C28. WASHROOM

This chamber features a privy and a large washtub.

C29. AMEON'S CHAMBERS

This bedroom belongs to the captain of the guards, Ameon Trask. If he managed to escape the PCs' justice after the Battle for Tatzlford, he can be encountered here—he emerges to defend the keep with the rest of the guards if an alarm is raised. If Ameon is dead or captured, this room is empty—Drelev has no immediate plans to replace him. The stairs lead down to area **C24**.

C30. GUARD TOWER LOW 11

Creatures: Four guards are stationed here; if they notice fighting down below, they mobilize to join the fight as soon as possible.

DRELEV GUARDS (4) CREATURE 8

See page 304

Initiative Perception +16

C31. ART GALLERY

Treasure: The walls here hold recessed stone ledges containing sculptures and paintings. Baroness Pavetta filled this small antechamber with works of art brought from Brevoy. Her favorite pieces include ceremonial armor and garb decorating a statue of Choral the Conqueror (worth 100 gp) and a sculpture of the two-headed red dragon Veylmalourne (worth 70 gp).

C32. BALCONY

Two wrought-iron tables and outdoor chairs dominate this expansive balcony 30 feet above the inner bailey. Baroness Pavetta is particularly fond of taking her meals at one of the outdoor tables rather than in the dining hall. At night, Drelev's guards lock the double doors leading into areas **C31** and **C33**.

C33. BALLROOM

Several tapestries hang from the walls of this wide chamber, depicting a variety of distinctive floral patterns. This chamber once saw frequent use by Baron Drelev and Baroness Pavetta for throwing parties, hosting visiting dignitaries, or entertaining guests from town. When not spending time in her room, the baroness spends several hours a day here planning and dreaming up parties she might throw someday.

C34. IMECKUS'S BEDCHAMBER LOW 11

This bedroom contains elegant furnishings. A bed faces an open window along the north wall. A bookshelf stands to the west and a small table and chair sit next to the entrance.

Creatures: Imeckus Stroon, Baroness Pavetta's older brother, chose this room as his sleeping quarters while he's stationed at the keep. At his sister's invitation, he journeyed to the River Kingdoms to help the Drelevs against the Tiger Lords. He casts daily *scrying* spells

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to follow Armag's activities in the hills as part of the baron's strategy of letting the horrors of the burial site claim the warlord first.

The skilled wizard brings a level of organization and structure to every task he undertakes. Very detailed and analytical, he speaks softly and listens carefully. Like his sister, Stroon also enjoys the finer things in life, frequently relying on his magic to conjure or provide them. But having traveled widely, he also knows how to bear temporary inconveniences while treading a path to greater gain. Recently, and at his sister's request, Stroon has started to formulate plots to remove the baron and his mistress from power, but he hasn't taken any steps toward this tactic yet. He sees the PCs as a potential ally in this regard; before a fight begins, he asks them to hold and hear him out.

If the PCs agree to listen, Stroon suggests that the problems facing Drelev Keep would end if its namesake were to go away. If the PCs agree to take out the baron and his mistress (whom Stroon suspects is a spy, although he's not sure for whom) and remove the threat Armag poses to the region, Stroon promises that he and his sister will ally with the PCs. Stroon is forthright in this offer, but also remains self-centered and arrogant. If the PCs agree to aid him, he won't help them directly, but neither will he hinder them.

In combat, Imeckus seeks to prevent enemies from approaching him easily through tactical use of wall spells. He then uses his spells to pick foes off one at a time. If he's confronted in this room, such tactics are less effective, and as such one of his first objectives in battle is to lure the PCs into a larger area to fight—preferably by casting *fly* and then swooping out of the room's open window to use his spells from outside at PCs who remain in this chamber.

Stroon serves Drelev only as a courtesy to his sister, the baroness, not because he has any loyalty to the baron. If reduced below 40 hit points, he flees and attempts to escape to his home in Pitax—if he escapes, he uses *sending* to warn his sister to take care, but he won't return to Fort Drelev. In this case, feel free to have the PCs encounter Stroon again as you see fit later in the campaign.

Stroon allows his dust mephit familiar Lintwerth freedom to wander the keep—normally, Lintwerth can be found in area **C27**. If the PCs haven't defeated the mephit already, Imeckus uses his Recall Lintwerth action on the first round of combat to bring the familiar to his side.

IMECKUS STROON — CREATURE 12

UNIQUE | LE | MEDIUM | HUMANOID | HUMAN

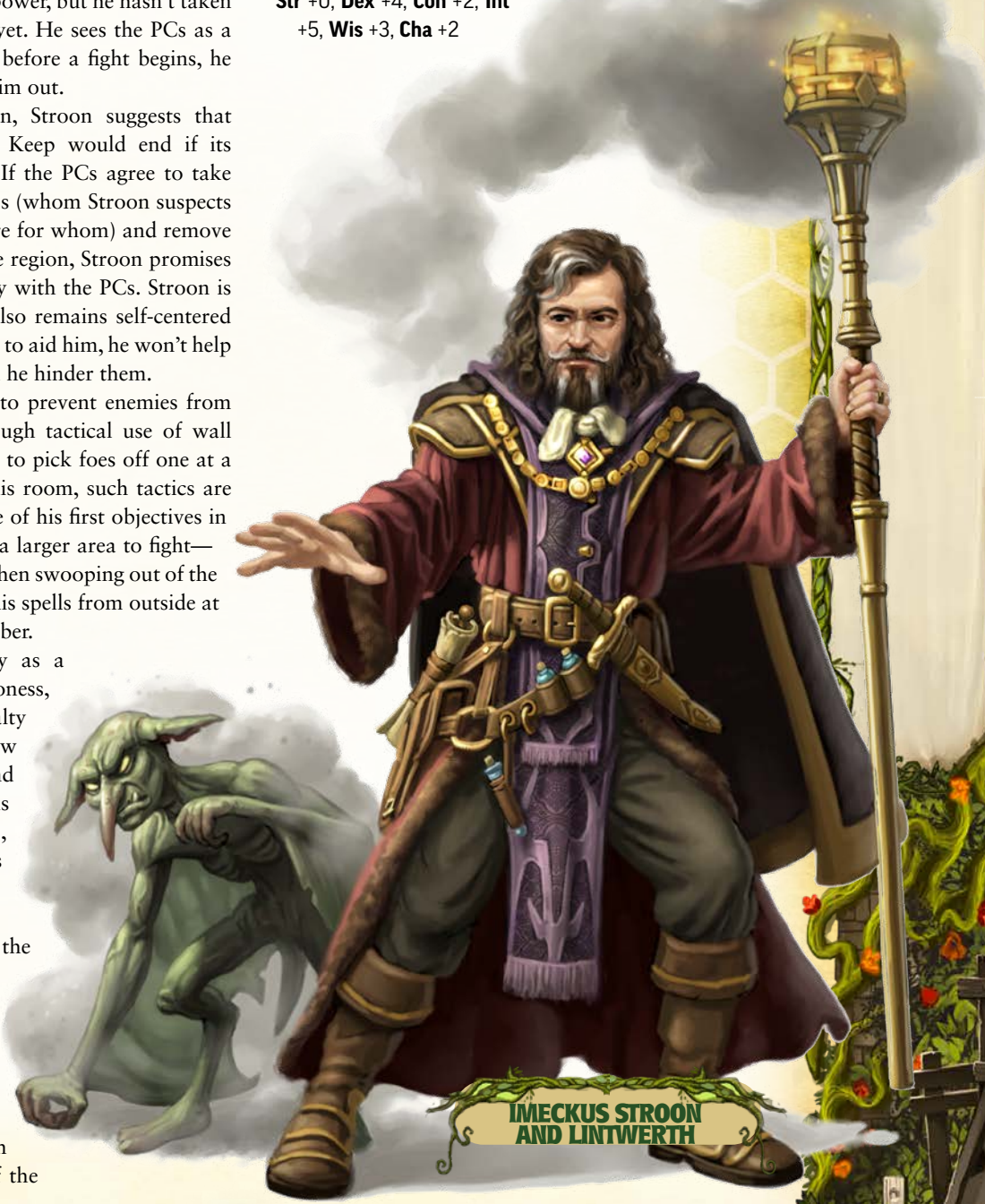
Male human wizard

Perception +25

Languages Auran, Common, Jotun, Hallit, Skald

Skills Academia Lore +25, Arcana +25, Crafting +23, Diplomacy +22, Nature +21, Occultism +25, Society +23

Str +0, **Dex** +4, **Con** +2, **Int** +5, **Wis** +3, **Cha** +2



IMECKUS STROON AND LINTWERTH

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Items dagger, *+1 major striking staff of fire* (7 charges), spellbook (*The Inward Flowing Source*—contains all prepared spells plus an additional 4 spells of each level of the GM's choice—including *lock*)

AC 33; **Fort** +21, **Ref** +23, **Will** +22

HP 210

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ *staff* +24 (two-hand d8), **Damage** 2d4+3 bludgeoning

Melee ❖ dagger +21 (agile, finesse, versatile S), **Damage** 1d4+3 piercing

Ranged ❖ dagger +21 (thrown 10 ft.), **Damage** 1d4+3 piercing

Arcane Spells Prepared DC 33, attack +23; **6th** *chain lightning*, *scrying*, *teleport*; **5th** *dispel magic*, *sending*, *wall of ice*; **4th** *discern lies*, *fly*, *wall of fire*; **3rd** *fireball*, *lightning bolt*, *wall of wind*; **2nd** *acid arrow*, *flaming sphere*, *lock*; **1st** *charm*, *magic missile*, *ray of enfeeblement*; **Cantrips (6th)** *detect magic*, *electric arc*, *light*, *produce flame*, *shield*

Drain Lintwerth ❖ (arcane) **Frequency** once per day; **Requirements** Imeckus hasn't yet acted on his turn and Lintwerth is in an adjacent square; **Effect** Imeckus draws power from his bond with his familiar. During his turn, he gains the ability to cast one spell he prepared today and already cast, without spending a spell slot. He must still Cast the Spell and meet the spell's other requirements.

Enhanced Familiar Imeckus Stroon's familiar Lintwerth is a loyal companion and is a bit more powerful than the standard familiar in that he does not possess the minion trait; Imeckus can direct Lintwerth's actions verbally as a free action. If Lintwerth is slain, Imeckus becomes drained 1 for 24 hours.

Steady Spellcasting If a reaction would disrupt Imeckus's spellcasting action, he attempts a DC 15 flat check; if he succeeds, his action isn't disrupted.

Recall Lintwerth ❖ (arcane, conjuration, teleportation) Imeckus calls out Lintwerth's name and snaps his fingers, causing his dust mephit familiar (and up to 1 Bulk of objects carried by Lintwerth) to instantly transport to an adjacent square of Imeckus' choice, providing Lintwerth is within a mile.

Quickened Casting ❖ (concentrate, metamagic) **Frequency** once per day; **Effect** If Imeckus's next action is to cast a cantrip or spell that is 4th level or lower, reduce the number of actions to cast it by 1 (minimum 1 action).

Reward: If the PCs agree to work with Imeckus and his sister, grant them 80 XP.

C35. WASHROOM

This chamber features a privy and a large washtub.

C36. SECRET ROOM

The secret doors and trapdoors here can be noticed with success on a DC 30 Perception check. One leads down to area **C26**, while the other leads up to the hallway between areas **C40** and **C41**.

C37. BARONESS'S BEDCHAMBER TRIVIAL 11

Elegant silk hangings cover most of the wall space in this elaborately decorated bedroom, expertly framing the large window looking south. A canopy bed takes up the center of the room, with teak end tables placed to either side. A small writing desk and cushioned stool also stand along the north wall, and a large fireplace in the south corner heats the room comfortably.

Creatures: Baroness Pavetta Stroon-Drelev is a creature devoted to excess and comfort, and her bedchamber reflects her personality in every way. Long before Hannis Drelev was chosen to lead a settlement attempt of the Slough, she was a master of the game of social politics and quite enjoyed life in Brevoy. Originally, she balked at the idea of joining him in the "gods-forsaken frontier." But since arriving, Pavetta has discovered the pleasing advantages of holding the highest social stature of anyone within dozens, if not hundreds of miles. She enjoys lording over the simple folk of the Drelev Demesne and now grows agitated over the possibility of losing control of the region to the bloodthirsty warlord Armag.

Baroness Pavetta has made her wishes to cut ties with the Tiger Lords well known to her husband, but she senses he's too weak to know how to handle the unpredictable warriors. Recently, she encouraged the baron to contact her brother, Imeckus Stroon, a powerful and well-traveled wizard. She hoped to use Imeckus's arcane skills to undo her husband's mess for him. But now that Drelev has shown an eye for the pretty young Lady Quintessa, the baroness has quietly encouraged her brother to find the means to "accidentally" remove the baron and his mistress from the picture as well, and she is preparing to assume complete control of Fort Drelev herself. As with her brother, the baroness sees the PCs as a handy tool, and offers them a similar alliance to her brother's (see area **C34**) if they agree to listen to her before they attack.

The baroness is rarely seen without Jewel, her shrill, obnoxious, and almost unbearably noisy little dog. Although ferocious and brave, Jewel is little more than a nuisance in combat. This doesn't prevent the baroness from using the dog for defense. The baroness isn't a particularly threatening combatant, and she surrenders in the face of any real show of force as soon as she's reduced below 75 Hit Points. She's also excellent at harboring grudges and does her best to keep an eye out for any opportunity to cause trouble for the PCs if they grant her mercy after they attack her.

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PAVETTA STROON-DRELEV — CREATURE 9

UNIQUE | NE | MEDIUM | HUMANOID | HUMAN

Female human baroness

Perception +19

Languages Common, Skald

Skills Deception +19, Diplomacy +19, Intimidation +19, Nature +17, Nobility Lore +17, Performance +15, Society +17

Str +0, **Dex** +2, **Con** +2, **Int** +2, **Wis** +4, **Cha** +4

Items dagger, emerald ring worth 50 gp, royal outfit worth 60 gp, sapphire earrings worth 80 gp, gold signet ring worth 60 gp

AC 25; **Fort** +15, **Ref** +15, **Will** +21

HP 150

Vengeful Rage ↻ (emotion, mental) **Trigger** Jewel is either killed or knocked unconscious; **Effect** Pavetta flies into a rage. She gains 20 temporary Hit Points, gains a +4 circumstance bonus on attack rolls, and deals 4d6 additional damage with melee weapons. In addition, she becomes confused. This rage persists for 1 minute or until she ceases to be confused, after which she becomes fatigued.

Speed 25 feet

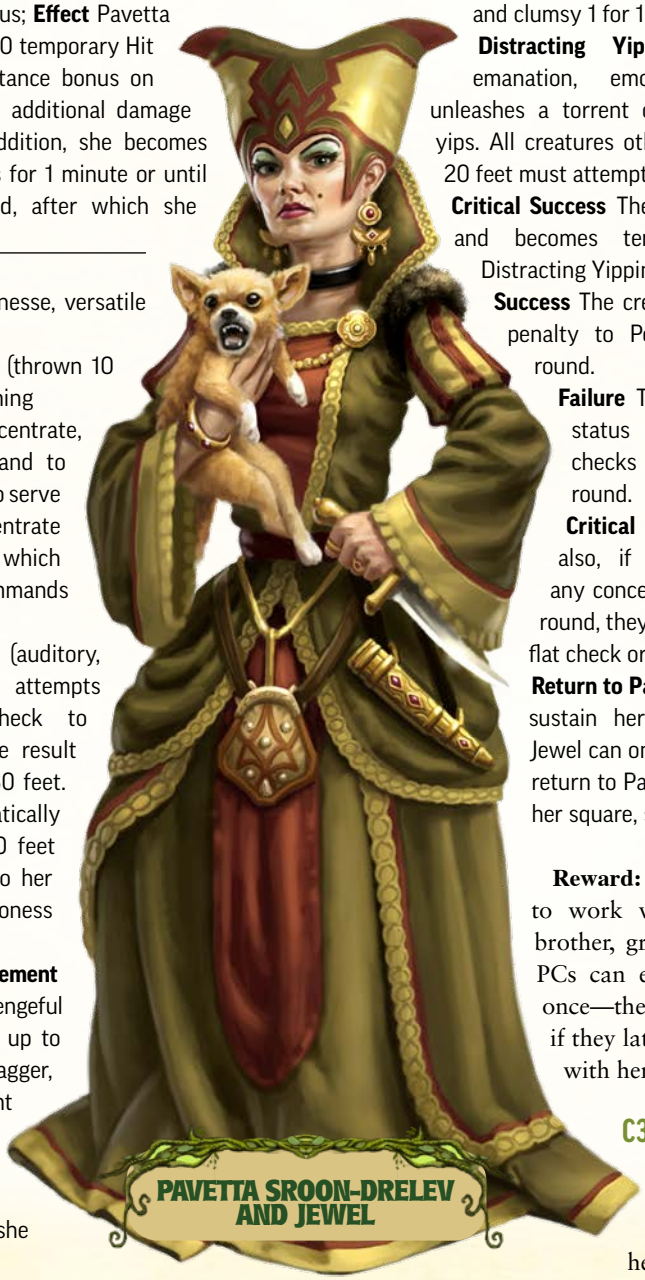
Melee ❖ dagger +17 (agile, finesse, versatile S), **Damage** 1d4+3 piercing

Ranged ❖ thrown object +17 (thrown 10 ft.), **Damage** 1d6+3 bludgeoning

Release Jewel ❖ (auditory, concentrate, manipulate) With a command to Jewel, Pavetta releases her to serve as a minion. She must concentrate to sustain this ability, during which she continues to shout commands to the little dog.

Baroness's Scream ❖❖ (auditory, emotion, mental) Pavetta attempts a single Intimidation check to Demoralize and applies the result to every opponent within 30 feet. Additionally, she automatically alerts any allies within 100 feet that are able to hear her to her need for assistance. The baroness can't Scream for 1 round.

Stabbing Fit ❖❖ **Requirement** Pavetta is affected by Vengeful Rage. **Effect** Pavetta makes up to five melee Strikes with her dagger, each against a different target. These attacks count toward her multiple attack penalty, but the penalty doesn't increase until after she makes all of her attacks.



PAVETTA SROON-DRELEV AND JEWEL

JEWEL — MINION

UNIQUE | N | TINY | ANIMAL | MINION

Ferocious little dog

Perception +21; low-light vision, scent (imprecise) 30 feet

Skills Acrobatics +19, Intimidate +17

Str –2, **Dex** +4, **Con** +2, **Int** –4, **Wis** +4, **Cha** +2

AC 29; **Fort** +17, **Ref** +21, **Will** +19

HP 60

Speed 30 feet

Melee ❖ jaws +19 (agile, finesse), **Damage** 1d4+1 piercing plus Ankle Bite

Ankle Bite If Jewel damages a Small or larger creature standing on the ground with her jaws Strike, that creature becomes flat-footed for 1 round (or flat-footed and clumsy 1 for 1 round on a critical hit).

Distracting Yipping ❖❖ (auditory, emanation, emotion, mental) Jewel unleashes a torrent of grating, high-pitched yips. All creatures other than Pavetta within 20 feet must attempt a DC 25 Will save.

Critical Success The creature is unaffected and becomes temporarily immune to Distracting Yipping for 24 hours.

Success The creature takes a –2 status penalty to Perception checks for 1 round.

Failure The creature takes a –4 status penalty to Perception checks and is flat-footed for 1 round.

Critical Failure As failure, but also, if the creature attempts any concentrate action during the round, they must succeed at a DC 11 flat check or the action is lost.

Return to Pavetta If Pavetta doesn't sustain her Release Jewel action, Jewel can only take Stride actions to return to Pavetta's square. If she's in her square, she takes no actions.

Reward: If the PCs agree to work with Pavetta and her brother, grant them 80 XP. The PCs can earn this reward only once—they don't earn it again if they later make the same deal with her brother.

C38. CLOSET

Treasure: Baroness Pavetta stores her elaborate wardrobe here. The closet contains

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ALTERNATIVE JEWELS

While Jewel is intended to be a frustrating nuisance, some groups won't be comfortable with a small dog in a fight. You know your group best, so make sure to adjust this encounter to match your table's preferences. If you do so, you can rule that Jewel is merely knocked unconscious if reduced to 0 HP. Alternatively, you can simply have Jewel be a flavorful, noisy addition to the combat rather than a participant. Pavetta isn't a loving mistress to the dog, so if she's slain, Jewel doesn't mourn her passing. In such an event, Jewel can potentially be adopted by a PC as a pet, or potentially an animal companion or familiar if a PC has such an option.

two dozen royal outfits, complete with a collection of accompanying footgear, headdresses, scarves, and decorative shawls. She considers most of the outfits already woefully out of fashion, but she keeps them for their sentimental value. The entire collection is worth 800 gp.

C39. GUEST BEDROOM

This currently unoccupied bedroom includes a large bed draped in rose-pink blankets.

C40. LADY QUINTESSA'S BEDCHAMBER TRIVIAL 11

This richly appointed bedroom includes a decorative, handmade bed with a carved headboard depicting satyrs and nymphs at play. Lavender curtains match the bed's blankets; they trim a massive window that overlooks the inner courtyard.

Creatures: This bedchamber belongs to Lady Quintessa Maray, Baron Drelev's lover and (currently unknown to the baron) a spy from the distant River Kingdom of Daggermark. Quintessa has used her natural talents and skills to convince Baron Drelev that she's a poor, exiled noblewoman from Galt in need of shelter. Since moving into Drelev Keep, she has maneuvered to become his mistress—a fact that sits none too well with Baroness Pavetta. Drelev often uses the secret passage between their rooms to visit her at night. It's certainly become clear to the keep's inhabitants that the baron dotes on her far more than a married man should.

Quintessa knows the arrival of Imeckus Stroon serves as a harbinger for new developments in the Drelev Demesne. So far, her charms have proven fruitless in enticing him to share any of the plans he's made with his sister. Quintessa also senses the disdain Baroness Pavetta holds for her, but she hopes that she'll be able to keep going for at least a few more weeks to learn more information for her contacts in Daggermark.

Quintessa has no real interest in fighting the party on her own; her first act in a battle if she's caught alone is to cast *dimension door* to flee to wherever she suspects Baron Drelev might be, so she can both warn him and recruit his aid. If the baron or his guards are present, Quintessa focuses on supporting her allies with spells and *inspire courage*. She particularly likes using *confusion* or other distracting magic on enemies, as she enjoys seeing cooperation and well-laid plans fall apart. She surrenders immediately if she has no escape route and no allies left, or as soon as she's brought below 60 Hit Points.

If the PCs defeat Baron Drelev before they encounter Quintessa, or if she surrenders to them, she feigns dismay at being held a veritable hostage in the tower while the baron and baroness allowed Tiger Lords and giants to control things. If the PCs fall for the ruse, she works at developing a relationship with the PCs to ensure she is close at hand to keep tabs on them. Daggermark isn't scheduled to play a major role in the rest of Kingmaker, but it could become an important player if you intend to keep playing this campaign beyond the conclusion of the Adventure Path. In time, she may even come to value her PC friends and switch allegiances to the PCs' kingdom, but exactly how loyal she'll remain to the PCs and their kingdom in such a development is left to you.

QUINTESSA MARAY CREATURE 11

UNIQUE | CN | MEDIUM | HUMANOID | HUMAN

Female human bard

Perception +20

Languages Common, Elven

Skills Acrobatics +19, Deception +24, Diplomacy +20, Performance +22, Society +21, Stealth +21, Thievery +23

Str +0, **Dex** +4, **Con** +2, **Int** +2, **Wis** +3, **Cha** +5

Items *+1 striking silver dagger*, *+1 glamered chain shirt*, mithral necklace worth 30 gp

AC 32; **Fort** +19, **Ref** +23, **Will** +20

HP 145

Damsel Act ↻ (mental) **Trigger** A critical hit is scored against Lady Quintessa; **Effect** Lady Quintessa exaggerates the impact of the blow, attempting to trick her foes into underestimating her as weak and frail. She makes a Feint attempt against the triggering creature. If she successfully performs her Damsel Act while she has an *inspire courage* composition active, the duration of that composition increases by 1 round.

Speed 30 feet

Melee ❖ *dagger* +23 (agile, finesse, versatile S), **Damage** 2d4+4 piercing

Bard Spontaneous Spells DC 30, attack +22; **6th** (2 slots)

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feeblemind, *spirit blast*; **5th** (3 slots) *hallucination*, *sending*, *subconscious suggestion*; **4th** (3 slots) *confusion*, *dimension door*, *glibness*; **3rd** (3 slots) *haste*, *mind reading*, *vampiric touch*; **2nd** (3 slots) *dispel magic*, *invisibility*, *mirror image*; **1st** (3 slots) *charm*, *soothe*, *sleep*; **Cantrips (6th)** *dancing lights*, *ghost sound*, *prestidigitation*, *shield*, *telekinetic projectile*

Bard Composition Spells 2 Focus Points, DC 30; **6th** *inspire heroics*; **Cantrips (6th)** *inspire courage*

Quickened Casting ◆ (concentrate, metamagic) **Frequency** once per day; **Effect** If Quintessa's next action is to cast a bard cantrip or a bard spell that is 4th level or lower, reduce the number of actions to cast it by 1 (minimum 1 action).

Signature Spells Quintessa can heighten the following spells freely: *dimension door*, *dispel magic*, *hallucination*, *soothe*, and *vampiric touch*.

C41. BARON DRELEV'S BEDCHAMBER

Baron Hannis Drelev claims the largest bedroom of the upper tower as his own. During the day, he rarely spends time here, while at night, he often sneaks over to area **C40** to spend time with his mistress, Lady Quintessa, using the secret passage to the east (DC 30 Perception check to detect this secret door).

C42. WASHROOM

This chamber features a privy and a washtub.

C43. CELLAR

This cold, earth-floored cellar helps keep food from spoiling as quickly as it would in the upstairs pantry. The door to area **C46** is an iron door that is always kept locked—a key carried by the baron himself can unlock this door, as can a key carried by a guard stationed in area **C47**.

C44. WINE CELLAR

Baron Drelev keeps a wide selection of spirits on hand in his wine cellar. Something of a connoisseur, he has collected Taldan fire-brandy, liquor from Andoran, and delicate berry wines out of the elven nation of Kyonin. In all, his wine cellar holds 119 bottles representing 48 separate vintages. The entire collection is worth 600 gp, and ironically represents a greater treasure than what is now kept in the actual vault nearby.

The secret door to area **C48** is locked (DC 32 to Pick the Lock) and can be found with success on a DC 30 Perception check.

C45. TREASURE VAULT

Despite the fact that much of the keep's treasure has already gone on as tribute, the baron always keeps the iron door to this room locked. This lock can be Picked with success on a DC 35 Thievery check.

Treasure: All that remains here are 11 pp, 97 gp, 492 sp, 160 cp, and 10 silver ingots bearing the baron's personal seal, each worth 5 gp.

C46. DUNGEON

Five cells, complete with meticulously crafted iron bars and doors, fill most of this cold, musty dungeon.

The middle cell along the eastern wall rarely holds prisoners since it also includes a locked secret door (DC 30 Perception to detect, DC 32 to Pick the Lock) into the baron's prized treasure vault and the caverns below the keep.



QUINTESSA MARAY

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The door to area **C47** is generally kept open; unless the alarm has been raised or a lot of noise (such as by bashing down a door) is generated here, the sound of two guards playing cards in area **C47** is obvious to anyone who manages to enter this room quietly.

Creatures: Currently, the largest cell along the northern wall contains Kisandra's father, Lord Terrion Numesti. The other cells stand empty since Baron Drelev released the former prisoners and pressed them into service as part of the army that attacked Tatzlford. Those who refused to go were fed to the giants that now guard the Keep's courtyard. Captured PCs are likely to end up in these cells.



Terrion himself is in poor health but remains determined to defy Drelev to the bitter end. He would like nothing more than to take up arms against the corrupt baron, but his responsibilities to his family weigh more heavily on his mind. If the PCs rescue him (DC 30 Thievery to Pick the cell's Lock), he thanks them by pledging his life to their service. He prefers to escape the keep as soon as possible to seek out his daughters, but if armed and armored, he agrees to aid the PCs with their remaining tasks in the keep.

Terrion's statistics presented below in parentheses represent his statistics when the PCs rescue him from the prison, while he is unarmed, fatigued, and clad in prisoner's clothing. His personal gear is long gone along with other tributes sent to Irovetti and Armag, but if rescued he attempts to arm and armor himself with gear taken from a Drelev guard. In this case, you can treat his stats instead as an elite Drelev guard.

TERRION NUMESTI — CREATURE 9

UNIQUE | NG | MEDIUM | HUMANOID | HUMAN

Male human soldier

Perception +18

Languages Common

Skills Athletics +20, Intimidation +18

Str +4, **Dex** +2, **Con** +4, **Int** +0, **Wis** +2, **Cha** +2

AC 24 (23 while fatigued); **Fort** +20 (+19 while fatigued), **Ref** +16 (+15 while fatigued), **Will** +18 (+17 while fatigued)

HP 155 (currently 50)

Attack of Opportunity ↷

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ fist +18 (versatile P), **Damage** 1d4+10 slashing

Formation Fighter Terrion gains a +2 circumstance bonus on attack and damage rolls as long as he is adjacent to at least two other allies.

Intimidating Strike ❖❖ (emotion, fear, mental) Terrion makes a melee Strike. If he hits and deals damage, the target is frightened 1, or frightened 2 on a critical hit.

C47. GUARD ROOM — TRIVIAL 11

Creatures: This cramped room contains a very small table and a pair of chairs—furnishings to give a bit of comfort to the two guards stationed here. The dungeon's sole occupant is well behaved, but "dungeon duty," as the Drelev guards call it, is nevertheless one of the least desirable posts in the keep, since the accommodation is uncomfortable at best. The guards have been trying to while away the hours playing cards and are deep into their game—they suffer a –2 circumstance penalty to Perception checks as a result as long as the alarm hasn't been raised. If they're attacked, the guards attack at once but as soon as one is dropped below 40 Hit Points, they try to flee upstairs to gather more guards to return in force.

DRELEV GUARDS (2) — CREATURE 8

See page 304

Initiative Perception +16

Items one guard carries the keys to area **C46** and the cells found within.

C48. SECRET VAULT

A table sits in the southeast corner of this dusty chamber, its velvet-lined surface displaying a number of precious stones and pieces of jewelry. A couple of large, ornately carved cedar trunks take up the other corners of the room.

Baron Drelev keeps this vault hidden from all but his most trusted senior officers, as it contains priceless treasures collected over his many years. Accessing the room requires entry through one of three secret doors (DC 30 Perception to detect) or the hidden trapdoor from the cloakroom (area **C14**). All of these doors are locked (DC 32 Thievery to Pick the Lock).

Treasure: Upon the display table rests a golden yellow topaz worth 50 gp, a deep blue spinel worth 40 gp, an amethyst worth 35 gp, a chrysoberyl worth 10 gp, five freshwater pearls worth 10 gp each, and eight moonstones worth 5 gp each. The table also holds a golden circlet worth 75 gp, which the baron wears only on special occasions.

In one of the cedar chests, Drelev has stored valuable gear taken from various prisoners and would-be

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heroes whom he captured and sent on to their fates among the Tiger Lords. It includes a suit of *+1 resilient leather armor*, a set of *druid's vestments*, an *oathbow*, a moderate elixir of life, a greater antidote, and four doses of wyvern poison. Any gear taken from PC prisoners is stored here as well.

In another chest, the baron has stored a variety of treasures taken from the Tiger Lords' barrow mounds worth a total of 150 gp. Among these treasures is a *greater ring of acid resistance* made of green wood carved to depict a snake and a lizard locked in a tangle. This ring is a companion to the *ring of the tiger* hidden in the warrior cairn in encounter site **NM1**.

C49. LIMESTONE CAVERN

When Baron Drelev designed his keep, he purposefully built it over these natural limestone caverns to take advantage of their access to the lakeshore as an emergency evacuation route in the event of an attack. He occasionally uses this entrance to smuggle in goods or visitors he wishes to keep away from prying eyes.

C50. STORAGE CAVE

Treasure: Success on a DC 25 Perception check is all that's needed to discover a hidden stash tucked into a nook on the northern wall of this cavern. Within a *knapsack of halfingkind* are stored emergency supplies should the baron need to flee the keep: several days of trail rations, four *potions of flying* (to aid in both speeding through area **C51** out of reach from its denizens and swift escape from the region), and four *greater healing potions*.

C51. UNDERGROUND POOL SEVERE 11

The stone walls of this massive cavern bear signs of discoloration from occasional flooding, no doubt due to water from Lake Hooktongue entering through the eastern passage when the lake rises during the rainy season. Stagnant runoff has collected in a natural limestone basin of filthy water to the north. An iron gate caked with rust blocks a tunnel to the west.

The iron gate can be opened from the west side by pulling a lever on the wall ten feet down the tunnel to the west, but from the east, the gate must either be destroyed or Forced Open—fortunately, the gate's poor repair makes this a little easier than for most iron gates (Hardness 16, 60 HP (30 BT), DC 28 Force Open).

The tunnel to the east ends at a secret door that opens onto the beach of Lake Hooktongue (area **B5**) at the base of a ridge just outside of Fort Drelev.

Creatures: This cavern and the tunnel to the east existed before the castle was built; Drelev incorporated it into his design as an escape tunnel. The cavern has recently become the lair of a pair of particularly dangerous black puddings that have adapted to an amphibious environment; these rare variants are known as fen puddings. Originally, the baron intended to slay them, but when he recruited Imeckus Stroon to aid in burning the deadly oozes out, the wizard convinced him to leave the monsters as "free guards." The oozes are content to remain here as long as Imeckus tosses a few slabs of meat to them every few days (usually from livestock, but now and then unfortunate prisoners), and in the meantime, the wizard has been studying the monsters in hopes of finding a safe way to harvest portions of their protoplasmic material as weapons.

When the PCs arrive, it has been a day since the oozes have been fed—or longer, if the PCs' actions have prevented Stroon's feedings—so if after 1 round no food has been tossed into the waters, the oozes surge up out of the pool to attack, using Stealth for initiative. They pursue fleeing PCs relentlessly—canny players can potentially use the oozes' tenacity to lead them up into the keep and loose them on the guards.

FEN PUDDINGS (2) CREATURE 12

RARE | N | HUGE | AMPHIBIOUS | MINDLESS | OOZE

Variant black pudding (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 255)
Perception +15; motion sense 60 feet, no vision
Skills Athletics +26, Stealth +23
Str +7, **Dex** –5, **Con** +7, **Int** –5, **Wis** +0, **Cha** –5
Motion Sense As black pudding.

AC 20; **Fort** +26, **Ref** +11, **Will** +16
HP 300; **Immunities** acid, critical hits, mental, piercing, precision, slashing, unconscious, visual
Corrosive Mass As black pudding, but DC 29 Reflex.
Split As black pudding.

Speed 20 feet, swim 20 feet
Melee ❖ pseudopod +26 (reach 10 feet), **Damage** 2d8+12 bludgeoning plus 2d8 acid, corrosive touch, and Grab
Constrict ❖ 1d8+12 bludgeoning plus 1d6 acid, DC 32
Corrosive Touch As black pudding.

CLAIMING DRELEV

Once the PCs have amassed 20 Liberation Points and overthrown the baron, the government of Drelev quickly collapses and its hexes become uncontrolled and ripe for annexation by the PCs and their kingdom. The PCs may have the chance to ally with remaining named NPCs, or they might hunt them down and confront them. In any event, kingdom expansion into the region (zone 11) will no longer be opposed by the baron, and Fort Drelev itself becomes a freehold that can be integrated normally (see Appendix 2). See page 104 of Chapter 2 for full details on Fort Drelev's currently constructed structures.

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PART 3:

THE TWICE-BORN WARLORD

Armag's Tomb was built unknown ages ago to inter the bones of Armag, one of the Tiger Lords' greatest heroes, and his legendary magic sword *Ovinrbaane*, a weapon sacred to the faith of Gorum. Today, this tomb serves as a testing ground intended to reveal the God of War's next champion.

ARMAG'S TOMB

In the earliest days of the Tiger Lords' history, the original Armag led his people out of the Realm of the Mammoth Lords and into Numeria. They clashed repeatedly with others, eventually pushing through the Rostland plains to clash against the Iobarian warlords and centaurs of Casmaron. These conflicts hardened Armag, forging him into a legendary champion who earned the direct favor of Gorum, the Iron Lord and god of war.

Pride was Armag's weakness. He boasted he would live forever—that death herself couldn't slay him. Pharasma heard his boasts and was offended, and her anger manifested as psychopomps aided Armag's enemies or sought to lay him low on the battlefield. This angered Gorum, who had come to enjoy Armag's audacity and brutal nature, and as Armag fought against his enemies on the Material Plane, Pharasma and Gorum engaged in a battle of wits in the Great Beyond over the ultimate fate of Armag's soul. When Armag finally succumbed and died on the field of battle, laid low by a mighty red dragon who served neither deity, Gorum intervened and infused Armag's soul

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into his sword *Ovinrbaane*, preventing his soul from entering the Boneyard. He then sent visions to a Tiger Lord priest named Zorek, inspiring him to construct a fitting tomb for the Iron Lord's champion—a tomb that would be sufficiently protected with traps and guardians to test any who might come to claim the legendary sword. Gorum also elevated Zorek into a supernatural guardian to watch over the tomb, charging him with slaying the unworthy and adding their souls to the ranks of those keeping Armag out of Pharasma's reach.

Pharasma, in her own inscrutable way, allowed all of this to occur, for it had been Armag's fate. Still, she brooded for an eon before losing interest, while Gorum eventually moved on to other distractions as well. And so, for several centuries, just as the Tiger Lords themselves became estranged from their own past, Armag's legacy dwindled into obscurity among the minds of mortals and gods alike.

This history of Armag's Tomb is very obscure—success on a DC 35 Religion check or a DC 30 check in an appropriate Lore skill (such as Gorum Lore, Pharasma Lore, or Warfare Lore) is needed to recall the legend. Alternatively, a PC who uses *read omens* or similar divination magic in Armag's Tomb could learn fragments of this history, depending upon what legends they seek.

FINDING THE TOMB

Armag's Tomb and the Tiger Lord camp itself lie in encounter site **TL3** in zone 12. While the PCs could certainly stumble across this site while exploring the hills, they can also learn of its location from the map found in Fort Drelev's library (area **C27**). If the PCs don't recover this important clue, after they've liberated Fort Drelev, NPC allies (likely one of the Numestis, but potentially someone like Quintessa or Imeckus, eager to prove their worth to their new rulers) can discover this map and bring the information to the PCs' attention. Kingmaker assumes that the PCs travel to Armag's Tomb well before Armag himself emerges, but if the PCs take too long, at your option the Twice-Born Warlord could rise to gather vast armies to his banner, forcing several mass conflicts against the Tiger Lords before the PCs are able to track him down to this location.

FATE OF THE IRON WRAITHS

At the start of this campaign, an adventuring party known as the Iron Wraiths were considered by Restov and Lady Jamandi to be the most capable group they were sending out into the Stolen Lands. It was for this reason the group was assigned to the dangerous hills known collectively as Glenebon, yet after these four adventurers accept their charter during Chapter 1, the PCs hear very little of them, and for a good reason: the Iron Wraiths' greatest strength was not their skill and power, but their ability to oversell their capabilities. This, combined with the group's pride, doomed them to failure.

If the PCs were intrigued by the appearance of the four heavily armored adventurers at the start of this Adventure Path, they may well seek more information about them as the campaign progresses. They can do so by attempting to Gather Information—at any time before the end of Chapter 4, a DC 20 Diplomacy check to Gather Information is enough to dig up rumors that the Iron Wraiths set their sights against the Tiger Lords of Glenebon, and made their way west along Brevoy's southern border before heading south into the hills just beyond Wyvernstone Bridge, where news of their clashes with raiders and hill giants alike inspires tavern tales and promotes speculation about what sort of nation the Iron Wraiths might be seeking to found.

Once Chapter 5 begins, though, no further news of the Iron Wraiths is forthcoming. Success at a DC 25 Diplomacy check to Gather Information confirms that the last known sighting of the Iron Wraiths was as they were heading deep into Tiger Lord territory, seeking

WHO WERE THE IRON WRAITHS?

The four adventurers known as the Iron Wraiths all wore distinctive suits of heavy armor with full helms. Fond of spreading rumors that they were indeed wraiths within suits of armor, these four adventurers were all very much alive until they perished in Armag's Tomb. Success at a DC 20 Diplomacy check to Gather Information is enough to learn a bit more about the Iron Wraiths, including the fact that the fighter Quain provided special training to the others allowing them to utilize the full plate armor they wore. The information in parentheses is revealed only with critical success on the check.

Quain Kortun: A male human Taldan fighter from Galt who fought with a magic (electricity infused) warhammer and was the leader of the group.

Kralanx: A female half-orc ranger from Druma who fought with a magic composite longbow (that was particularly effective against undead).

Arven Vendrivinn: A male human Varisian cleric from Daggermark who worshiped Hanspur and was armed with a magic trident (that returned to his hand after he threw it).

Nolfi of Trollheim: A female human Ulfen bard from the Land of the Linnorm Kings who carried a magic warhorn (capable of blasting targets with damaging sound).

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to "cut off the head of the beast" by confronting a rising chieftain. A critical success at this check reveals the chieftain to be someone named Armag. No further news comes forth.

If the PCs consult with Lady Jamandi about the Iron Wraiths, she can confirm that the adventuring party seems to have gone missing, but she notes that Glenebon is a dangerous place; she hopes the PCs have better luck in their pursuits.

In truth, at about the time the PCs were dealing with the Cult of the Bloom, the Iron Wraiths got in over their heads when they confronted Armag. The Tiger Lords captured the four adventurers and held them prisoner for a time. When it came time for Armag to explore the tomb with his honor guard, he used the Iron Wraiths as advance scouts, stripping them of their armor and gear and then marching them into the tomb. All four died as victims to the tomb's traps and guardians, sacrifices that allowed Armag to more safely reach his goal. Their bodies can be found as the PCs explore the tomb, while their recognizable suits of armor now serve those camped outside the tomb as decor.

THE TIGER LORD CAMP SEVERE 12

Armag's favorite companions and bodyguards have settled in a small box canyon that shelters the entrance to the tomb. The camp itself is located at the edge of a small forest, against the side of a 50-foot cliff in the hills. The encampment consists of only the leaders of Armag's army, including several of his best kinsmen and clan champions, along with the Sisters of the Bloodshot Eye who helped put him on the path toward this location. The rest of his loyal followers camp to the east and north in small groups, waiting until Armag gives the call to join and rise as one. Armag took several of his kin with him into the tomb days before the PCs finally reach this site, and the remaining warriors left behind wait here in this camp for his return while keeping watch over their five hostages (including Kisandra Numesti's sister, Tamary). The campsite consists of 11 circular tents, a fenced-in area for horses, and a wooden cage with a roof made of leather. But perhaps the most striking features in the camp are the four suits of plate armor that have been set up along the fenced-in area to serve as trophies; these formerly belonged to the Iron Wraiths.

Creatures: In all, there are a dozen Tiger Lords waiting at the campsite. At any one time, four of them are sleeping, four are relaxing in various tents, and four are on guard duty, hidden in nearby trees or standing sentry at the campsite's edge. A Tiger Lord who notices any sort of intruder raises an alarm by giving a powerful roar, bringing all of the others into the conflict. The Tiger Lords are not interested in talking and quickly attack any intruders in their territory, fighting to the death to defend it.

TIGER LORDS (12) CREATURE 8

UNCOMMON CN MEDIUM HUMANOID HUMAN

Human barbarians

Perception +18

Languages Common, Hallit

Skills Acrobatics +16, Athletics +18, Intimidation +16

Str +4, **Dex** +2, **Con** +2, **Int** +0, **Wis** +4, **Cha** +2

Items *+1 striking battle axe*, hatchets (6), heavy wooden shield, hide armor

AC 26; **Fort** +16, **Ref** +14, **Will** +18

HP 160

No Escape ↷ **Trigger** A foe within reach attempts to move away from the Tiger Lord; **Effect** The Tiger Lord Strides up to its Speed, following the foe and keeping it in reach throughout its movement until it stops moving or the Tiger Lord has moved its full Speed.

Speed 30 feet

Melee ❖ *battle axe* +21 (sweep); **Damage** 2d8+8 slashing

Ranged ❖ hatchet +21 (agile, sweep); **Damage** 1d6+8 slashing

Ranged ❖ hatchet +21 (thrown 10 feet); **Damage** 1d6+8 slashing

Closing Volley ❖❖❖ The Tiger Lord makes a ranged Strike with a hatchet, then Strides up to twice its speed. If it ends its movement within melee reach of the target of its ranged Strike, it may make a melee Strike against that enemy. If the ranged Strike hit the target, the target is flat-footed against the melee Strike.

Vengeful Rage ↷ **Requirements** The Tiger Lord is not fatigued or already in a rage; **Trigger** The Tiger Lord suffers damage that reduces its Hit Points to 100 or less. **Effect** The Tiger Lord flies into a rage that lasts 1 minute. While raging, the Tiger Lord gains a +1 status bonus to attack rolls, gains a +2 status bonus to damage rolls, and takes a –2 status penalty to AC. After the rage, the Tiger Lord is fatigued.

Hostages: The large cage at the center of the campsite contains the five hostages that Armag took from Baron Drelev. While these men and women (Anjan, Galine, Marinda, and Staven, along with Tamary Numesti, Kisandra's sister) are all terrified, they've been treated relatively well—not because the Tiger Lords are particularly interested in honoring the wartime tradition of taking hostages, but because they see these soft, squealing "city folk" as relatively pitiful creatures who are already adept at terrorizing themselves into compliance without extra work needed. All five hostages are ordinary aristocrats unused to the rigors of combat or adventure, and thus relatively useless in a fight; they'll need to be escorted to safety.

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FRIGHTENED HOSTAGES (5) CREATURE 3

Nobles (*Pathfinder Gamemastery Guide* 206)
Initiative Perception +11

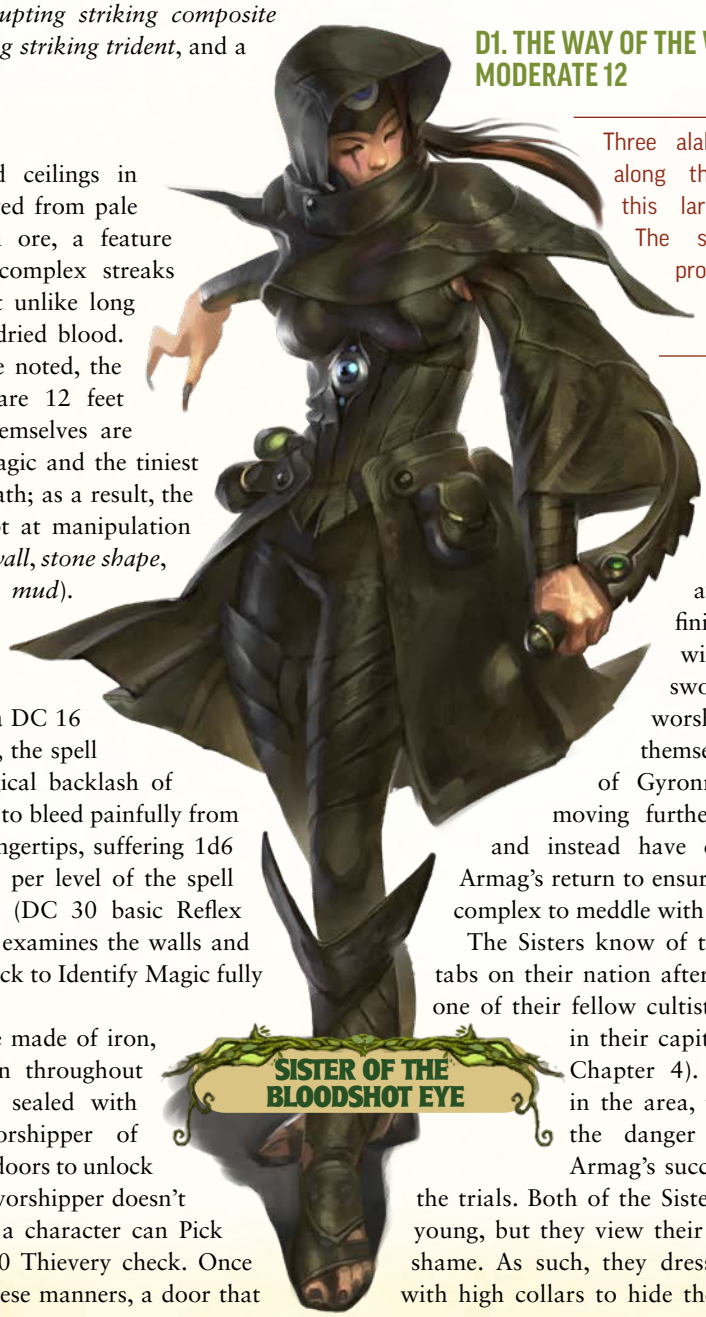
Treasure: The four suits of armor strung up along the corral's fence once belonged to the Iron Wraiths; the PCs should automatically recognize these distinctive suits of plate mail, having met the Iron Wraiths at the start of this campaign. All four suits are battered, filthy, and spattered with blood, but are otherwise fully functional suits of *+1 full plate*. In addition, each suit of armor is also adorned with one of the Iron Wraith's distinctive pieces of magical gear—a *+2 shock striking warhammer*, a *+1 disrupting striking composite shortbow*, a *+1 returning striking trident*, and a *horn of blasting*.

TOMB FEATURES

The walls, floors, and ceilings in Armag's Tomb are carved from pale stone heavy with iron ore, a feature that gives the entire complex streaks of oxidized brown, not unlike long dead flesh streaked in dried blood. Except where otherwise noted, the rooms and corridors are 12 feet high, and the walls themselves are infused with ancient magic and the tiniest fraction of Gorum's wrath; as a result, the walls resist any attempt at manipulation via magic (such as *passwall*, *stone shape*, or *transmute rock to mud*). In order to affect the stone of the tomb with such a spell, the caster must succeed at a DC 16 flat check—on a failure, the spell is wasted and the magical backlash of energy causes the caster to bleed painfully from the eyes, mouth, and fingertips, suffering 1d6 points of force damage per level of the spell they attempted to cast (DC 30 basic Reflex save). A character who examines the walls and succeeds at a DC 30 check to Identify Magic fully understands this ward.

The tomb's doors are made of iron, and the divine infusion throughout the tomb keeps them sealed with magical locks. A worshipper of Gorum can cause these doors to unlock at a touch (even if the worshipper doesn't realize this); otherwise a character can Pick the Lock with a DC 30 Thievery check. Once unlocked in either of these manners, a door that remains unbroken automatically closes and locks after 10 minutes. Several rooms include tests and tricks that can cause the doors to open as well; these represent opportunities for creatures who don't worship Gorum to prove their worthiness.

Several chambers within Armag's Tomb present dangerous tests that give intruders a chance to display qualities valued by the faithful of Gorum. Some of these dangerous tests are presented as traps that trigger only if the PCs fail to complete the test in a specified amount of time. Characters can bypass any of these tests completely if they have other methods of opening the doors.



D1. THE WAY OF THE WARRIORS THREE MODERATE 12

Three alabaster statues stand along the western wall of this large square chamber. The statues depict well-proportioned Kellid men, each set in a different warlike pose.

Creatures: Armag's hateful advisors, the Sisters of the Bloodshot Eye, have come to this chamber to await him while he finishes his communion with Gorum and the sword *Ovinrbaane*. Not worshippers of Gorum themselves, the two clerics of Gyronna are wary about moving further into the complex and instead have chosen to wait for Armag's return to ensure that none enter the complex to meddle with Armag's awakening.

The Sisters know of the PCs, having kept tabs on their nation after a failed attempt by one of their fellow cultists to establish a cult in their capital city (page 196 of Chapter 4). More than anyone in the area, the Sisters recognize the danger the PCs pose to Armag's successful completion of the trials. Both of the Sisters are actually quite young, but they view their youth as a mark of shame. As such, they dress in hooded clothes with high collars to hide their faces. They hope

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ARMAG'S TOMB
ONE SQUARE = 5 FEET

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that as a reward for helping to achieve vengeance against Brevoy by leading a horde of warriors north, Gyronna will care for them in their old age to come. Each has abandoned her personal life and even her name in pursuit of this singular goal.

If the Sisters notice the PCs approaching (likely as a result of a particularly noisy fight in the Tiger Lord camp), they cast *freedom of movement* and *resist energy* on themselves, then each takes up a defensive position before one of the two double doors. They cast *globe of invulnerability* as soon before combat starts as they can manage, but on their first actions they cast *repulsion*. Following this, they'll cast *globe of invulnerability* (if they haven't already) followed by *summon fiend* to each summon an invidiak (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 65) to attack the PCs in melee before moving on to fight with their ranged spells. Their primary goal is to prevent the PCs from moving deeper into the tomb, and while they'll pursue intruders throughout the complex, they won't chase them back outside. Otherwise, they fight to the death.

SISTERS OF THE BLOODSHOT EYE (2) CREATURE 12

UNIQUE | CE | MEDIUM | HUMANOID | HUMAN

Female human cleric of Gyronna

Perception +23

Languages Abyssal, Common, Hallit

Skills Deception +22, Intimidate +22, Religion +25, Society +20, Survival +23

Str +2, **Dex** +2, **Con** +4, **Int** +1, **Wis** +5, **Cha** +2

Items *+1 wounding striking dagger*, *+1 breastplate*, religious symbol of Gyronna

AC 31; **Fort** +22, **Ref** +20, **Will** +25

HP 250

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ *dagger* +24 (agile, finesse, versatile S), **Damage** 2d4+6 piercing plus 1d6 bleed

Divine Spells Prepared DC 36, attack +26; **6th** *blade barrier*, *harm* (×3), *repulsion*, *summon fiend*; **5th** *dispel magic*, *heal*, *shadow blast*; **4th** *divine wrath*, *freedom of movement*, *globe of invulnerability*; **3rd** *blindness*, *chilling darkness*, *vampiric touch*; **2nd** *ghoulish cravings*, *resist energy*, *silence*; **1st** *bane*, *command*, *ray of enfeeblement*; **Cantrips (6th)** *daze*, *detect magic*, *divine lance*, *message*, *shield*

Divine Font *harm*

Infectious Wrath ❖ (aura, divine, emotion, enchantment, mental) **Frequency** once per day; **Effect** The Sister projects her wrath and rage into the minds of any number of creatures of her choice within 30 feet. Targeted creatures must attempt a DC 32 Will save.

Critical Success The creature is unaffected.

Success The creature is flat-footed for 1 round as they become distracted by the unexpected fit of rage.

Failure The creature is confused for 1 round.

Critical Failure The creature is confused for as long as they remain within 30 feet of the Sister, or until they succeed at the DC 11 flat check to recover.

D2. TEST OF STRENGTH

Four boulders of varying size lie within this chamber. At the far end, progressively larger steps rise toward a set of iron doors. Each step bears a round depression corresponding in size to one of the boulders. The crushed body of a dead half-orc dressed in rags lies on the floor near the north.

The dead half-orc is one of the Iron Wraiths—Kralanx the ranger.

Hazard: This chamber presents a Test of Strength to challenge those who seek to enter the Tomb of Armag. Properly weighting each step with the appropriately sized boulder opens the iron doors at the south end of the hall. Rolling the boulders into place requires progressively harder Athletics checks due to their size and the height at which they need to be placed. From smallest to largest, the Athletics DCs to move each boulder are DC 28, DC 30, DC 32, and DC 35. One additional character may use the Aid action, attempting the same check. It takes 1 minute to attempt to move a boulder into place. The PCs can retry failed checks, but if they don't move quickly enough, the room's trap soon activates.

TEST OF STRENGTH HAZARD 13

MECHANICAL | TRAP

Stealth DC 37 (expert)

Description The steps angle downward into a slope, releasing all currently placed boulders to roll back down to the north.

Disable Thievery DC 37 (expert) to disable the hidden hinges for one of the steps, thereby locking all four steps into place

Open Doors ↷ **Trigger** All four boulders are placed within six minutes; **Effect** the doors to area **D3** open.

Release Boulders ↷ **Trigger** All four boulders are not placed within six minutes; **Effect** All four steps angle downward, causing any boulders held within to roll toward area **D1**. Each rolling boulder inflicts 3d6+6 bludgeoning damage on all creatures in area **D2** (DC 37 basic Reflex save).

Reset The trap Releases Boulders 24 hours after it Opens Doors. Once the trap Releases Boulders, it resets itself automatically.

D3. TEST OF ENDURANCE

Columns of fused iron weapons emerge from a sheet of iron on the chamber floor. An iron wheel protrudes from

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the floor in the middle of the room. A human corpse, a man dressed in rags, lies slumped on the ground near the wheel.

A DC 25 Medicine check made while examining the body suggests the man perished from a blast of deadly, magical cold. This body is that of Quain Kortun, once the leader of the Iron Wraiths.

Hazard: If the iron wheel in the middle of the room is rotated for seven complete revolutions, the locks on the doors in this room are deactivated for 12 minutes. One character can attempt to rotate the wheel by taking the Rotate the Wheel action (others may Aid this action). If the wheel is released before seven revolutions are complete, it unwinds, resetting its revolutions to 0, and the Test of Endurance's trap is triggered.

ROTATE THE WHEEL ◆▶▶▶

MANIPULATE

The character takes time to rotate the wheel. Doing so is exhausting, and at the end of a round the PC must attempt a DC 25 Fortitude save. The DC of this save increases as the attempts to Rotate the Wheel progress. Achieving a full 7 revolutions causes both double doors in this room to open (they close automatically in 24 hours).

Critical Success The wheel rotates 2 revolutions. The DC to Rotate the Wheel increases by 1.

Success The wheel rotates 1 revolution. The DC to Rotate the Wheel increases by 1.

Failure The character fails to complete a revolution. The DC to Rotate the Wheel increases by 2.

Critical Failure The character stumbles and loses their grip on the wheel, triggering the Test of Endurance hazard. The wheel unwinds, resetting its revolutions to 0 and its DC to 25.

TEST OF ENDURANCE HAZARD 13

COLD EVOCATION MAGICAL TRAP

Stealth DC 40 (master)

Description The room fills with swirling vortexes of freezing wind that swiftly freeze flesh and chill the bones.

Disable Thievery DC 33 (master) to adjust the wheel's mechanisms so that it won't trigger the Test of Endurance, or *dispel magic* (7th level, counteract DC 31) to counteract the trap's magic.

Freezing Wind ↷ (cold, evocation) **Trigger** A creature critically fails at an attempt to Rotate the Wheel or releases their grip on the wheel once they've started to rotate it; **Effect** A vortex of freezing wind howls through the room—all creatures in the room must attempt a DC 33 Fortitude save.

Critical Success The creature takes no damage.

Success The creature takes 1d6 cold damage for each revolution the wheel has been rotated (max 7d6).

Failure The creature takes 2d6 cold damage for each revolution the wheel has been rotated (max 14d6) and becomes fatigued.

Critical Failure The creature takes 3d6 cold damage for each revolution the wheel has been rotated (max 21d6), becomes drained 1, and becomes fatigued.

Reset The trap resets automatically.

D4. THE TACTICIAN'S WAY

An alabaster statue of a human warrior stands in this antechamber against the north wall. Two five-foot passageways open to either side.

This alabaster statue's unwavering gaze stares at a secret door on the south wall (requiring success on a DC 30 Perception check to locate the door).

D5. TEST OF TACTICS MODERATE 12

Large sigils the size of shields, each glowing softly with a pale blue light, adorn the walls of this long hallway. Judging by the dust and abandoned cobwebs, the passageway itself appears to have lain unused for centuries.

Hazard: The sixteen magical sigils glowing on these walls each represent a personal rune for the sixteen great champions who once fought in Armag's armies so many years ago and are now skeletal undead in the Cavern of the Slain and beyond (areas **D10–D12**). Anyone who speaks Hallit can understand these sigils are highly stylized representations of given names for different men and women, although none of the names seem particularly noteworthy from a historical vantage. A character who succeeds at a DC 32 check to Identify Magic on the runes reveals that they are imbued with necromantic energies meant to bind the souls of those named to their mortal remains for all eternity, yet there are other runes hidden within these sigils that comprise the Test of Tactics.

If this trap is disabled, the links between the skeletal Tiger Lords and their sigils here is severed, and the undead in areas **D10–D12** lose their rejuvenation ability.

TEST OF TACTICS HAZARD 13

MECHANICAL TRAP

Stealth DC 37 (expert)

Description Obscure magical runes hidden within the runes of the 16 named warriors bind a pair of derghodaemons into the walls of this hallway.

Disable Thievery DC 37 (expert) to remove a set of runes linked to one bound derghodaemon, or *dispel magic* (7th level, counteract DC 31) to counteract the trap's magic.

Conjure Daemon ↷ **Trigger** A creature moves past the bend

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in the middle of the hall; **Effect** A pair of derghodaemons rise up from the floor to the north and southeast near the stairs; the daemons roll for initiative using Stealth, and fight to the death but do not pursue foes out of this area.

Reset If at least one of the derghodaemons survives, the trap resets after 1 hour, causing the surviving derghodaemons to be completely restored to full health and to merge with the floors.

DERGHODAEMONS (2) CREATURE 12

Pathfinder Bestiary 2 60

Initiative Stealth +24

D6. TEST OF AGILITY LOW 12

The ceiling of this circular room rises from the floor in a hemisphere, reaching a height of ten feet. The floor is highly polished and smooth.

Hazard: Despite its appearance, this chamber is actually spherical—the "floor" is the top of a circular disc balanced on a pivot rising to the center of the room from below. When any creature steps into the room, the floor underfoot shifts downward under the creature's weight while rising up at the far side of the room. By moving around the room, one can control the angle of the floor's tilt. Standing exactly in the center allows the floor to return to level, as would placing two objects of equal weight on opposite sides of the room, in theory. Unfortunately, the pivot on which the disk balances is itself unstable, causing the floor to wobble and shake even when the characters take care to keep things as balanced as possible.

Navigating the room by foot is difficult. The smooth walls and floor offer no handholds for climbing, and as such it's a DC 40 Athletics check to Climb them. Flight offers a safer route through the room, as does jumping across the room, but any character who puts weight on the floor triggers this hazard.

TEST OF AGILITY HAZARD 13

COMPLEX | MECHANICAL | TRAP

Stealth DC 37 (expert)

Description The floor of this circular room pivots and shifts awkwardly when weight is placed upon its surface, pitching those who attempt to walk on it off their feet and potentially into one of two deep spiked pits.

Disable Thievery DC 37 (expert) to wedge scraps of material into the edges of the room to hamper the floor's tilt (requires 4 successes).

Tilt and Roll ↷ Trigger A creature or object of at least 3 bulk moves onto the floor; the trap can use this reaction multiple times in a round, but only once per triggering creature or object; **Effect** The floor pitches and rolls. The triggering creature must attempt a DC 33 Reflex save.

Critical Success The character can move across the room normally this turn, without having to attempt Acrobatics checks, but treats the unstable floor as difficult terrain.

Success The character treats the ground in this room as difficult terrain, but each time they move they must succeed at a DC 30 Acrobatics check or they fall prone at the start of their turn. A character who falls prone must succeed at a DC 33 Reflex save or fall into one of the two spiked pits to the north or south of the room (see Failure).

Failure As success but the character automatically falls prone and must succeed at a DC 33 Reflex save to avoid being pitched into one of the two spiked pits to the north or south of the room. A character who is pitched into a pit can attempt to Grab an Edge to avoid falling. The DC to Grab an Edge or Climb a pit's walls is 33.

A character who falls into one of the pits plunges 50 feet onto a bed of spikes, taking 25 points of bludgeoning damage and 2d6 piercing damage (DC 33 basic Reflex save).

Critical Failure As failure, but the character automatically rolls into one of the two pits.

Routine (1 action) On its initiative each turn, the floor tilts randomly, forcing all characters standing on the floor of the room to attempt a DC 33 Reflex save to avoid being pitched into one of the two pits.

Reset This trap resets instantly.

Treasure: Lying among a number of ancient bones in the north pit is a *+1 flaming longsword*, while the south pit contains a scroll case within which is a *scroll of blade barrier*, a *scroll of remove curse*, and a *scroll of drop dead*.

D7. ANT NESTS MODERATE 12

The hall ends at a precipice overlooking a natural stone cavern, the earthen floor of which lies thirty feet below. The ceiling arches another thirty feet overhead. Throughout the chamber, pillars of rounded rock rise at varying levels like uneven stepping-stones leading to another tunnel opening on the far side. The body of a dead woman dressed in rags, her remains covered in welts, lies sprawled on the earthen floor below.

Those who cannot fly or easily climb the walls of this chamber (DC 30 Athletics check to Climb the relatively smooth walls) can navigate the chamber by using the Leap basic action. Characters also can perform a long jump to Leap over several pillars at once, but when doing so they take a –5 penalty on the Acrobatics check

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to Balance when they land on the pillar. A creature that falls into the room takes 15 bludgeoning damage from the fall.

The body is that of Nolfi of Trollheim, the Iron Wraiths' bard. A successful DC 20 Medicine or Nature check suggests her cause of death was from the hundreds of stinger wounds on her remains. A critical success at either check reveals that her death was from a brutal swarm of army ants.

Creatures: Anyone who walks across the ground or otherwise disturbs the earth at the bottom of the pit (such as by falling onto it) awakens this chamber's nightmarish guardians: swarms of bright red army ants, each the size of a person's finger. There are two swarms present in the soil here; once roused, they'll climb up pillars or walls to attack foes, pursuing creatures as far as area **D6** or **D9**.

VICIOUS ARMY ANT SWARMS (2) CREATURE 12

RARE | N | LARGE | ANIMAL | SWARM

Variant army ant swarm (*Pathfinder Bestiary 2* 20)

Perception +23, darkvision, scent (imprecise) 30 feet

Skills Athletics +16

Str –2, **Dex** +7, **Con** +5, **Int** –5, **Wis** +5, **Cha** –4

AC 32; **Fort** +25, **Ref** +23, **Will** +19

HP 155; **Immunities** precision, swarm mind; **Weaknesses** area damage 15, splash damage 15; **Resistances** bludgeoning 8, piercing 15, slashing 15

Cling As army ant swarm, but 7d6 damage.

Speed 30 feet, climb 30 feet

Swarming Bites ❖ As army ant swarm, but 7d6 damage (DC 31 basic Fortitude save).

D8. SIDE CHAMBERS

Treasure: Each of these six chambers previously served as living space for those who helped construct the tomb. Now they contain a variety of historical relics and curious minor art objects from Armag's age. Each chamber contains 2d20 gp worth of valuable but forgotten treasures.

D9. TEST OF PROWESS MODERATE 12

Four massive pillars hold up this large, dome-shaped chamber's ceiling, which rises to a height of fifty feet. A man's corpse, his limbs and back broken, lies at the feet of a tall, spiky suit of plate armor standing in the middle of the room.

The body belonged to Arven Vendrivinn, the Iron Wraiths' cleric. He was slain by the creature that now stands over his remains.

Creatures: What appears to be a towering spiky statue of a suit of plate armor standing at the center of the room is actually an iron golem crafted to resemble Gorum himself; the imagery can be recognized with a DC 10 Religion check to Recall Knowledge. The golem animates as soon as anyone enters this chamber, and it fights until destroyed, pursuing foes throughout the tomb if necessary.

ELITE IRON GOLEM CREATURE 14

Pathfinder Bestiary 6, 188

Initiative Perception +23

D10. CAVERN OF THE SLAIN MODERATE 12

The corridor emerges into a huge natural cavern supported by a single, immense pillar of stone. To the west rises a twenty-foot-high ridge capped by a small forest of stalagmites. The ceiling rises to a height of forty feet above.

The Tiger Lords refer to this chamber as the Cavern of the Slain. Legend says it



SKELETAL TIGER LORD

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contains an army of undead forever bound to Armag's will—this rumor is true. The ridge to the west can be Climbed with a DC 20 Athletics check.

Creatures: A small army of deadly undead skeletons stands at eternal attention in the western part of this room, hiding among the spires of sharp stalagmites and watching for intruders into the Cavern of the Slain. Each of these blood-soaked skeletal warriors were, in life, devoted to the first Armag, and in undeath their loyalty remains. The wielder of *Ovinrbaane* can continue to command the obedience of these undead—Armag has thus called eight of the skeletons from this room to areas **D11** and **D12**, leaving eight here to protect the cavern.

The remaining eight skeletal Tiger Lords are stationed within the stalagmites on the western ridge, looking out over the lower portion of the cavern to the east. The skeletons will initially attack intruders using longbows; when they run out of arrows, they'll clamber down the ridge to engage in melee. They won't pursue characters into area **D9**, but they will pursue them into area **D11**.

SKELETAL TIGER LORDS (8) CREATURE 8

RARE CE MEDIUM SKELETON UNDEAD

Variant skeleton (*Pathfinder Bestiary* 298)

Perception +18

Languages Hallit

Skills Athletics +18

Str +6, **Dex** +4, **Con** +4, **Int** +0, **Wis** +4, **Cha** +0

Items breastplate, composite longbow (20 arrows), greatsword

AC 28; **Fort** +18, **Ref** +16, **Will** +16

HP 99, negative healing, fast healing 10; **Immunities** death effects, disease, mental, paralyzed, poison, unconscious; **Resistances** cold 10, electricity 10, fire 10, piercing 10, slashing 10

Rejuvenation (divine, necromancy) When a skeletal Tiger Lord is destroyed, its bones clatter to the ground in a tangle and its armor and weapons crumble to dust. It automatically reforms with its armor and weapons intact (regaining a full quiver of 20 arrows) 1 hour later at 1 Hit Point, allowing its fast healing to resume healing it thereafter. If the trap in area **D5** is disabled, the skeleton loses this ability; otherwise, the only way to permanently destroy a skeletal Tiger Lord is to reduce it to 0 Hit Points with positive damage or good damage.

Attack of Opportunity ↷

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ greatsword +20 (versatile P); **Damage** 1d12+10 slashing plus 2d6 negative

Ranged ❖ composite longbow +18 (deadly d10, range increment 100 feet, reload 0, volley 30 feet); **Damage** 1d8+10 piercing

D11. TEMPLE OF GORUM MODERATE 12

Two churning fountains take up alcoves to the east and west of this immense chamber, their water cascading down the faces of beautifully rendered women as if they were crying for the souls lost in battle. Directly ahead, four rows of intricately carved columns reach deeper into the chamber, resembling armed soldiers kneeling in honor of the massive statue of a suit of spiky armor at the chamber's far end. Stairs descend into a passageway between two braziers to the north.

Creatures: Ageless Zorek, sacred guardian of the Tomb of Armag, resides in this temple, administering the Test of Faith to all who reach his inner sanctum. A confrontation with Zorek need not result in battle, for Zorek is loyal first to Gorum. As the tomb's guardian, he can sense the PCs' successes as they confront the various tests, and when they first step into this room, he greets them with open arms, saying the following in Hallit.

"And so another group steps before me, bathed in blood and armed with weapons. Tell me your purpose within this sacred place!"

Assuming the PCs understand and can speak Hallit, they can take this opportunity to explain themselves, using Deception, Diplomacy, or Intimidation. Zorek responds best to Intimidation: impressing him in this way requires only a DC 30 check. He's less patient with friendly overtures (DC 32 Diplomacy) and actively dislikes liars (DC 35 Deception). One PC attempts this check, but all others can Aid that PC by attempting the same check. In addition, for each of the tests the PCs encountered and survived, reduce the DC of the check by 2. On a success, Zorek steps aside and orders his skeletal guardians to stand down, informing the PCs that they are free to enter Armag's Armory to the north to challenge Armag himself. On a critical success, if the PCs have with them one or both of the tiger lord rings (the *ring of the tiger* from encounter site **NM1** or the *ring of acid resistance* from area **C48** of Fort Drelev), Zorek thanks them for spreading the war glories of Gorum through the world before infusing either or both rings present. This gift from the guardian changes the rings into the greater versions of each—a permanent upgrade to the magic items.

If the PCs fail to succeed on the check, or if they simply cannot communicate with him, Zorek simply shakes his head sadly before he attacks—one sure way to determine the intruders' value in Gorum's eyes. He sends four skeletal Tiger Lords to engage the PCs in melee while he moves to the top of the stairs leading to area **D12** before casting *repulsion*. He then uses his ranged spells to soften up the PCs for 4 rounds before

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moving to engage them in melee. He uses one-action *heal* spells on himself whenever he is below 150 HP, but he fights to the death. Although Zorek is not aware of this fact, if he is slain by mortals, he's granted the true freedom of death as certainly as if his charge to guard the tomb had been completed.

ZOREK CREATURE 12

UNIQUE CN MEDIUM HUMANOID HUMAN

Ageless male human cleric of Gorum

Perception +25

Languages Hallit

Skills Athletics +24, Gorum Lore +20, Religion +25, Survival +23

Str +7, **Dex** +4, **Con** +5, **Int** +0, **Wis** +7, **Cha** +4

Items *+1 resilient hide armor*, *+2 anarchic striking spear*

AC 32; **Fort** +23, **Ref** +20, **Will** +25

HP 220, fast healing 10; **Immune** controlled, disease; **Resistances** physical 10 (except lawful), poison 15; **Weaknesses** lawful 10

Attack of Opportunity ↷

Speed 40 feet

Melee ❖ *spear* +32, **Damage** 2d6+8 piercing plus 1d6 chaotic (against lawful creatures)

Divine Spells Prepared DC 36, attack +26; **6th** *heal* (x3), *repulsion*, *spirit blast*, *weapon storm*; **5th** *dispel magic*, *flame strike*, *heal*; **4th** *divine wrath*, *harm*, *spiritual weapon*; **3rd** *blindness*, *searing light*, *vampiric touch*; **2nd** *heal*, *resist energy*, *silence*; **1st** *bane*, *fear*, *ray of enfeeblement*; **Cantrips (6th)** *detect magic*, *divine lance*, *guidance*, *light*, *shield*

Divine Innate Spells DC 36; 5th *banishment*; 3rd *alarm* (x3);2nd *augury* (x3), *lock* (x3); **Cantrips** (7th) *dimension door* (to any location in Armag's Tomb)

Blessed Life Zorek does not age or breathe, and he doesn't need to eat, drink, or sleep.

Divine Font *heal*

Divine Recovery ↷ **Frequency** once per day; **Trigger** Zorek fails a saving throw; **Effect** Zorek loses all negative conditions he is currently affected by and may attempt a new saving throw against the effect that triggered Divine Recovery. His armor and weapons glow with blood-red light when he uses this ability.



ZOREK

SKELETAL TIGER LORDS (4) CREATURE 8

See page 327

Initiative Perception +18

D12. ARMAG'S ARMORY SEVERE 12

Ten flickering braziers cast long shadows across this huge chamber, their wavering light gleaming from walls spattered with blood. The air reeks of decay, for the violently hacked bodies of a dozen men lie strewn about the chamber.

The dead bodies are all that remains of Armag's honor guard—once he claimed *Ovinrbaane*, the cursed weapon forced him to attack and slay his guards as proof of his devotion.

Creatures: Armag the Twice-Born has slaughtered his guards, but he is not alone; he is accompanied and protected by four skeletal warriors from area **D10**. Warned by Zorek of the PCs' approach, Armag eagerly awaits their arrival—another chance for him to prove his worth to his new weapon. He and his skeletal warriors attack as soon as the PCs arrive. Even before he succumbed to the bloodlust of *Ovinrbaane*, Armag never retreated or surrendered—he fights to the death.

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ARMAG THE TWICE-BORN CREATURE 14

See page 592

Initiative Perception +24

SKELETAL TIGER LORDS (4) CREATURE 8

See page 327

Initiative Perception +18

Treasure: If you aren't comfortable with giving the PCs a powerful weapon like *Ovinrbaane*, simply play up its disadvantages—if you wish, you might add that anyone in possession of the weapon must succeed on a DC 35 Will save once per minute to avoid becoming confused. You should certainly play up the artifact's personality if the PCs keep it. Its power will certainly come in handy as the *Kingmaker Adventure Path* enters the final chapters, but you should never let the PCs feel fully comfortable in the chaotic artifact's presence. See page 587 for *Ovinrbaane*'s statistics.

D13. ARMAG'S TOMB

To the west of this large, austere chamber, a massive raised dais supports a coffin of black stone; to the east, the walls are decorated with a bas-relief of a stern man dressed for war and wielding a greatsword.

This chamber serves as the final resting place for the original Armag's body, which lies within the sarcophagus. The wall carving is actually a secret door (DC 30 Perception to detect) that lifts upward to provide access to area **D14**.

Treasure: Armag's body measures just over 6-1/2 feet tall and is dressed in *+1 resilient hide armor*. A *greater sturdy shield* decorated with chasings of dire tigers lies over his chest.

D14. HOLY SEPULCHER

Within this roughly octagonal chamber, a five-foot-square alabaster pedestal sits inside a ring of brilliant light shining from the ceiling.

Treasure: Piled around the pedestal lies a treasure hoard of immense value. Altogether, it contains 112 pp, 2,276 gp, 4,724 sp, and 9,762 cp. The gems and jewelry include a 1,000 gp diamond, a 200 gp fire opal, three 100 gp violet garnets, an electrum crown with a blue star sapphire worth 500 gp, a ruby-encrusted silver armband worth 250 gp, and a malachite-adorned gold necklace worth 180 gp.

Also included among these items are a *bag of holding* (type IV), a *decanter of endless water*, a *triton's conch*, a *necklace of fireballs* (type V), a *javelin of lightning*, a dose of giant wasp venom, a *cloak of the bat*, and a *wand of heroism*.

CONCLUDING THE CHAPTER

"Blood for Blood" doesn't really have an endpoint as much as it has a point where the next chapter begins. Even after the PCs depose Baron Drelev and defeat Armag, they can continue exploring the surrounding regions and expanding their kingdom into this realm as long as they wish. Still, there are three elements to this chapter in particular that the PCs should seek to address.

The East Sellen River has been closed to trade for several years due to the aggression of the boggards of M'botuu. If the PCs manage to either defeat these boggards or secure their cooperation in allowing river trade, an important economic link between Brevoy and the south reopens. Once the PCs have claimed at least nine hexes that include a portion of the East Sellen River or Lake Hooktongue as part of their nation, their kingdom gains 120 XP, and at the start of the next Kingdom turn they receive 6 bonus Resource Dice.

Without Armag or the Sisters of the Bloodshot Eye stirring the pot, the Tiger Lords cease to be a true threat to their neighbors, but their raiding parties continue to be an annoyance. Handing *Ovinrbaane* over to the Tiger Lords as a peace offering is the best way to appease them—in this case, the sword still works at remaking a new warlord in Armag's image, but without the Sisters' influence, this new Armag focuses his anger not at the PCs or Pitax but north and east at Numeria and Brevoy. Alternately, the PCs could seek to secure diplomatic relations with the Tiger Lords (see Appendix 2 for details on how a kingdom can achieve diplomatic relations with the Tiger Lords).

Finally, if the PCs liberate Fort Drelev, they also push back Lord Irovetti's presence in the region. Not only can they add a sizable city to their nation by incorporating Fort Drelev, but the PCs' kingdom should also be well on course to becoming the largest and most successful nation in the Stolen Lands.

As the PCs' successes grow, however, Irovetti of Pitax grows ever more jealous and wary. While there's no hard evidence to suggest he encouraged Baron Drelev to attack the PCs, the political situation should certainly suggest it. And while Irovetti would certainly love to annex the PCs' nation, he knows that they've grown far too powerful to defeat in a fair war. And so, as the PCs settle into their newly expanded nation, Lord Irovetti sets in motion a fresh treachery as he makes his move to claim the Stolen Lands. For what at first may seem like an idle invitation to a local tournament is destined to erupt into a war of the River Kings.

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CHAPTER 8

WAR OF THE RIVER KINGS

BY JASON NELSON

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PART 1:

THE RUSHLIGHT TREACHERY

The River Kingdoms are fluid by nature, mirroring the flow of the waterways from which their name is taken. Rulers rise and fall like the changing of seasons in this tumultuous region, but some of the kingdoms found here have endured and prospered for generations, cementing their place in the pecking order of this confederacy of outlaws. Every new upstart dreams not just of conquest but of legacy, and the wise know full well that the greatest threat to security and legacy typically comes not from established kingdoms but from upstarts fighting for the last seat at the table.

Pitax is a River Kingdom of some pedigree, able to trace its history back over three centuries. During those centuries, it has been overrun on more than one occasion, first by the Steel Phalanx of Numeria, then a generation later by invaders from Mivon, and it was even split for half a century by civil war between its leading families. Yet through this all, Pitax has remained a hub for trade and a haven for smugglers. But now it faces its most dangerous enemy yet, an enemy from within—its own king, Castruccio Irovetti, who may be able to do through corruption and pride what three centuries of war and upheaval could not: bring Pitax to an end.

The man known today as Castruccio Irovetti was not born unto that name. The bastard son of a crusading Taldan knight and a Numerian noblewoman, Castruccio's birth name was the even more flamboyant Mandalarucio. His father sent regular deliveries of gold from the field of battle, so he and his mother Cimany

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never wanted for wealth. Mandalarucio's mother doted on him, paying for dance, music, and language lessons and parading him among the other nobles of Hajoth Hakados as often as possible. Mother and son knew little of hardship until the payments from Mandalarucio's father—a man the future king never met—ceased with the elder's death at the hands of the Worldwound's demonic host. Cimany did her best to make ends meet, but she and her child had both grown used to extravagances, and within two months their funds had given out. The cutthroat aristocracy of Hajoth Hakados swiftly took action to reclaim the family estate, and just like that the two were out on the street.

After suffering another two months of indignities, Mandalarucio turned to crime, using occult magic to gain the confidence of rich visitors and then robbing them, leaving behind victims too shamed at being duped to pursue justice. Eventually, though, Mandalarucio made a critical error by attempting to con and rob a member of the Technic League. When the con went sour and the Technic League sorcerer lost his hand to Mandalarucio's blade, the budding con artist went into hiding to escape punishment. But the Technic League didn't need *him* to repay the blood debt—operating under the aegis of the Black Sovereign and the slanderous whispers of local aristocrats, they quickly found that the missing man had a mother. They arrested Cimany, and by the time Mandalarucio heard of her arrest, she'd already been executed.

When he learned of this development, Mandalarucio wasted no time. He stole into the inn the Technic League agents were staying at and extracted his revenge in a single night of red ruin. When the sun rose, the five Technic League agents were dead and the delivery of rare Numerian artifacts they had been entrusted with delivering to Starfall had vanished. Hajoth Hakados's government had its suspicions, but the case was never solved, for Mandalarucio had fled Numeria entirely, never to return.

The next two years of his life were spent lying low in the River Kingdoms. He changed his name to Castruccio Irovetti, combining the first and last names of his mother's favorite artists. He periodically sold off some of the Numerian artifacts he'd stolen for funds, but overall, he kept a low profile. It wasn't until his wanderings took him to Pitax that his fortunes finally changed. After hearing rumors of strange treasures hidden in the forest called Thousand Voices, Irovetti entered the mysterious woodland in search of riches. It may have been his good looks and strong singing voice that attracted the attention of the cruel queen of Thousand Voices, but more likely it was the intrusive stink of the technological items he carried that caused the nymph Nyrissa to take special note of this latest intruder. She sent her minions against Irovetti to test him, but he defeated them all with a combination of his magic, his wits, and his Numerian devices.

Intrigued, Nyrissa realized that here was a perfect tool to use to increase her influence over the encroaching tide of civilization. She appeared before Irovetti, who in the face of such power had little choice but to fall to his knees in adoration. Nyrissa took Irovetti away for a month to her strange and wondrous realm in the First World. There she showed him great marvels and fearsome sights, and on the eve she returned him to Pitax, she granted him her favor and became his muse, giving him a lock of her hair. In return, she asked only that he perform one favor for her in the world of mortals—recovering a sword called *Briar*, lost long ago somewhere in the region. (For more information on how Nyrissa lost *Briar*, what the sword actually means to her, and why she can't simply retrieve it on her own, see Chapter 10.)

With Nyrissa's favor granting Irovetti even greater skill, he made his way to the city of Pitax. He reasoned that with a kingdom at his command, the search for a missing sword would be a trivial thing. Armed with his two remaining Numerian devices and an idea of how to become Pitax's newest ruler, Irovetti wasted no time setting his plot into motion. One of his Numerian devices is a mindrender baton—a technological wonder capable of commanding false loyalty in a victim's mind. Irovetti began building his reputation in the city by using the mindrender baton to aid in purchasing several warehouses for scandalously low prices and securing relationships and deals with several important merchants and smugglers. Eventually, he invited two of Pitax's leaders, the brothers Lothaire and Berengar, to a card game at one of his warehouses. Through the use of his mindrender baton and magic (particularly *modify memory*), Irovetti swindled the brothers out of their rule; the next morning, neither had any memories of being duped, but Irovetti owned a signed document legally handing over all the possessions of the ruling family to him, including the crown of Pitax.

KINGDOM IN THE BACKGROUND

By this point, the PC's kingdom is the largest in the Stolen Lands. Fort Drelev has been incorporated into the kingdom, and its borders are creeping toward Pitax to the west. For the most part, you should present the battles that take place during this chapter (largely in Part 2) as events that occur in the background, and tie the overall success or failure of the war to the PCs' own success in opposing King Irovetti.

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Greetings from His Supreme and Inimitable Magnificence, Castruccio Irovetti, by the grace of the gods the rightful King of Pitax, Marvel of Numeria, Master of Mormouth, and Prince-Regent of the Sellen.

It is with great delectation and delight that I greet you, my fellow River Kings! I would be honored if you would accept my invitation to attend the fifth annual Rushlight Tournament as my guests. I know you to be discerning rulers and trust you would not dare miss such an extravagance, for I plan this to be the finest Rushlight yet! And to sweeten the pot, as it were, I have secured a glorious magical item, a gold-and-gemstone wand capable of creating a wondrous and magnificent mansion worthy of the bearer's regal nature, which I am willing to bestow upon the nation that proves itself by fielding the true Rushlight Champion! Could this champion be one of your own?

Please confirm your attendance via this invitation's courier. I look forward to your attendance!

-King Castruccio Irovetti of Pitax

HANDOUT 8-1

At first, Irovetti used his new resources as king of Pitax to search for *Briar*. But as the years wore on, his memories of his time with Nyrissa began to pale against the reality of the decadence and power that ruling a River Kingdom brought. While her influence continued to subtly manipulate Irovetti's personality (and is in large part responsible for his founding of Pitax's Academy of Grand Arts), her hold over his heart and lusts faded. So when several of Irovetti's agents came to him years later with the good news that *Briar* had been found, Irovetti did something his fey patron hadn't foreseen: he had his agents murdered before they could spread the news, then hid *Briar* away in a chamber deep under his palace. Irovetti feared that upon returning the sword to Nyrissa, she would cast him aside. He was not yet ready to lose the power her favor granted him, and he reasoned that he could simply rule Pitax for another decade or so and keep *Briar's* recovery secret; then, when he grew tired of life as a king, he could announce to Nyrissa his "recent recovery" of *Briar* and enjoy the reward for his service to the fey queen.

Yet Nyrissa has had little time to wonder why it has taken Irovetti so long to find the sword, for as "War of the River Kings" begins, the time for her to gather up the Stolen Lands draws near. Through her manipulation of Irovetti, she hopes to spur the headstrong king into attacking the PCs' kingdom. If the PCs don't react in kind, she is prepared to send one of her agents to provoke them, but she hopes that Irovetti's unprovoked attack does the trick. She then has but to wait for the human kingdoms that control the lands she wishes to take to weaken each other; she hopes that after the war is over, the surviving kingdom will be worthy of her eldritch assault on the land.

THE RUSHLIGHT TOURNAMENT

Once the PCs reach 13th level and have defeated Drelev and Armag, it's time to begin this chapter. The PCs receive an invitation from Pitax's King Irovetti to something called the "Rushlight Tournament." The invitation arrives via messenger—a fleet-footed man named Velemandr (use the stats for a Pitax warden if necessary) who is willing to wait up to a day for the PCs to make their decision before returning to Pitax to report their response to Irovetti. The invitation is presented above as **Handout 8–1**.

A PC who succeeds at a DC 20 Society check to Recall Knowledge knows that the Rushlight Tournament is one of King Irovetti's most popular traditions. A Rushlight Tournament has been held every year since King Irovetti claimed the crown; it's a popular event that draws the majority of its contestants from Pitax

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but also sees participants from throughout the River Kingdoms. The tournament traditionally takes place on a small area of cleared land on the southern shore of the Rushlight River near the northeastern border of Pitax, just a few days' travel west of Fort Drelev.

If the PCs don't seem interested in attending the Rushlight Tournament, you can have helpful NPCs give some good reasons for taking part in the competition: even if the PCs don't compete in the numerous events, attending the Tournament is a great opportunity to meet other notables of the River Kingdoms and to present themselves as the rulers of the newest River Kingdom, and failure to appear at this well-known and much anticipated event could be misinterpreted by other River Kings as a sign of weakness or even a deliberate insult or veiled act of aggression. Actually competing in the tournament and winning (or even placing) in the events would bring fame and prestige not only to the PCs, but to their entire kingdom. And finally, there's the lure of the promised magical wand—this year's grand prize for the kingdom that scores the most points during the tournament.

THE FESTIVAL GROUNDS

The Rushlight Tournament is held at a massive festival ground erected by King Irovetti a dozen miles northeast of the city of Pitax, about a half-mile from the southern shore of the Rushlight River itself on the banks of a minor waterway called Cutter's Creek (encounter site **RU2**). Once the tournament gets underway, the festival grounds become thronged with people, essentially transforming the area into a town overnight. Merchants from numerous River Kingdoms come to hawk their wares at this event; traditionally, even Brevoy sends some representatives, although this year marks the first with no official Brevic presence as internal tensions in that nation are nearing a breaking point. Wandering merchants jockey for space, crying their wares, whether hot from a basket or cool from a cask. Stages with jugglers, minstrels, mummers' troupes, and trained animals dancing and leaping all vie for the attention (and the coin) of the crowds reveling in King Irovetti's bounty.

The festival begins on the first Fireday of the month (although you should feel free to adjust this date to anything that you wish to fit the realities of your Kingmaker campaign). The first day of the tournament is given over to trading, feasting, a preview of the beasts of the traveling menagerie, entertainment (of varying quality), and after sunset, a grand display of fireworks. The next three days are highlighted by contests at the Coliseum, then followed by a day of rest. Finally, on the sixth day, the tournament concludes with a nightlong celebration of wine in honor of Pitax's many vintners, all culminating in the traditional Midnight Joust, after which the winner of the tournament is announced.

ALTERNATE PRELUDES TO WAR

This chapter assumes the PCs take up the invitation to participate in the Rushlight Tournament, but Kingmaker is first and foremost a sandbox campaign. Some parties may not be interested in participating in a tournament, and others may well (and rightly) suspect treachery from Irovetti. If the PCs decline the invitation, Irovetti is frustrated yet continues forward with his plans. The events of the Rushlight Tournament take place off-screen (and you can use the rules here later if you wish, with a few names changed, to present a tournament the PCs' own citizens put on in their honor—in this case, the competition is largely for fun rather than for a vaunted prize, fame, and glory), and the PCs are free to continue to explore the Stolen Lands and build up their resources. Once the PCs reach 14th level, King Irovetti launches an attack on one of their kingdom's settlements and you can proceed with Part 2.

The festival grounds themselves are laid out along Cutter's Creek, a minor tributary of the Rushlight River. The major features of the festival grounds are described below; all of these locations can be visited at any time by curious PCs.

Coliseum: All of the official tournament events take place in this large field of hard-packed dirt. The northern side of this large, open field has rows of bench seats for spectators. A noble's box stands at the east end of the field; seating there is limited.

Menagerie: This enormous purple pavilion is a showplace of tamed horrors and monstrosities from across Golarion. The mysterious **Madame Duclarion** (CN female human sorcerer 10) and her hulking handlers, the **Brothers Ohka** (CN male ogre warriors; *Pathfinder Bestiary* 252), keep a charmed menagerie of dinosaurs, rare animals, and supernatural beasts culled from every land for the viewing pleasure of festival-goers. Madame Duclarion keeps her creatures (and her handlers) calm and controlled through judicious use of various enchantment effects.

Rotunda: The Rotunda is where tickets to tourney events can be purchased; each day's events cost as little as 1 sp for a single ticket to as much as 100 gp for a noble "box" suitable for seating up to 10.

The Royal Blue: The buildings that surround this small lake are grand silk pavilions facing the water. These are reserved for the private use of visiting dignitaries from the other River Kingdoms, with flags flying above them marking the lands of their inhabitants. If the PCs accept their invitation to the event from Lord Irovetti, they are granted the use of the easternmost pavilion for the duration of the event.

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Royal Pavilion: This pavilion is used by the king. Irovetti keeps the pavilion protected with a *private sanctum* heightened to 8th level, so that anyone who peers into the tent sees only a dark, foggy mass.

Staging Pavilion: This pavilion is used for competitors preparing for games or other competitions in the coliseum. The pavilion has several smaller areas formed by canvas walls around a central area for competitors to gather in before they emerge when announced for a competition.

TOURNAMENT SECURITY

Many of Pitax's most capable guards serve long hours as security. The bulk of these guards are the equivalent of palace guards (*Pathfinder Gamemastery Guide* 206) or watch officers (*Pathfinder Gamemastery Guide* 234), but a more dangerous type of guard patrols the tournament grounds—and Pitax itself. These are the notorious Pitax Wardens—battle-trained soldiers who augment their skill at swordplay with occult magic. They are encountered often throughout this adventure, so their stats are presented below and referenced as needed in the text.

PITAX WARDEN — CREATURE 12

RARE N MEDIUM HUMAN HUMANOID

Human royal guard

Perception +22

Languages Common, Hallit

Skills Acrobatics +22, Athletics +25, Intimidation +24, Occultism +20, Performance +24, Society +20

Str +5, **Dex** +2, **Con** +3, **Int** +0, **Wis** +2, **Cha** +4

Items *+1 full plate*, *+1 striking greatsword*, *moderate healing potions* (2), composite shortbow (20 arrows)

AC 33; **Fort** +23, **Ref** +21, **Will** +23

HP 215

Attack of Opportunity ↷

Speed 25 feet

Melee ❖ *greatsword* +26 (versatile P), **Damage** 2d12+9 slashing

Ranged ❖ shortbow +23 (deadly d10, propulsive, reload 0), **Damage** 1d6+9 piercing

Occult Spontaneous Spells DC 30, attack +22; **4th** (1 slot) *discern lies*; **3rd** (1 slot) *haste*; **2nd** (1 slot) *telekinetic maneuver*; **1st** (1 slot) *ray of enfeeblement*; **Cantrips (4th)** *daze*, *shield*

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Power Attack ❖❖ The warden makes a melee Strike. This counts as two attacks for their multiple attack penalty. If it hits, it deals an extra die of weapon damage.

Sudden Charge ❖❖ The Pitax warden dashes up to their foe and swings. They Stride twice; if they end their movement within melee reach of at least one enemy, they can make a melee Strike against that enemy.

AN AUDIENCE WITH THE KING

When the PCs first arrive at the Festival Grounds, King Irovetti expects them to pay a visit to his Royal Pavilion (allow the PCs a DC 20 Society check to realize this). If the PCs don't visit the king within a few hours of arriving at the festival grounds, a Pitax warden arrives to request their presence and escort them to the Royal Pavilion to greet the king.

The royal pavilion stands in sharp contrast to its relatively plain exterior. Lush, red carpets cover the ground and a dais supporting a carved and gilded chair evoke the feel of a throne room, while a haphazard collection of pedestals bearing sculptures and mounted paintings of wildly varying quality and realism suggests a strange sort of art gallery. A small, raised stage supporting numerous large musical instruments sits to one side of the pavilion.

King Irovetti is a handsome, muscular, dark-haired man clad in deep red velvets. A crown sits comfortably on his brow and an elegant cloak drapes his shoulders. His belt is thick with tools, weapons, and pouches, bespeaking an adventuring lifestyle not completely left behind. He also carries two strange pieces of equipment: The first and most impressive is a long staff of unusual metal, one end of which is fitted with thin blades and a spike that periodically shift and move with a soft whirring noise. The second is a thin, short rod of strange metal with a single spike at the end; small, circular lights periodically flash along the length of this rod. Both of these curious items are Numerian devices (a rod of razors and a mindrender baton; see page 589 and 586 respectively for details). Attended by a pair of servants, Irovetti greets the PCs enthusiastically.

"My most illustrious guests! I am so eternally and unendingly happy to see that you have safely arrived. Come, my pretties, bring refreshment for these weary travelers—whether by magic or by mare's shank, traveling is thirsty work! Drink with me to our continued success and to the bonds of brotherhood and friendship that shall be ours."

Irovetti may seem friendly and calm, but in fact he's already sizing up the PCs for what he believes is an inevitable conflict—whether in person or on the battlefield remains to be seen. For now, though, he wants the PCs to feel as comfortable as possible, and he has no intention of treachery. The food and wine he offers are safe and delicious, and the idle questions about how they and their kingdom fare are relatively meaningless. If the PCs ask him point blank about Drelev, he seems to be somewhat embarrassed and admits that "Lord Drelev was, shall we say, a bit too eager for his own good. He got what he deserved, and I'm only thankful that you put him down before he caused both of our kingdoms more damage. I trust his attack on your town of Tatzlford left no lasting problems?" Irovetti does his best to steer talk away from politics, though, reminding the PCs that they are here for a festival, not a summit.



PITAX WARDEN

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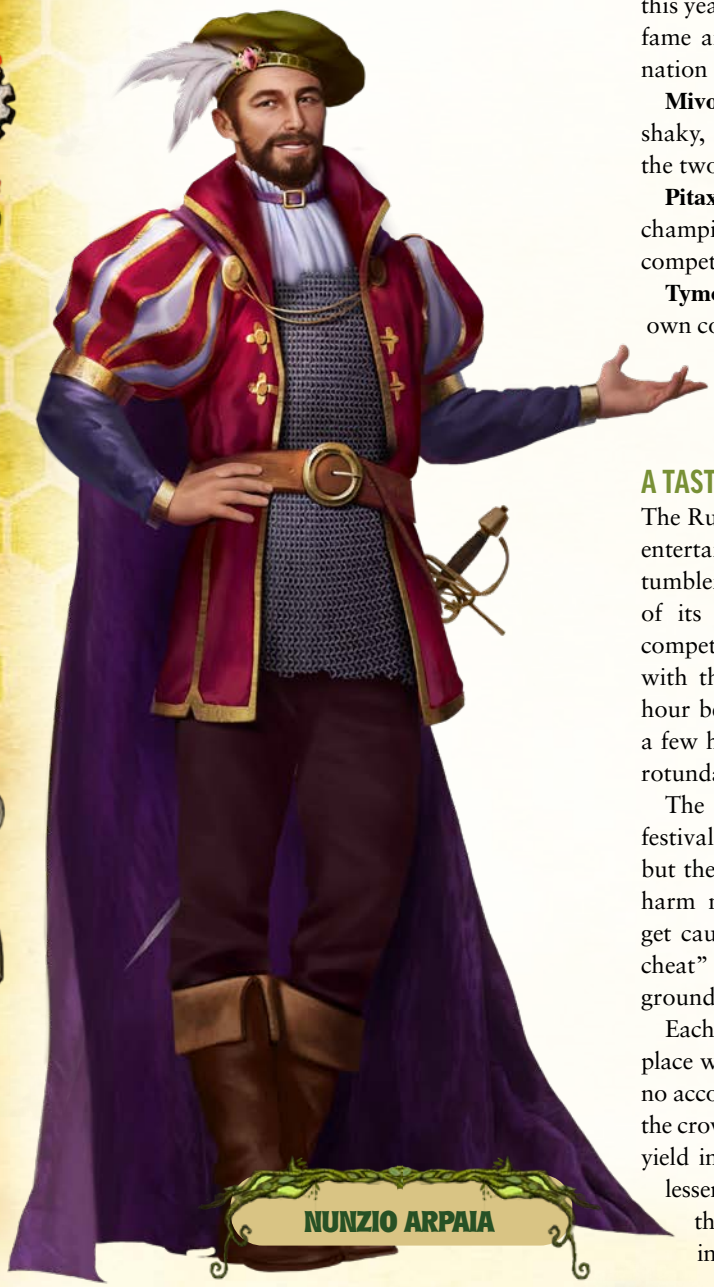
This chat should be relatively short—before long, Irovetti indicates he has much to do to prepare for the games, and he invites the PCs to retire to their assigned pavilion on the Royal Blue. He wishes them well in the games to come, and with that the PCs are expected to leave the tent and return to the festival grounds.

QUEST: THE RUSHLIGHT CHAMPION

80 XP | 80 KINGDOM XP

The PCs must compete in the Rushlight Tournament against several other River Kingdoms, either on their own or by selecting champions to represent their kingdom.

Source: King Irovetti.



NUNZIO ARPAIA

Completion: Earn the most tournament points overall (page 339).

Reward: A *wand of magnificent mansion* and 8000 gp.

MEETING THE COMPETITION

This year, the participants consist of six kingdoms in all, including the PCs' kingdom.

Daggermark: Daggermark, as one of the most successful River Kingdoms, attends the competition out of a sense of duty, although their competitors are generally more interested in the entertainment than they are at actually competing for the prize.

Gralton: The kingdom of Gralton has suffered long and hard to survive, and their reasons for competing this year are the same as every year: if they can win, the fame and glory and monetary awards will help their nation greatly.

Mivon: Although Mivon's relations with Pitax are shaky, with skirmishes common along their borders, the two nations are currently in something of a peace.

Pitax: Although Pitax hosts the competition, its champions feel no shame or awkwardness over competing themselves.

Tymon: The kingdom of Tymon is famous for its own competitions and gladiatorial battles. King Ungin sends representatives to all of the competitions and tournaments that occur in the River Kingdoms if he can, large or small.

A TASTE OF GLORY

The Rushlight Tournament has all manner of common entertainments, minstrels, mummers, singers, jugglers, tumblers, trained animals, and on and on, but much of its allure lies in the glory of competition. All competitive events take place in the Coliseum and, with the exception of the Midnight Joust, begin an hour before noon. Typically, the competitions last for a few hours, with the day's winners announced at the rotunda in the Commons in the early evening.

The schedule of games is posted throughout the festival grounds. Each competition has its own rules, but there are three rules that govern all of the events: harm no spectators, kill no competitors, and don't get caught cheating (canny PCs will note that "don't cheat" is not a rule). Breaking any of these rules is grounds for disqualification from that event.

Each contest has a first-place winner and a second-place winner; those who don't place first or second win no accolades at all and are instead mocked ruthlessly by the crowd after the competition. Contestants can always yield in a contest if they wish, although this does not lessen the mockery. Most of the contests are timed by the use of a large and extravagant water clock kept in the nobles' palisade to the east of the coliseum.

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Although King Irovetti serves as the arbiter and final judge for all of the events, his master of ceremonies, an unarmored Pitax Warden named **Nunzio Arpaia** (N male human royal guard), handles all of the announcements, introductions, and commentary during the games. At some point on the first day of the ceremony, Nunzio approaches the PCs and briefly outlines the nature of the four events for them, describing them as "an archery contest using longbows, a test of strength using handaxes or greataxes, a boasting contest, and a drunken jousting competition." He assumes the PCs' kingdom will be participating in the tournament and needs to know who their competitors will be for each event, along with how each competitor wants to be announced at the start of each contest.

Contest Rules: The rules for each contest differ, but each participant in the contest has a stat block with all the information you need to determine their rolls or if they can catch a PC cheating. In most cases where a character attempts to cheat, observers (including the PCs, all other contestants, and Nunzio Arpaia) have a chance to notice.

First-Place Win: If the PCs win first place in a contest, they earn 2 Tournament Points, 80 XP, and 80 Kingdom XP.

Second-Place Win: If the PCs win second place in a contest, they earn 1 Tournament Point, 40 XP, and 40 Kingdom XP.

EVENT 1: AIMING AT THE TARGET

The first tournament event is an archery competition on the second day of the Rushlight Tournament. Since this competition is meant to test skill and not magic, each contestant must use a nonmagical longbow provided by Irovetti. Contestants stand at the eastern end of the Coliseum and fire at one of three targets set up at varying distances to the west. Particularly foolish or daring observers enjoy sitting on the benches on the west side of the shooting range; if they're accidentally shot, this does not count as a "harming spectators" disqualification. The four hours leading up to the actual competition are filled with exhibition archery from a wide range of archers of various levels of talent (or lack thereof).

Contest Rules: Each contestant is given six arrows to fire at three different targets—a short-range blue target, a medium-range green target, and a long-range red target. To score points, the contestant's arrow must make a solid hit, not only hitting the target but sticking into it—a shot that fails to do enough damage to overcome the target's Hardness bounces off and does not stick. A critical hit on a target indicates a bull's-eye. All shots must be taken in 6 rounds or the shooter is disqualified. Likewise, if no shots hit, the shooter is disqualified. If the shooter fires all six arrows in fewer than 6 rounds, they earn 2 bonus points for each remaining round.

BLUE TARGET

This target has a picture of a kobold painted on it. The target is made of canvas stretched over straw.

Range 50 feet (no range penalty)
AC 25; **Hardness** 2
Solid Hit 1 point; **Critical Hit** 3 points

GREEN TARGET

This target has a picture of an owlbear painted on it. The target is made of wood reinforced with metal bands.

Range 150 feet (–2 range penalty)
AC 30; **Hardness** 6
Solid Hit 3 points; **Critical Hit** 9 points

RED TARGET

This target has a picture of a dragon painted on it. The target is made of reinforced iron.

Range 450 feet (–8 range penalty)
AC 35; **Hardness** 10
Solid Hit 5 points; **Critical Hit** 15 points

Contestants: The five other contestants are listed below, with the kingdom they represent indicated as a trait, after which their individual strategy for accumulating as many points as possible is presented. As more contestants shoot, the target number of points becomes a quantifiable goal, which might spur a contestant to abandon a strategy to take riskier or easier shots, depending on what the established point total to beat is. Determine the order in which the contestants shoot randomly.

DAMANJOT

TYMON

CN male half-orc rogue 13

Damanjot has made a career of winning competitions by cheating, and he sees no reason to change tactics that have served him well—this time, he has smuggled in six adamantine-headed arrows to give him an advantage.

Perception +23
Skills Deception +24, Thievery +27
Will +21
Items disguised adamantine arrows (6)
Ranged longbow +27, **Damage** 1d8+4 piercing
Far Shot Damanjot takes no range penalty when shooting at the green target and only a –4 penalty when shooting at the red target.
Strategy Before the contest begins, Damanjot uses his skill at Thievery to attempt to swap out the normal arrows he's given at the start of the competition with adamantine-tipped arrows he has prepared beforehand (these arrows treat the targets as if they had half as much Hardness). He attempts a Thievery check opposed by the Perception DC of all observers. If anyone notices and calls him on

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the swap, he attempts a Deception check to Lie, spinning a tale that he was only making sure that everyone was watching for cheaters and trying to prove a point. If he succeeds at his Lie against the observers, he's allowed to continue with normal arrows—otherwise he's disqualified. If no one notices his arrow swap, the adamantine arrows are eventually noticed after the contest while the arrows are being gathered up, but by this point it's too late to accuse anyone in particular of the cheating. Damanjot takes two shots each round—the first at the red target and the second at the green one.



FLORANTE MAYANK

GRALTON

CG female half-elf fighter 9

Florante is an eager, proud archer who has been looking forward to representing Gralton in the Rushlight Festival, but her placement has more to do with pulled political strings than actual skill; she'll need luck to stand a chance against the PCs and most other archers.

Perception +21

Will +16

Ranged longbow +21, **Damage** 1d8+3 piercing

Precise Aim ❖❖❖ Florante takes the entire round to line up her shot and aim at its weak points. She makes a ranged Strike against her target. On this Strike, she gains a +2 circumstance bonus to the attack roll and reduces the target's Hardness by 4 (minimum 0).

Strategy Florante takes one shot per round, using Precise Aim to make each shot count. She shoots her first three arrows at the green target, hoping to score at least one critical hit. If she does, she shoots her second three attacks against the red target. If she misses two shots in a row, she takes the next shot against the blue target before returning to her previous choice.

ILRAITH VALADHKANI

DAGGERMARK

CN male human rogue 12

Ilraith is a smirking cad of a man, a thief whose dabbling in bardic traditions and archery have afforded him both the will and the means to cheat at contests such as these.

Perception +22

Skills Performance +25

Will +22

Ranged longbow +26, **Damage** 1d8+6 piercing

Occult Spontaneous Spell DC 30; **1st** (1 slot) *true strike*

Far Shot Ilraith takes no range penalty when shooting at the green target and only a –4 penalty when shooting at the red target.

Braggadocio ❖ (concentrate, manipulate, metamagic) Ilraith can disguise his spellcasting with an over-the-top oration proclaiming his skill and predicting where his shot will land. If the next action he takes is to cast *true strike*, he attempts a Performance check against all observer's Perception DCs. If his check is successful against an observer's Perception DC, that observer doesn't realize Ilraith has cast *true strike*.

Strategy Each round, Ilraith spends one of his actions to brag (not using Braggadocio) about his skills, then he takes two shots. His first shot is at the red target, and his second shot is at the green target. If he is down on points on the third round, he fires only one arrow at the green target, then on the fourth round he uses Braggadocio before casting *true strike* and shooting at the red target.

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NAVARATHNA

MIVON

CN female elf ranger 11

Navarathna is something of a show-off, and she has a habit of not thinking through her plans. This, combined with a stubborn streak, puts her at a significant disadvantage in this contest.

Perception +21, low-light vision
Will +22
Ranged longbow +23, **Damage** 1d8+3 piercing
Triple Shot ❖❖❖ Navarathna makes three longbow Strikes, each against a separate target and with a –4 penalty.

Strategy Navarathna's plan is to fire her arrows as quickly as possible in the first 2 rounds of the contest, so she can automatically pick up the extra 8 points for finishing off all six of her arrows early. She does so by using Triple Shot to fire at each of the three targets. If she makes at least 4 points, she repeats this tactic on round 2, otherwise, her bravado breaks and she takes only single shots at the blue target on each of the following rounds, saving her last shot for the red target in hopes of making up a few extra points.

VILLAMOR KOTH

PITAX

CE male human barbarian 15

Villamor is a foul-tempered, unpleasant, bristly mountain of a man. King Irovetti makes sure Villamor participates in as many of the contests as possible; the king has privately promised the man additional fame and riches if he manages to win out over the PCs.

Perception +27
Will +27
Ranged longbow +25, **Damage** 1d8+4 piercing

Strategy Villamor takes only one shot per round. His first five shots are all against the red target. If he misses more than two of these shots, he chickens out and takes his last shot at the blue target.

Winning: The contestant with the high score wins first place, and the contestant with the second highest score wins second place. In the unlikely event of a tie, the contest moves on to as many tiebreaker stages as are necessary, with each tied contestant given only 1 arrow per stage (Damanjot has no more adamantine arrows to use in such an event).

EVENT 2: TEST OF THE AXE

This event is a test of strength that occurs on the third day of the Rushlight Tournament. In the test of the axe, each contestant is assigned to one of six fifteen-foot squares demarcated at each corner by a large upright log. The winner is the first contestant to hew through all four of their square's logs using a greataxe. Similar to the archery competition, the four hours leading up to this event are filled with exhibition woodchopping from a wide range of would-be lumberjacks.

Contest Rules: At the start, contestants are supplied with a greataxe and are then directed to take position inside their square. Nunzio holds a bright red flag up in the air, and when he lowers it, the six contestants can start hacking away at their logs (AC 20, Hardness 5, HP 20 [BT 10]) with their greataxe. Magic is allowed, but only to enhance an axe or its wielder—if the contestant damages or directly targets a log with something other than a greataxe or casts a spell on another competitor or their axe, they are disqualified.

It's easiest to set up this contest in encounter mode, assigning each contestant a three-by-three grid of five-foot squares with the contestant starting in the grid's center square and the logs in the middle of each corner square. The six grids should all be close together so that each contestant starts no more than 15 feet from at least one other contestant; some of the NPCs have tactics below that can affect other targets in range. Let the PC contestant choose whichever grid they want to be assigned to them (note that this contest is designed for Small or Medium contestants—larger contestants are not allowed, since they would have an unfair advantage). Once Nunzio lowers his flag, each contestant determines Initiative by rolling a Perception check, then attempts to chop through their logs as detailed in their Strategy section.

Contestants: The five NPC contestants are listed below, along with their strategies for chopping through their logs as quickly as possible.

YEGINA VARUDU

DAGGERMARK

N female human sorcerer 12

Yegina looks rather small and frail, and she receives a fair amount of mockery during the early portions of this contest—mockery she heroically ignores with a smile on her face. Despite being something of a waif, Yegina is a talented sorcerer with a few magical tricks up her sleeve. She picked up proficiency with several martial weapons as a result of growing up in a family of mercenaries, and her ability to mix magic with her axe blows, she hopes, will help her not only win, but humiliate the other, more brawny contestants.

Perception +25 (+27 rolling initiative)
Will +25
Melee *greataxe* +16, **Damage** 2d12+2 slashing

Strategy On the first round, Yegina casts *magic weapon* on her greataxe, then uses Quickened Spell metamagic to cast *haste* as her third action on that round. She spends the following rounds powering through as many logs as she can. Her melee strike above includes adjustments for *magic weapon*.

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KILBASKIAN ORD

GRALTON

CN male human ranger 10

Kilbaskian is a handsome man with a full beard and broad shoulders who has spent much of his youth as a border guard for Gralton. He's somewhat frustrated that he has to use a single greataxe rather than a pair of battleaxes (his preferred fighting style).

Perception +22

Skills Intimidation +22

Will +19

Melee greataxe +23, **Damage** 1d12+6 slashing

Threaten Competition ↷ (emotion, mental) **Trigger** another contestant destroys a log; **Effect** Kilbaskian quickly hurls a string of threats at the triggering contestant, promising the contestant that they'll be the first thing he chops in half once this contest is over if they don't back out at once. Kilbaskian attempts to Demoralize the foe but suffers a –2 circumstance penalty on his Intimidation check to do so.

Strategy Kilbaskian spews profanities as he starts hacking away at his logs, increasingly angered by the fact that "last year, we could use any axe, not just these big clumsy things!" He'll make use of his Threaten Competition reaction as often as he can. While this isn't strictly against the rules, it's close. The other contestants do their best to ignore him, but any PC (not just a PC contestant) can attempt a DC 31 Diplomacy check to appeal to Nunzio to issue a warning to Kilbaskian. On a success, Nunzio does so and Kilbaskian doesn't use the reaction for the rest of the competition. On a critical success, Nunzio disqualifies Kilbaskain after the competition. On a critical failure, Kilbaskian is emboldened and at the start of his next turn, he gains an additional reaction that he can use to Threaten Competition.

DIZON MARMADA

MIVON

LN female dwarf fighter 12

Dizon is a no-nonsense woman who agreed to take part in this contest only after pretty much everyone she knows cajoled her into it. She's the only professional lumberjack among the contestants, and her skill at chopping trees makes her a formidable competitor, although her personality makes her particularly vulnerable to Kilbaskian's attitude.

Perception +22

Will +20

Overreaction If Kilbaskian successfully intimidates Dizon with Threaten Competition, she wastes an action on her next turn yelling back at him in addition to suffering the normal penalty for being Demoralized.

Melee greataxe +26, **Damage** 1d12+7 slashing

Lumberjack Style Dizon treats the logs as if they have Hardness 2 when she strikes them.

Power Attack ◆◆ Dizon makes a particularly powerful attack. She makes a melee Strike that counts as two attacks when calculating her multiple attack penalty. If this Strike hits, she deals two extra dice of damage.

Strategy Dizon uses Power Attack every turn, followed by a standard attack.

VILLAMOR KOTH

PITAX

CE male human barbarian 15

The PCs recognize Villamor from the archery contest.

Perception +27

Will +27

Melee greataxe +28, **Damage** 1d12+25 slashing

Strategy Villamor rages as his first action, then focuses his actions each round on simply hacking logs apart. If he hits a log but fails to destroy it, he then takes an action to use Knockback to push the log into a square adjacent to another of his logs. Once he does so, if he critically hits a log, he can use the axe's critical specialization effect to deal damage equal to his 1d12 roll to damage the first log to an adjacent log.

TIMSINA SIRAJ

TYMON

CN female human cleric of Gorum 12

Timsina is a very well-known face among the many fighting pits and arenas of Tymon, where she's built up a reputation for violence. She'd hoped a grand melee style event would take place at the tournament, but she settled for "chopping up some logs with a big axe" instead. She chants prayers to Gorum throughout the contest.

Perception +25

Will +25

Melee greataxe +24, **Damage** 1d12+6

Strategy Timsina initially hopes to win this competition based solely on her physical might, but if she's falling behind, she casts *magic weapon* on her greataxe. If it becomes apparent that she's not going to get first or second place, she uses *cry of destruction* heightened to inflict 6d8 points of sonic damage (DC 32 basic Fortitude save) to one of her remaining logs (potentially catching a PC or other competitor in the 15-foot-cone at your discretion); since she has already lost this competition, she isn't too worried about being disqualified.

Winning: The winner is the first contestant to destroy all four of their logs. The contestant who is the second to destroy their logs comes in second place.

EVENT 3: BOASTING

The third tournament event is a test of boasting and storytelling; it occurs on the fourth day. This is the event the audience is anticipating the most, as it is

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one of the most traditional events—it has occurred in every Rushlight Tournament from the start, beating out the Midnight Joust by a year for that honor. Much speculation on the audacity and nature of the tales to be shared during the boast make the rounds in the days leading up to this event.

Contest Rules: For this event, a wooden platform is built in the center of the Coliseum. In turn, each contestant takes this stage and boasts to the audience of one of their greatest accomplishments. The boast must last for 15 minutes and must consist of a beginning, a middle, and an end. The contest requires the boaster to take the Boast activity three consecutive times to determine how well they tell their tale and how the audience responds.

BOAST

AUDITORY | CONCENTRATE | EXPLORATION | LINGUISTIC

You recount a crowd-pleasing tale, showing off something you and your allies may (or may not) have actually done—the story you tell just needs to be exciting. In this contest, a Boast consists of three parts: a beginning, a middle, and an end. To begin, the character introduces themselves and sets the scene for the story. The character then goes on to tell the bulk of the tale in the second part. In the final part they conclude with the story's climax. In each part, the character can decide to entirely make things up by attempting a Deception check, to relate the events in a way that appeals to the specific audience's interests with a Diplomacy check, to present the story in an intense and frightening way with an Intimidation check, to enhance the tale with their own storytelling craft with a Performance check, or to impress the audience with fine details and bits of knowledge on the topic with a Lore check appropriate to the story's topic. Boasting is meant to keep the audience enthralled and surprised, so the boaster must use a different skill check for each of the three parts unless they critically succeed at a check, in which case the audience loves that style of boasting so much that the boaster can use that check again for their next Boast check.

This particular contest is a 13th-level encounter, so in all cases, the DC for these checks is 31. If you wish to include Boasts in other encounters, you should use the appropriate DC by level.

Critical Success The audience reacts with cheers, screams, and laughter as appropriate to the tale. The boaster gains 2 Victory Points and can use the same skill check that just achieved this critical success again for their next Boast.

Success The audience is delighted with the tale. A few chuckles and screams and applause happen here and there. The boaster gains 1 Victory Point.

Failure The audience is not quite bored, but also not quite engaged—awkward silences, coughs, and shifting in seats reveal the crowd's growing disinterest. The boaster gains no Victory Points.

Critical Failure The audience reacts with derisive laughter, catcalls, or even thrown food. The boaster loses 1 Victory Point.

Contestants: The order in which the contestants boast doesn't matter, though Memon should go before Mialolessa. Each contestant's boast is presented in abbreviated form in their strategy entry; you can use this summary as presented or you can expound upon it as you see fit. After the strategy entry is a Boast Checks entry that lists the order in which the NPC makes skill checks for the beginning, middle, and end of their boast (NPCs don't take advantage of critical successes to roll the same check for the next boast).

MEMON ESPONDE

DAGGERMARK

NE male human rogue 12

Memon Esponde is a dashing rogue with an immaculately groomed mustache and beard.

Perception +23

Skills Deception +25, Intimidation +22, Performance +19

Will +21

Strategy Memon introduces himself as a master infiltrator and implies that he has manipulated the ebb and flow of political power in the River Kingdoms for nearly a decade. He then lightens the mood, going on to spin an implausible tale about how he stole into a temple of Calistria and seduced all seven of its priestesses, including the high priestess, in a single night; when the clergy realized he loved none of them, he escaped on the back of the temple's sacred giant wasp with the high priestess's corset as a trophy. A successful DC 35 Perception check to Sense Motive during this boast gives the distinct impression that the high priestess Memon is talking about is none other than Tymon's contestant, Mialolessa, although she's nonplussed by Memon's story.

Boast Checks Intimidation, Deception, Performance

ANKUS DEPERGODE

GRALTON

N male dwarf rogue 10

Ankus Depergode is a relatively flamboyant dwarf with a bombastic voice.

Perception +20

Skills Deception +24, Diplomacy +19, Performance +22

Will +18

Strategy Ankus boasts of how he stowed away on the *Seawraith*, the ship of the goddess of pirates, Besmara, and of his adventures in the Outer Sphere. In particular, he boasts of how he won a deva's wings and a devil's beard in a single gambling game. Despite the audacity

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of Ankus's claims, the crowd seems to be particularly excited and delighted by his tale. This is because Ankus has a ringer in the crowd—a bard friend who's using his various talents and spells to subtly manipulate key members of the audience to make it appear that Ankus is far more popular than he really is. At the end of each of Ankus's Boast activities, allow each of the PCs to attempt a DC 33 Occult or DC 36 Perception check to notice Ankus's ringer behaving strangely. If the PCs call out the ringer and confront him, Ankus panics and King Irovetti bemusedly disqualifies the dwarf for cheating.

Boast Checks Performance, Diplomacy, Deception



ANKUS DEPERGODE

CEALA RAVENBROW

MIVON

CG female human fighter 11

Ceala Ravenbrow is something of a folk hero in her home nation of Mivon. She wears her signature raven-themed helm and cloak of black feathers, and her fans in the crowd are particularly excited to hear her story, even though it's arguably the least impressive of the boasts on offer today.

Perception +17

Skills Intimidation +22, Galt Lore +21, Performance +19

Will +19

Strategy Ceala's boast is a tale of blood and danger—she single-handedly saved a small village in northern Galt from the ravages of a demonic chimera who had wings of fire and a scorpion's tail. If her tale is to be believed, Ceala lopped off the chimera's dragon head with her sword, crushed the goat head under a falling rock, and tore the chimera's tail from its body and strangled its remaining lion head in order to kill it—all without spilling the glass of elven absinthe she'd started to drink when the chimera spotted and attacked her.

Boast Checks Galt Lore, Intimidation, Performance

ANNAMEDE BELAVARAH

PITAX

CN female human bard 13

Annamede is one of Pitax's best-known comedians and social commentators. King Irovetti has a strong dislike of the woman, as she has rebuffed his advances numerous times and seems to have no fear of speaking out against his rule in Pitax, yet the fact that she's so well-loved by the populace and has won the boasting competition every year ensures her role—Irovetti would rather Pitax keep its crown in this contest than silence the bard. Annamede remains as charming and arrogant as she was when the PCs first encountered her during the hunt at the start of the Season of Bloom (see Chapter 5). Since then, her fortunes in Pitax have grown considerably, and she's gained five levels of experience since her previous encounter with the PCs. (If Annamede did not survive the hunt, her sister Ilemestra fills her role here; Ilemestra is antagonistic to the PCs as—rightly or wrongly—she believes their actions contributed to Annamede's death.)

Perception +23

Skills Deception +26, Diplomacy +24, Performance +27

Will +23

Strategy Annamede's boast should interest the PCs in particular, for she claims to have spent the past several months (or years, as appropriate for your campaign) spying upon the PCs' kingdom. The nature of her boast varies. If the PCs didn't particularly impress or befriend her in Chapter 5, she speaks of how she used her influence and skills to cause all sorts of misfortune in the PCs' kingdom. You can cite specific events or developments

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from the past several sessions of play to make it seem like Annamede was the behind-the-scenes instigator of these events. If, on the other hand, the PCs impressed her in Chapter 5 by gaining at least 4 Influence with her, her boasts instead reveal how she aided the PCs' kingdom behind the scenes, helping to prevent greater disasters or otherwise taking the credit for kingdom successes in the past several sessions. Whether or not these boasts are true, her knowledge of various embarrassing failures and problems the PCs have had with their kingdom should feel eerily accurate. At your option, if a particular PC made a significant impression upon Annamede (either negative or positive), she'll throw out a specific insult or compliment as appropriate.

If Annamede's boast is positive or complimentary to the PC's kingdom, a PC can attempt a DC 30 Perception check to notice some pointed glances between Annamede and King Irovetti—she's obviously enjoying how her compliments are making the king squirm. King Irovetti manages to mostly hide his frustration and anger... but only just barely.

Boast Checks Performance, Deception, Diplomacy

MIALOLESSA

TYMON

CN female elf cleric of Calistria 14

Mialolessa is an elven woman, well-known and well-loved in her home kingdom of Tymon as a priestess of Calistria who specializes in mocking and humiliating failed gladiators.

Perception +22

Skills Deception +24, Intimidation +27, Performance +22

Will +26

Strategy Mialolessa boasts of her days spent in Kyonin, and of how she seduced a succubus who had been sent from Tanglebriar to capture her and drag her back to Treerazer to serve as the demon's consort. After captivating the succubus, Mialolessa sent her back into Tanglebriar and, to this day, the elf receives gifts of strange fungal potions and wines with which the succubus attempts to win her back. She ends her story with a stinger: it took her weeks to recover from a particularly embarrassing condition she "caught" from her succubus lover, and she hopes none of her lovers since then have been suffering from a painful rash of late. At this, she casts a sly glance at Memon, who seems to look a bit worried.

Boast Checks Performance, Deception, Intimidation

Winning: The first- and second-place winners of the boast are determined by the accumulated Victory Point totals. In the unusual event of a tie for second place, all of those boasters are awarded a second place reward, but in the event of a tie for first place involving a PC, the tied boasters must perform a single new tie-breaking boast (rather than 3 boasts); the DC for this tiebreaker round increases by 2 to DC 33. Each time a tie repeats, this "sudden death" round repeats, with the DC increasing by 2 each time. If the tie for first place doesn't involve PCs, you should just decide which of the tied boasters wins the tie-breaker round rather than force the players to sit through rolls that don't directly affect them.

EVENT 4: THE MIDNIGHT JOUST

The final tournament event is one that many look forward to, if only since it's the Midnight Joust that promises the best chance at seeing competitors really hurt each other. It's something of an unspoken tradition that those who participate in the Midnight Joust are drunk; certainly, the majority of the audience is. The Midnight Joust, as implied by its name, takes place at midnight on the last day of the Tournament. The Coliseum is well lit by dozens of *everburning torches*, many of which are held by drunken observers in the stands. Those who elect to participate in the jousting while drunk are effectively sickened 2 at the start of their joust; jousting while drunk amuses the crowd but doesn't grant any additional points.

Contest Rules: Each jouster is equipped with a lance and a wooden shield. Riders may provide their own armor and gear, but they must use the weapon and shield provided. A heavy horse and a military saddle are provided for anyone who doesn't have their own mount. Once all six contestants have their mounts, the joust plays out over three stages, with each nation's champion facing off against one opponent. King Irovetti has predetermined who's jousting whom, but he does not reveal this information until the start of each stage.

A joust consists of both competitors beginning at opposite ends of the jousting arena. The competitors have 1 round in which they can prepare for the joust (the PCs are allowed to cast spells or otherwise prepare the jousting PC for the event as they wish during this round), after which Nunzio drops the flag and the two jousters charge toward each other, lances lowered, in an attempt to unhorse the other. Both jousters make Nature checks to Command an Animal to determine initiative as they charge toward each other; a character with wild empathy or who can speak to their mount can instead roll Diplomacy to determine initiative if they wish. In the event of a tie, both strike at each other simultaneously, possibly unseating each other in a dramatic clash.

When a character attempts to unseat a foe during a joust, they attempt an Athletics check to Shove their opponent. On a success, the foe can attempt a DC 30 Reflex save to resist being unseated; on a critical success, the foe is automatically unseated. On a critical failure, the Shoving character is instead unseated and tumbles to the ground. If the first jouster fails to unseat their foe but remains seated themselves, then the second jouster

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attempts to Shove the first jouster. If neither jouster is unseated, they replace their lances and shields (both are designed to shatter dramatically when they are used) and line up for another go. Any attack against a foe's horse is grounds for disqualification.

Stage One: This stage consists of three separate bouts. In the first, Pitax's champion Villamor Koth, whom the PCs encountered in the first two events, faces off against a staggeringly drunk human man named Khristel Cotoio from Mivon. As the joust begins, Khristel vomits and topples from his horse, blacking out from the drink. The crowd particularly enjoys this turn of events, although Villamor is frustrated at being denied a chance to show off his skills and sends a tirade of insults at Khristel as his allies drag him from the field.

In the second bout, the champions from Daggermark and Gralton clash spectacularly, with Chantal Urena (a female human ranger from Daggermark) unseating Sir Briannel Paulson (a male human ranger from Gralton) from his horse.

In the third and final bout of Stage One, the PC's chosen jouster faces off against Damanjot, the Tymon champion whom the PCs previously encountered in the archery contest. Damanjot is drunk and waves off all attempts form his supporters to provide aid; his statistics below include calculations for being sickened 2.



VILLAMOR KOTH

DAMANJOT

TYMON

CN male half-orc ranger 11
Perception +19
Skills Athletics +19, Nature +21
Fort +19, **Ref** +22, **Will** +16

Stage Two: As the reigning champion of the Midnight Joust from the previous year, Villamor Koth sits stage two out and watches impassively as the PCs face off against Chantal Urena of Daggermark (or a clash between Chantal and Damanjot, in the case the PCs' champion failed to progress from stage one). Chantal drinks a greater juggernaut mutagen before the bout to gain a +3 bonus on her Fortitude save but taking a –2 penalty to her Will saves, Perception checks, and her Nature check to determine initiative; these modifications are calculated into the following statistics already.

CHANTAL URENA

DAGGERMARK

CG female human ranger 13
Perception +21
Skills Athletics +24, Nature +27 (+25 when determining initiative)
Fort +26, **Ref** +26, **Will** +18

Stage Three: In the final stage, Villamor Koth faces off against the winner of stage two. If this is Chantal Urena, Villamor automatically wins the bout, much to King Irovetti's delight.

If the PCs face Villamor, though, then set up for a jousting match as in the first two stages. Villamor spends his round of preparation by drinking one of his *potions of barkskin* while a Pitax Warden casts *haste* on him (these effects are not included in his stat block below). He avoids raging since he needs to Command his mount in the joust.

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Villamor has no intention of keeping this friendly—he intends to humiliate and hurt his opponent—especially if they're doing well in the competition and look like they have a good chance at winning. He figures that if he can egg his jousting contestant into attacking him, he can kill that PC in self-defense without getting in too much trouble. He does not attempt to unseat a PC contestant when it gets to his turn in the joust, but instead makes a lance Strike against his opponent, following a successful Strike up with a Knockback. This forces the PC to attempt a DC 30 Reflex save to resist being unseated. To the observing crowd, Villamor's tactics are easily mistaken for overly aggressive attempts to unseat a rider—the crowd certainly loves the violence. If he's properly unseated by a PC, Villamor swallows his pride for now and nurtures the thought of revenge—he's one of Irovetti's closest allies, after all, and knows that the king plans to go to war.

Villamor does not fight to the death at this time. If the PCs respond to his goading by attacking, he'll "defend" himself (and attempt to kill the attacking PC), but if all the PCs start to gang up on him, or if he's reduced to fewer than 150 Hit Points, he breaks off his attack and Irovetti steps in to try to calm things down. Villamor resists the urge to Rage during this fight so he can keep his cool and not escalate things too far as a result. If the PCs continue to attack, Irovetti uses magic to escape back to the Royal Pavilion with Villamor and announces that the Rushlight Festival is canceled due to unwarranted aggression on a visitor's behalf. He gives the PCs an hour to leave Pitax before he attempts to have them arrested as criminals; this development gives him a handy, if flimsy, excuse to go to war with the PCs' kingdom. Certainly, the PCs aren't thought of kindly by the other competitors and attendants at the festival, for they see the PCs as the ones responsible for the tournament's cancellation in this case. See Part 2 for more information on how the war develops.

VILLAMOR KOTH CREATURE 15

UNIQUE | CE | MEDIUM | HUMAN | HUMANOID

Perception +27

Languages Common, Hallit

Skills Athletics +30, Intimidation +26, Nature +27, Survival +27, Warfare Lore +25

Str +5, **Dex** +2, **Con** +4, **Int** +0, **Wis** +4, **Cha** +3

Items *+2 resilient hide*, *+2 striking grievous greataxe*, lance

AC 35; **Fort** +27, **Ref** +23, **Will** +27

HP 350

Deny Advantage Villamor Koth's foes struggle to pass his defenses. He isn't flat-footed to hidden, undetected, or flanking creatures of his level or lower, or to creatures of his level or lower using surprise attack. However, these creatures can still help their allies flank.

Raging Resistance While raging, Villamor Koth gains resistance 7 to physical weapon damage (but not physical damage from other sources, such as unarmed attacks).

Attack of Opportunity ↷

Speed 35 feet

Melee ❖ *greataxe* +30 (sweep), **Damage** 2d12+13 slashing

Melee ❖ lance +28 (deadly d8, jousting d6, reach), **Damage** 1d8+12 piercing

Axe Specialization Villamor Koth gains the critical specialization effects for all axes he wields.

Furious Finish ❖ (rage) Desperate to finish the fight, Villamor Koth pours all his rage into one final blow. He makes a Strike. If it hits, he gains a circumstance bonus to damage equal to the number of rounds remaining in his Rage (maximum 10). After this Strike, his Rage immediately ends and he is fatigued until he rests for at least 10 minutes.

Giant's Lunge ❖ (concentrate, rage) Villamor Koth extends his body and prepares to attack foes outside his normal reach. Until his rage ends, all his melee weapons and unarmed attacks gain reach 10. This doesn't increase the reach of any weapon or unarmed attack that already has the reach trait, but it does combine with abilities that increase his reach due to increased size.

Knockback ❖ (rage) **Requirements** Villamor Koth's last action was a successful Strike. **Effect** Villamor Koth pushes his foe back 5 feet, with the effects of a successful Shove. He can follow the foe as normal for a successful shove.

Rage ❖ Villamor begins raging. He gains 19 temporary Hit Points. This frenzy lasts for 1 minute, until there are no enemies he can perceive, or until he falls unconscious, whichever comes first. He can't voluntarily stop raging. While he is raging, he deals 12 additional damage with melee weapons and unarmed attacks. This additional damage is halved if his weapon or unarmed attack is agile. While raging, Villamor Koth's AC is 33.

SPOILS OF VICTORY

With the end of the Midnight Joust, King Irovetti and his master of ceremonies take the field, inviting the contestants to join them as they award the grand prize—a *wand of magnificent mansion* and a iron-bound treasure chest filled with 8,000 gp. (If your group contains no spellcasters capable of using the wand, fee free to swap it for a different 15th-level item.) See page 339 for how to determine the actual tournament winner. In any event, once the ceremony is over, the crowd breaks up quickly, eager to either attend one of the many post-tournament celebrations or to get some much-needed rest. Traditionally, visitors to Pitax spend several days unwinding in the city, but the PCs are likely to receive urgent news from home before the dawn—see Part 2.

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PART 2:

BEHIND ENEMY LINES

As entertaining as the Rushlight Tournament is, and as friendly as King Irovetti might seem, the entire tournament is little more than a devious distraction. Irovetti has entrusted the general of his armies, an onidoshi oni named Avinash Jurrg, to lead some of Pitax's army—including a flight of wyverns—on an initial attack against the PCs' heartland. When word of this attack reaches the PCs' ears, they'll doubtless react in kind, and war will come to the Stolen Lands—just as Nyrissa had planned.

THE WAR BEGINS

How the War of the River Kings begins depends on the situation in your game and how your players have built their kingdom, but the assumption is that the PCs learn about an attack on one of their settlements (such as Fort Drelev, Tatzlford, or Varnhold) by a sizable group of Pitaxian soldiers and a flight of wyverns. If the PCs are the aggressors, then Irovetti's armies should react as makes sense to their actions. There's no way to predict what a PC kingdom looks like, so the following suggestions should be used and adapted as needed to fit your game.

IROVETTI'S FIRST STRIKE — SEVERE 13

The settlement Irovetti chooses to attack depends on where your players have placed their settlements. It's best if he targets a smaller settlement with at least one standing army in the same hex, so that the PCs can actually react to the fight and play out the battle as detailed below.

The PCs should hear about Pitax's attack on their kingdom via a message, perhaps delivered by a

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spellcasting NPC from the settlement via something like *sending* or *dream message*. You can then play out this War encounter in the context of a flashback.

The forces Irovetti sends on this first strike consist of three armies: a warband of mercenaries, a band of mammoth-mounted hill giants, and a flight of wyverns. This force is expected to crush the PCs' resistance, thus impressing on the players the seriousness of the situation, but it also represents the bulk of Irovetti's field forces. The rest of his armies remain behind to fortify his territories (detailed in Wartime Exploration on page 350).

Irovetti's armies are led by Avinash Jurrg, the commander of all of Pitax's forces, and the defenders should witness the onidoshi acting during the battle—perhaps he's using *cone of cold* to blast foes, or he's simply bellowing commands to foreshadow the PCs' eventual confrontation with him later in this chapter—but he does not remain behind once the battle is over. Avinash isn't particularly stealthy in his approach, and any defending armies should be able to march out onto the field to meet him before they reach the settlement. As a result, the assumption is this battlefield is open without unusual terrain, but if you wish to move the War encounter into the settlement, feel free to adjust this as you see fit.

PITAXIAN RAIDERS — ARMY 12

CN SKIRMISHER

Scouting +22

Description The Pitaxian Raiders consist of a mix of Pitax city guards and mercenaries eager for battle.

AC 33; **Maneuver** +25; **Morale** +19

HP 4 (RT 2)

Melee swords +26

Ranged longbows +24 (7 shots)

Pitaxian Training (unique tactic) The Pitaxian Raiders can use the Counterattack, Dirty Fighting, and Feint tactical actions.

TUSKER RIDERS — ARMY 14

CE CALVARY

Scouting +24, darkvision

Description The hill giant warlord Kob Moleg sent these mammoth-mounted hill giants to King Irovetti as a gift.

AC 35; **Maneuver** +22; **Morale** +28

HP 8 (RT 4)

Melee morningstars and tusks +30

Ranged thrown rock +28 (5 shots)

Tusker Training (unique tactic) The Tusker Riders can use the All-Out Assault, Covering Fire, and Taunt tactical actions.

Trampling Charge ❖❖❖ (unique tactic) The Riders trample an enemy army. They attempt a Maneuver check against a target non-engaged army's Maneuver DC. Trampling Charge does not trigger Counterattack reactions.

Critical Success The target army takes 2 points of damage and increases their Shaken value by 1.

Success The target army takes 1 point of damage.

Failure The target army takes 1 point of damage. The Tusker Riders are now engaged with the target army.

Critical Failure The Tusker Riders are now engaged with the target army and are flat-footed until the start of their next turn.

WYVERN FLIGHT — ARMY 12

CE SKIRMISHER

Scouting +23, darkvision

Description This flight of wyverns has been trained to obey orders in battle.

AC 33; **Maneuver** +25; **Morale** +17

HP 4 (RT 3)

Melee fangs, claws, and stingers +18 plus wyvern venom

Flight (unique tactic) The Wyvern Flight ignores all ground-based difficult terrain and cannot become mired by effects that can be escaped by flight. When they use the Disengage action against armies that can't fly, their check result is improved one degree. Armies that lack the ability to fly suffer a –2 circumstance penalty on Advance actions against a Wyvern Flight.

Wyvern Venom (unique tactic) An army that takes damage from a Wyvern Flight's melee strike increases its weary condition value by 1. If this would cause an army to increase its weary condition above 4, it instead takes 1 point of damage. Each time an army regains Hit Points during a battle, it can attempt a DC 11 flat check; on a success, it no longer suffers the ongoing effects of Wyvern Venom (but can still be affected by it later from a future attack, and does not reset its weary condition). The effects of Wyvern Venom also end as soon as an army escapes the battlefield or once the battle ends.

Wyvern Tactics The Wyvern Flight can use the All-Out Assault and Counterattack tactical actions.

Loss: If the PCs' forces lose the battle (or if they simply had no armies stationed near the attacked settlement), then Avinash's remaining forces encamp in the settlement, claiming it and its hex for Pitax. In the coming months, Pitax attempts to expand their territory from this hex if left unchecked; see Kingdom Turns during the War on page 350 for details.

Victory: If Avinash's forces are defeated, he abandons the field and flees back to Pitax to report to King Irovetti, who puts his city on the defensive for the next three months before they manage to rebuild forces enough to field another warband like this one to send into the PCs' kingdom for further attacks.

AID FROM ILORA

Ilora Nuski is a Pitaxian exile who has spent her recent life living on the run in the wild. Her camp is detailed in encounter site **GU3** (page 111). She's eager

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